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Peri Bathous;

or, The Art of Sinking

Descent, Judgment, and the Bathic Covenant in the Cinema of James Cameron

Nov 10, 2026 · @ertertwert

THE DESCENT

This book is a sounding

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ABSTRACT

Abstract

This dissertation advances a unified interpretation of the cinema of James Cameron as a speculative cosmology organized around a single overdetermined operation: descent. Against the critical settlement that divides Cameron into an engineer of unprecedented spectacle and a purveyor of sentimental melodrama—and that treats the second as the embarrassing price of the first—it contends that the charge of *bathos* persistently levelled at his films names, with inadvertent precision, their governing principle. Taking its title from Alexander Pope's *Peri Bathous, or the Art of Sinking in Poetry* (1728), itself a parody of the pseudo-Longinian *Peri Hypsous*, the study demonstrates that Cameron's films sink in three mutually reinforcing registers: diegetically, in recurrent narratives of submersion, crash, drowning, and abyssal passage; rhetorically, in a systematic modulation of the technological and apocalyptic sublime into the domestic, the familial, and the sentimental; and theologically, in a structure of descent that conjoins the Greek *katabasis* (the descent of the living into the realm of the dead) with the Vaiṣṇava *avatāra* and the Pauline *kenōsis* (the self-emptying descent of the divine into flesh).

Reading the directed corpus from *The Terminator* (1984) to *Avatar: Fire and Ash* (2025), and situating it within a penumbra of screenplays, productions, expeditionary documentaries, and announced projects, the dissertation identifies a recurrent narrative form—the *tribunal of the nonhuman*—in which the human species is arraigned before a nonhuman intelligence (Skynet, the xenomorph hive, the non-terrestrial intelligences of the Cayman Trough, the indifferent North Atlantic, Eywa) and provisionally acquitted through acts of recognition and self-sacrifice. It formalizes this pattern as a six-moment *bathic schema*—*hypsos*, *lapsus*, *katabasis*, *krisis*, *kenōsis*, *diathēkē*—and traces its comic, tragic, broken, recursive, and finally inverted variants, culminating in the late reversal through which the nonhuman judge is itself put on trial and anthropodicy yields to theodicy.

Methodologically, the study conjoins film-philosophy (Cavell, Mulhall, Deleuze, Sobchack), Gaston Bachelard's elemental poetics of the material imagination, and a comparative mythopoetics (Doniger, Lévi-Strauss, Lincoln) attentive to difference rather than archetype, while subjecting its object to the decolonial, feminist, and disability-studies critiques the films have rightly attracted. It reconstructs the genealogy of Cameron's ideas through their originators—Empedocles' Love and Strife and Freud's appropriation of them as Eros and the destructive drive; Nietzsche's abyss; Burke's and Kant's sublime; Hesiod's Pandora and Jane Ellen Harrison's chthonic earth-goddess; the *Bhagavad Gītā*'s doctrine of recurrent descent; Günther Anders's "Promethean gap"; Hans Jonas's heuristics of fear; Jean-Pierre Dupuy's enlightened doomsaying; Heidegger's *Gestell*; Stiegler's pharmacology of technics; the Gaia of Lovelock, Margulis, Stengers, and Latour; Hegel, Buber, and Levinas on recognition; Catherine Keller's theology of the deep—and stages sustained comparisons with Harlan Ellison, Philip K. Dick, Poul Anderson, Ursula K. Le Guin, Stanisław Lem, Christa Wolf, Adrienne Rich, Thomas Hardy, Richard Wagner, Hayao Miyazaki, and others across literature, scripture, opera, comics, games, and film.

The dissertation's central claim is that the "Cameron paradox"—the deployment of maximal technology to warn against technology—is not a contradiction but the films' foundational wager: that the apparatus which produces catastrophe is the only apparatus capable of producing the *imagination* of catastrophe at the scale required to forestall it. Cinema, on this account, functions as an Andersian prosthesis for the moral imagination—a *pharmakon* administered to an audience that is itself, through the immersive technologies Cameron has pioneered, seated in the dock. The study concludes that the oeuvre issues not in salvation but in a *bathic covenant*: a secular, revocable, planetary compact between the human and the nonhuman, modelled on the Noahic covenant after the Flood, whose terms are recognition rather than dominion, and whose final test—anticipated by Cameron's announced turn to the atomic bombing of Hiroshima—is a descent into history in which no nonhuman judge will intervene.

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CHAPTER 01

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1

CHAPTER 01

Peri Bathous

The Art of Sinking as Method, Cosmology, and Judgment

The taste of the bathos is implanted by Nature itself in the soul of man.
— Alexander Pope, *Peri Bathous, or the Art of Sinking in Poetry* (1728)

And if thou gaze long into an abyss, the abyss will also gaze into thee.
— Friedrich Nietzsche, *Beyond Good and Evil* (1886), §146, trans. Helen Zimmern; in another English rendering, the opening title card of *The Abyss* (1989)

I come into being, age after age.
— *Bhagavad Gītā* 4.8 (*sambhavāmi yuge yuge*)

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1.1

The Cameron Problem

No filmmaker of the last half-century has joined commercial sovereignty to critical ambivalence in the proportions that attach to James Cameron. He has twice set the all-time worldwide box-office record with original screenplays, with *Titanic* (1997) and *Avatar* (2009), and has directed three of the highest-grossing films ever made; he has presided over, and in several instances engineered, the passages from photochemical to digital compositing, from optical to computer-generated creature work, and from flat to stereoscopic exhibition. Yet his reception has displayed, with a consistency that is itself a datum, a single recurrent structure: the image is conceded and the word is condemned. The liquid-metal morph, the vertical plunge of a forty-six-thousand-ton liner, the bioluminescent night forest of Pandora are entered in the history of the moving image as landmarks; the dialogue that accompanies them is anthologized as kitsch. The settlement acquired something like a primal scene in 1998, when Kenneth Turan's dissent from the near-unanimous reception of *Titanic* in the *Los Angeles Times*, a dissent that conceded the spectacle while indicting the screenplay's clichés, provoked a published letter from the director calling for the critic's removal. The episode is instructive less for its acrimony than for its terms. Neither party disputed the division of the film into a body of incontestable technical achievement and a voice of contestable sentiment; they disagreed only about whether the second disqualified the first.

The term that recurs across this reception, sometimes explicitly and more often as an organizing implication, is *bathos*. In its eighteenth-century sense the word designates a ludicrous descent from the elevated to the commonplace; in its later and looser usage it names a pathos so overwrought that it collapses under the weight of its own sincerity. Cameron's films, on this account, are sublime in their images and bathetic in their speech: they climb by means of their machines to altitudes from which their characters can only fall into cliché. The critique has an impeccable pedigree, and it is not, in any simple sense, mistaken. What this dissertation disputes is not its description but its diagnosis. Cameron's cinema does sink. It sinks with a regularity, a deliberateness, and a density of reference that no

theory of inadvertence can accommodate, and it sinks in more than one register at once. The descent from the sublime into the domestic, from the apocalyptic into the familial, from the planetary into the dyadic, is not the films' failure to sustain their altitude. It is the operation through which they discharge their ethical burden.

The dissertation's title proposes the frame within which this claim becomes legible. In 1728 Alexander Pope and his Scriblerian collaborators published, under the name of Martinus Scriblerus, *Peri Bathous, or the Art of Sinking in Poetry*, a mock treatise that inverted the pseudo-Longinian *Peri Hypsous*, the treatise on elevation that had served, since Boileau's French translation of 1674, as the charter of neoclassical sublimity. Pope's comic premise is that the taste for bathos, which he Englishes as "the Profund," is natural to humankind, and that the taste for the sublime is a perversion imposed by custom and example. The present study takes the joke at its word. It argues that Cameron's oeuvre constitutes the most sustained modern experiment in an art of sinking: a cinema whose native element is the *profund* in the full punning amplitude Pope bequeathed to the term, at once the physical deep and a depth of feeling that critics, measuring with the instruments of the sublime, have mistaken for shallowness.

A single image condenses the argument. On the prow of the *Titanic*, arms outstretched above the North Atlantic, Rose DeWitt Bukater declares that she is flying. The declaration is Longinian, an ecstasy of elevation in which the soul is lifted, in the treatise's own figure, as though it had itself produced what it beholds; and it is uttered on the bow of a vessel whose only destination is the bottom of the sea. The juxtaposition is not irony at the character's expense. It is the film's syntax and, as the chapters that follow demonstrate, the syntax of the oeuvre. In Cameron, *hypsos* and *bathos* are not opposed but sequenced: elevation is the prelude to submersion, and submersion the condition of a transfigured ascent. The same film that sends its heroine flying from the bow ends with her climbing the Grand Staircase of the sunken ship toward an assembly of the drowned, an ascent that takes place, impossibly and precisely, at the bottom of the ocean.

The critical problem has a second axis, which this dissertation treats as the obverse of the first. Cameron is at once the most consequential technophile and the most persistent technophobic moralist in contemporary popular cinema. He co-developed with Vince Pace the Fusion stereoscopic camera system; devised the virtual-camera and Simulcam pipelines through which the performance-captured actors of *Avatar* were composited into digital environments in real time; extended performance capture beneath the surface of a purpose-built tank for *Avatar: The Way of Water* (2022); and co-designed the *Deepsea Challenger*, in

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which he descended alone to the floor of the Challenger Deep on 26 March 2012. In 2024 he joined the board of the generative-image company Stability AI, while continuing to remind interviewers that he had warned the world about artificial intelligence in 1984. The films built with these instruments indict the hubris of instruments: Skynet, the unsinkable ship, the corporate colony, the mining operation that treats a living world as a deposit. For Cameron's detractors this is hypocrisy, an anticapitalist ecology delivered as the most lucrative commodity in cinematic history, a fantasy of going native that Slavoj Žižek (2010) read as ideology in its purest form. For his apologists it is irrelevant, since a filmmaker's tools need not share his themes. This study rejects both positions. The paradox is constitutive. The films stake their authority on a wager that the remainder of this chapter elaborates: that the means of catastrophe are also the only means of its imaginability, and that a sufficiently powerful apparatus of illusion can serve as a prosthesis for a moral imagination that modern technics has outpaced.

The thesis of this dissertation may accordingly be stated in five propositions. First, descent is the master operation of Cameron's cinema, active simultaneously in three registers: the diegetic (narratives of submersion, crash, drowning, and abyssal passage), the rhetorical (the deliberate modulation of the sublime into the sentimental), and the theological (a structure of descent that conjoins the Greek *katabasis*, the Vaiṣṇava *avatāra*, and the Pauline *kenōsis*). Second, these descents compose a *bathic cosmology*, an inversion of the vertical axis of Western metaphysics in which the sacred is located not above but below, in the trench, the wreck, the root, and the reef. Third, the narrative form through which this cosmology is dramatized is a *tribunal of the nonhuman*, in which the human species is arraigned before a nonhuman intelligence and provisionally acquitted through acts of recognition and self-sacrifice; the form can be stated as a six-moment schema whose variations organize the corpus. Fourth, the elemental spectacle for which Cameron is celebrated is governed by an Empedoclean dynamic of Love and Strife, transmitted to modernity through Freud's late drive theory and legible through Gaston Bachelard's poetics of the material imagination. Fifth, the technological apparatus that produces this spectacle functions as a *pharmakon*, at once poison and remedy, through which the spectator is placed in the dock; the oeuvre issues, accordingly, not in salvation but in a revocable covenant between the human and the nonhuman whose terms are recognition rather than dominion.

1.2

Corpus, Penumbra, and Paratext

The primary corpus comprises the nine feature films Cameron directed between 1984 and 2025, on each of which he also holds a writing credit: *The Terminator* (1984), *Aliens* (1986), *The Abyss* (1989; Special Edition 1993), *Terminator 2: Judgment Day* (1991), *True Lies* (1994), *Titanic* (1997), *Avatar* (2009; extended versions 2010), *Avatar: The Way of Water* (2022), and *Avatar: Fire and Ash* (2025). To these are added the two documentaries he directed for large-format exhibition: *Ghosts of the Abyss* (2003), the record of his 2001 expedition to the wreck of the *Titanic*, and *Aliens of the Deep* (2005, co-directed with Steven Quale), a survey of hydrothermal-vent ecosystems framed explicitly as a rehearsal for the search for life on other worlds. Where a film exists in more than one authorized version, as *Aliens*, *The Abyss*, *Terminator 2*, and *Avatar* do, the variants are treated not as textual accidents but as evidence. The restoration in the 1993 Special Edition of *The Abyss* of the tidal-wave sequence cut from the theatrical release, for instance, converts an implicit tribunal into an explicit one, and Chapter 5 reads the two versions as two theologies.

Cameron's credited feature debut, *Piranha II: The Spawning* (1982), occupies an anomalous position. Removed during production by its producer, Ovidio G. Assonitis, Cameron has consistently disowned the result; the film is excluded from the primary corpus but retained as the oeuvre's disowned prologue. Its premise, a species of flying piranha bred by a military weapons program and nesting in a sunken wreck off a Caribbean resort, is the bathic cosmology in debased form: the deep returns the buried hubris of military science to the surface of leisure, and the wreck is already the womb of the monstrous. Something similar holds for *Xenogenesis* (1978), the short co-directed with Randall Frakes that preceded Cameron's apprenticeship at Roger Corman's New World Pictures, whose image of a woman operating a walking machine against a robotic adversary is the germ of Ripley's power loader.

Around the directed corpus lies a penumbra of works in which Cameron's agency is partial but legible. As screenwriter he co-wrote *Rambo: First Blood Part II* (1985) with Sylvester Stallone in the same period as *Aliens*, a conjunction that made him the author, almost simultaneously, of a revanchist fantasy of Vietnam re-fought and an allegory of Vietnam lost. He wrote and produced *Strange Days* (1995), directed by Kathryn Bigelow, whose black-market recordings of other people's sensory experience anticipate the avatar link as a commodity of vicarious em-

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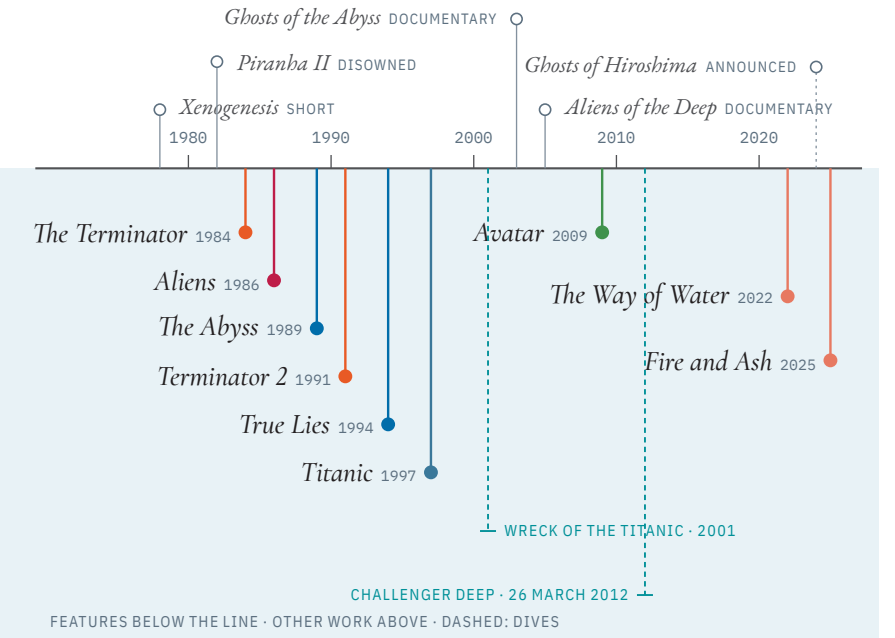


PLATE I *The directed corpus, 1978–2025*

The nine features Cameron directed, hung from a single timeline, with the early short *Xenogenesis*, the disowned prologue of *Piranha II*, the two expeditionary documentaries, and the dives to the wreck of the *Titanic* (2001) and to the Challenger Deep (2012). Colours follow the elemental order of the chapters.

bodiment; co-wrote and produced *Alita: Battle Angel* (2019), directed by Robert Rodriguez, the cyborg-adolescent project he had nursed for two decades; and supplied the story for *Terminator: Dark Fate* (2019), directed by Tim Miller, which restored the franchise to the continuity of his own two films. As producer he sponsored Steven Soderbergh's *Solaris* (2002), an adaptation of Stanisław Lem's novel of an ocean-intelligence that cannot be addressed, which constitutes the most important counter-text to Cameron's own legible oceans (§1.4); and *Sanctum* (2011), a cave-diving survival film that literalizes the katabatic narrative without consolation. As executive producer of *The Lost Tomb of Jesus* (2007), Simcha Jacobovici's much-contested documentary about a Jerusalem ossuary claimed for the family of Jesus, he attached his name, whatever the project's archaeological merits, to an inquiry into the historical body of a messiah, a preoccupation the theological register of §1.3 helps to situate. In television he co-created *Dark Angel* (2000–2002) with Charles H. Eglee and hosted *James Cameron's Story of Science*

Fiction (2018), whose interviews form a substantial body of self-commentary on the genre's intellectual lineage.

Unrealized projects belong to the penumbra as well. The early-1990s scriptment for *Spider-Man* characteristically relocated the hero's web-shooters from manufactured device to organic endowment, transferring technics into the body. Cameron's attachment as producer to Guillermo del Toro's unrealized adaptation of H. P. Lovecraft's *At the Mountains of Madness* bound him, for a time, to the canonical narrative of the deep as cosmic horror, the very cosmology his own films invert. Most consequentially, in 2024 he acquired the rights to Charles Pellegrino's *Ghosts of Hiroshima* (2025), to be combined with Pellegrino's earlier *Last Train from Hiroshima* (2010; revised 2015). Cameron has written a screenplay focused, by his own description, on the day of the two bombings and its immediate aftermath; on his own account in December 2025, however, the project had neither a production slot nor a distributor. Chapter 9 treats it, in its very suspension, as the oeuvre's foretold terminus. The expeditionary record forms a final ring of the penumbra: the 2002 expedition to the *Bismarck*, the 2012 descent to the Challenger Deep and its documentary record, *Deepsea Challenge 3D* (2014), and the long institutional association with National Geographic through which Cameron's dives have been made public.

Beyond the penumbra lie the paratexts in Gérard Genette's sense (*Seuils*, 1987): interviews, commentaries, production documents such as the 1990s scriptment for the project then designated *Project 880* that became *Avatar*, the drawings and paintings exhibited at the Cinémathèque française in 2024 and gathered in *Tech Noir: The Art of James Cameron*, and the activist interventions, such as his 2010 campaign alongside Indigenous communities against the Belo Monte dam on the Xingu River, through which the films' ecological claims were carried back into the world they allegorize. These materials corroborate; they do not adjudicate. The name "Cameron" designates throughout an author-function in Michel Foucault's sense (1969), a principle of grouping, coherence, and attribution rather than a sovereign consciousness whose intentions settle meaning. The films are industrial artefacts produced by large and continuous collaborations: with Gale Anne Hurd, co-writer and producer of *The Terminator* and producer of *Aliens* and *The Abyss*; William Wisher, co-writer of *Terminator 2*; Stan Winston, whose studio built the endoskeleton and the Alien Queen; Dennis Muren and Industrial Light & Magic, who realized the liquid forms of *The Abyss* and *Terminator 2*; Jon Landau, producer from *Titanic* through the *Avatar* sequels until his death in 2024; James Horner, Russell Carpenter, Mauro Fiore, Joe Letteri and Wētā FX; and Rick Jaffa and Amanda Silver, co-writers of the second and third

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Avatar films. The coherence this dissertation attributes to the corpus is a hypothesis about those artefacts, tested against them, not a claim about anyone's interior.

The same caution governs the study's genealogical claims, which are graded throughout into three orders. The first order comprises *documented derivations*: the settlement that added an acknowledgement of Harlan Ellison's work to *The Terminator*; the Nietzschean epigraph of *The Abyss*; Rose's invocation of "Dr. Freud" in *Titanic*; the android Bishop's recitation of a law of robotics that Isaac Asimov's readers will recognize; the naming of the hero of *The Abyss* Virgil Brigman, after the poet of the *Aeneid*'s descent and Dante's guide through the Inferno; the naming of the whaling captain of *The Way of Water* Scoresby, after the Arctic whaler-scientist whom Herman Melville repeatedly cites in *Moby-Dick*; the borrowing of *avatāra* and *amṛta* from Sanskrit; and Cameron's acknowledgement of a conceptual link between the Na'vi's blue skin and Hindu iconography. The second order comprises *acknowledged or widely remarked influences* within what Damien Broderick (1995) calls the science-fiction megatext: Edgar Rice Burroughs's Barsoom, Poul Anderson's "Call Me Joe" (1957), Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972), Arthur C. Clarke's *2001* and *Childhood's End*. The third order comprises *interpretive constellations*, comparisons such as Empedocles, Hölderlin, Wagner, and the *Völuspá*, which claim no causal relation to Cameron's work but illuminate structures that it shares with them. To confuse these orders is the characteristic vice of mythographic criticism; to refuse the third altogether is to forfeit the comparative intelligence without which the first two remain mere source-hunting.

1.3

Three Registers of Descent

THE CLAIM THAT DESCENT is Cameron's master operation would be trivial if it meant only that his films contain many falls; adventure cinema is made of them. The claim is rather that descent operates in three registers simultaneously, each glossing the others, so that a plunge in the diegesis is also a modulation of tone and an enactment of a theological figure. The registers are distinguished here for analysis. The films' power lies in their refusal to keep them apart.

THE DIEGETIC REGISTER. *The Terminator* begins with an arrival that is also a descent: the machine materializes in a sphere of electrical discharge above

Los Angeles, naked and crouched in the posture of a newborn, a body dropped from the future into the past. It ends in an automated factory, where its flayed endoskeleton, the image of a chrome skeleton dragging itself from fire that Cameron has traced to a fever dream in Rome during the misadventure of *Piranha II*, is crushed in a hydraulic press. *Aliens* opens with a drift, Ripley's escape craft recovered after fifty-seven years of hypersleep, and descends by way of a dropship crash and an elevator shaft into the sub-levels of a terraforming reactor where the hive has made its nest. *The Abyss* begins with the sinking of a ballistic-missile submarine at the edge of the Cayman Trough and ends only after its hero, breathing oxygenated liquid, has passed beyond the reach of light into a trench the film treats as the edge of the world. *Terminator 2* resolves in a steel mill, where one machine dissolves in molten metal and the other is lowered into it. *True Lies* stages its climactic rescue over a bridge whose span has been destroyed, the limousine carrying Helen Tasker plunging into the sea moments after her husband plucks her from it. *Titanic* is organized around the most famous vertical descent in modern memory, doubled by its frame narrative's submersibles and the remotely operated vehicle that threads the wreck's corridors. *Avatar* converts the plunge into a daily ritual, Jake Sully's descent into the coffin-like link unit in which his paralysed body is left behind; its decisive action is a leap downward onto the back of Toruk from the one quarter the great predator never watches. *The Way of Water* moves its family from the forest canopy to the reef and ends with them trapped in the flooding corridors of a capsizing vessel, an unmistakable restaging of the *Titanic*'s last hour. *Fire and Ash* brings Spider to the edge of death by asphyxiation, from which Kiri, joining her queue to the fungal network in the soil, returns him able to breathe the air of Pandora. The series culminates outside fiction altogether, in the descent of the *Deepsea Challenger* to the floor of the Mariana Trench, where the auteur's own body becomes the last term in the sequence.

THE RHETORICAL REGISTER. The descents of the diegesis are matched by descents of tone, and it is here that the charge of bathos finds its purchase. At the moment of maximal spectacle, Cameron's films characteristically collapse into the smallest available unit of domestic speech. At the bottom of the trench, having disarmed a nuclear warhead and with his oxygen nearly spent, Virgil Brigman types to his estranged wife a message that ends, in telegraphic indifference to grammar, "love you wife." The T-800, about to be lowered into the steel, explains that it now knows why humans cry. Ripley's challenge to the Alien Queen, the most celebrated line in the film, is a schoolyard insult issued in defence of a child. In the freezing water Jack Dawson extracts from Rose a promise that she will survive. *Avatar*'s metaphysics of recognition is compressed into a three-word

951 m
MESOPELAGIC

greeting; *The Way of Water*'s ethics into a father's declaration that a father protects. *True Lies*, the corpus's comedy, carries the operation to the edge of parody: Harry and Helen Tasker kiss as a nuclear detonation blooms behind them, the apocalyptic sublime of the Cold War reduced to the backdrop of a marital reconciliation.

These lines are the films' least sophisticated utterances and their most load-bearing. This study reads them as the rhetorical form of a deliberate change of scale, which it terms *affective downscaling*: the translation of magnitudes that exceed human imagination (nuclear war, abyssal pressure, the deaths of some fifteen hundred people in the North Atlantic, planetary ecocide) into the one magnitude the human sensorium can hold without numbing, the dyad. The necessity of such translation has been established from two directions. Philosophically, Günther Anders argued in *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) that modern humanity suffers a "Promethean gap" (*prometheisches Gefälle*): we can produce more than we can imagine, and imagine more than we can feel, so that our feelings, unlike our machines, do not scale. Empirically, the psychology of the identifiable victim, from Thomas Schelling's distinction between statistical and identified lives (1968) to Paul Slovic's studies of "psychic numbing" (2007), has shown that compassion does not rise with the number of victims and frequently declines. Cameron's bathos is, among other things, an applied psychology of the identifiable victim. Its sentimentality is not a failure to rise to the scale of catastrophe but a technique for bringing catastrophe down to the scale at which it can be felt, and the films stage the technique openly: *Titanic* sets the fifteen hundred in the water against the one woman who blows a whistle; *Terminator 2* sets the incinerated children of Los Angeles against a single mother clutching a playground fence; *The Abyss* sets the archive of human war against one man's message to his wife.

THE THEOLOGICAL REGISTER. The third register gives the first two their gravity. The Greek *katabasis*, the descent of the living into the realm of the dead, is a journey undertaken to retrieve a person or a knowledge the upper world cannot supply: Odysseus's *nekyia* in the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*, Orpheus's descent for Eurydice, Aeneas's in the sixth book of the *Aeneid*, and behind them the Sumerian Inanna, stripped at seven gates and hung as a corpse upon a hook before her restoration. Christianity absorbed the figure in the *descensus ad inferos* glimpsed in 1 Peter 3:19 and fixed in the creeds, and Dante made it the architecture of the *Commedia*, whose guide through the underworld is the author of *Aeneid* VI. Cameron's naming of the hero of *The Abyss* after that guide is therefore not ornamental. Bud Brigman's descent is a katabasis in the strict sense: undertaken

alone, past the possibility of return, to avert a death and to encounter what lives below, and rewarded by an unlooked-for return in which the world beneath rises bodily to the surface.

The katabatic vector carries the human down into the nonhuman. Its countervector carries the nonhuman down into flesh. The Sanskrit *avatāra* derives from *ava-√tṝ*, "to cross down," and designates the descent of a deity, paradigmatically Viṣṇu, into bodily form; its classical statement is Kṛṣṇa's in the *Bhagavad Gītā* (4.7–8), where the god declares that whenever righteousness declines he brings himself forth, for the protection of the good and the destruction of the wicked, coming into being age after age. Christianity's equivalent is *kenōsis*, from the hymn of Philippians 2:6–8 in which Christ, being in the form of God, "emptied himself" (*heauton ekenōsen*), taking the form of a slave and becoming obedient unto death. Simone Weil radicalized the figure into a spirituality of "decreation" (*La Pesanteur et la grâce*, 1947), in which the self consents to its own unmaking so that something other than force may act through it. The word *avatar* entered computing in the 1980s, when Lucasfilm's online world *Habitat* (1986) adopted it for the user's graphical body and Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash* (1992) gave it general currency, so that by 2009 Cameron's title could fuse the theological and the cybernetic: the descent of a god into flesh and the projection of a user into a simulated body. Jake Sully stands at their intersection, a human who descends into a body grown to be inhabited and who, at the film's close, does not come back.

Every film in the corpus combines the two vectors. In *The Terminator* the machine descends into flesh, living tissue grown over a metal endoskeleton, while Kyle Reese descends from the future into the past to father the leader of a war that has not yet happened; the film's Annunciation structure, in which an emissary from elsewhere informs a young woman that she will bear the saviour of humankind, is so marked that the son's initials, J.C., merely confirm it. In *Aliens* the alien descends into human bodies in a monstrous parody of incarnation while Ripley descends into the hive. In *The Abyss* the nonhuman rises to meet the human halfway, its water-tentacle offering a mimicry of human faces. In *Terminator 2* the machine undergoes a kenosis consummated by its immersion in fire. In *Avatar* the human descends into Na'vi flesh while Eywa descends from impassive balance into partisan action. *The Way of Water* and *Fire and Ash* add a third figure, the child of uncertain incarnation: Kiri, born without known father of the avatar body of the dead Grace Augustine and played by the actress who was Ripley, and Spider, the human boy whose body Eywa rewrites so that he may breathe the air of the world that adopted him.

1,051 m
BATHYPELAGIC

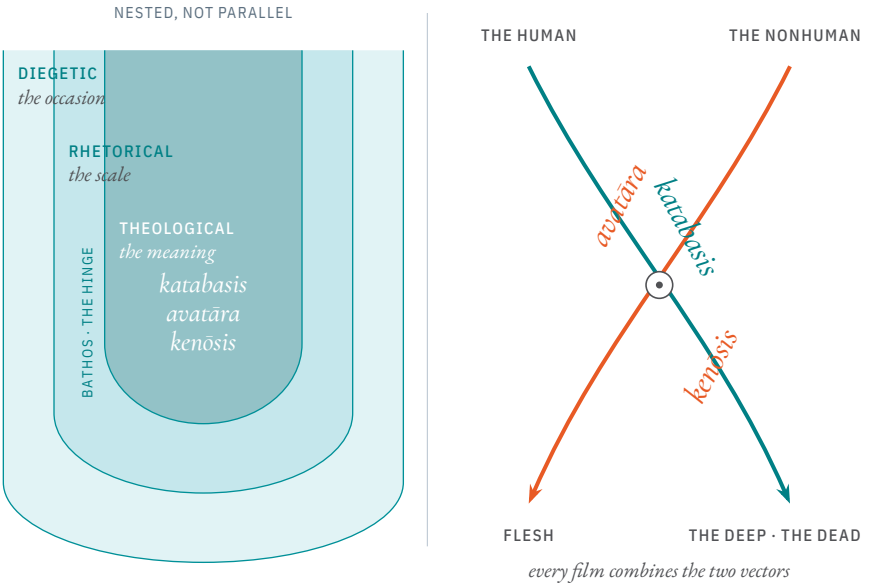


PLATE II *Three registers, two vectors*

Left: the registers of descent are nested rather than parallel; the diegetic supplies the occasion, the rhetorical the scale, and the theological the meaning, with bathos as the hinge between the second and the third. Right: the katabatic vector carries the human down into the nonhuman, and its counter-vector, *avatāra* and *kenōsis*, carries the nonhuman down into flesh. Every film in the corpus combines the two (§1.3).

The three registers are therefore nested rather than parallel. The diegetic descent supplies the occasion, the rhetorical descent the scale, and the theological descent the meaning; and the bathos the critics deplore is the hinge between the second and the third, the moment at which an unbounded magnitude is emptied into a finite and familiar form. That is exactly what *kenōsis* and *avatāra* describe. Erich Auerbach showed in *Mimesis* (1946) and in his essay on *sermo humilis* that the Gospel narratives scandalized classical decorum by recounting the most sublime of subjects, the incarnation and death of God, in the lowest of styles, among fishermen and servant-girls; the Christian mingling of styles (*Stilmischung*) was, from the standpoint of Longinian taste, bathos raised to a principle. Cameron's sentimentality is incarnational in this precise structural sense. It lowers the infinite into the domestic not because it cannot sustain the sublime but because, on the theology implicit in the films, the domestic is where the infinite consents to be met.

1.4

Paradise at the Bottom:
Toward a Bathic Cosmology

1,101 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Western metaphysics and theology have located value above with remarkable constancy. Plato's prisoner ascends from the cave toward the sun (*Republic* 514a–517a); Plotinus's soul returns by ascent to the One from which it emanated; Dante climbs from the frozen pit of Cocytus through the mountain of Purgatory to the Empyrean; and the Christian heaven is, in the overwhelming majority of its iconography, a height. The deep, conversely, has been coded as chaos. The second verse of Genesis places darkness "upon the face of the deep," the Hebrew *tehom*, cognate with the Babylonian Tiamat whom Marduk splits like a shellfish to make heaven and earth in the *Enuma Elish*; Psalm 74 praises the God who broke the heads of Leviathan in the waters; and the Apocalypse of John, describing the new creation, records as a condition of its perfection that "there was no more sea" (Revelation 21:1). Catherine Keller's *Face of the Deep* (2003) names this tradition *tehomophobia*, a theological dread of the formless depth that the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo* was elaborated partly to master, and proposes in its place a "tehomic" theology of becoming in which the deep is not the adversary of creation but its matrix.

Cameron's cinema is tehomophilic. The sacred in his films dwells at the bottom: in the luminous city of the non-terrestrial intelligences on the floor of the trench in *The Abyss*; in the Grand Staircase of the wreck, restored to its 1912 splendour, where the dead of the *Titanic* wait to receive Rose; in the root-network of Eywa, reached through the trailing, willow-like tendrils of the Tree of Souls; in the Spirit Tree of the Metkayina, rooted on the floor of a bay and approached only by diving; in the tulkun, whose memory and song are carried through the deep water. Even Pandora's sublime heights depend on what lies beneath. The floating Hallelujah Mountains are suspended, in the film's pseudo-physics, by the magnetic properties of the very mineral the colonists have come to mine, so that the height is literally upheld by the deep, and the extractive project that would empty the ground would also, by the same logic, bring the sky down.

The cosmology acquires definition against its alternatives. For a tradition running from H. P. Lovecraft's "Dagon" (1919) and "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) through the deep-sea horror of the late twentieth century, the bottom of the world is where an anti-human cosmos waits, indifferent or hostile, and descent

1, 151 m
BATHYPELAGIC

means contamination, as the hybrid families of Lovecraft's Innsmouth attest. Cameron's own attachment to del Toro's Lovecraft project notwithstanding, his films invert this cosmology point for point: the abyss contains angels rather than Old Ones; the hybrid body (the avatar, the recombinant, Spider's rewritten lungs) is a promise at least as often as a threat; and the encounter at the bottom issues in recognition rather than madness. *The Abyss* is in this sense an anti-Lovecraftian film, and the significance of its being so lies in what it refuses, namely the conviction, foundational to cosmic horror, that the nonhuman cannot be addressed.

That refusal marks the limit as well as the promise of the bathic cosmology. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) imagines a planetary ocean whose intelligence is real but irreducibly alien: it answers the scientists' probes by materializing figures from their memories, but whether this is communication, experiment, gift, or indifference remains undecidable, and the novel's argument is precisely that the human hunger for contact is a hunger for a mirror. Cameron produced Steven Soderbergh's adaptation, which shifted the weight of Lem's epistemological novel onto its love story, a characteristically Cameronian bathos realized in another director's hands. His own oceans always talk back. The non-terrestrial intelligences speak through video monitors and water-shaped faces; Eywa answers prayer; the tulkun converse with the Metkayina in a language of sign and song; and in every case the intelligences of the deep share the values of the films' protagonists: family, fidelity, the prohibition of killing. This legibility is the cosmology's ethical promise, since it holds open the possibility that the nonhuman may be addressed and may reply. It is also its ideological limit, since an ocean that answers in the idiom of the nuclear family has been turned, in Lem's sense, into a mirror. The dissertation returns repeatedly to this double edge.

Between Lovecraft and Lem stand the precursors who furnished Cameron's oceanic imagination with its specific features. Herman Melville's sea is inscrutable: the whiteness of the whale, in the forty-second chapter of *Moby-Dick* (1851), terrifies precisely because it signifies a blankness that cannot be read. *The Way of Water*, which names its whaler after a man Melville repeatedly cites, rewrites the inscrutable whale as a person with a name, a family, and a grievance. Jules Verne's Captain Nemo makes the deep a refuge from empire; his motto *mobilis in mobili* and his posthumous revelation in *L'Île mystérieuse* (1874–75) as the Indian prince Dakkar, a rebel against British rule, anticipate the alliance of technical genius with anticolonial resistance that *Avatar* would romanticize. And William Beebe's *Half Mile Down* (1934), the account of his bathysphere dives with Otis Barton off Bermuda, supplied the twentieth century with its first

eyewitness lyric of abyssal bioluminescence, a register of ecstatic description that passes almost unaltered into the night forests and reefs of Pandora.

Underlying this oceanic imagination is an affect that Freud, prompted by Romain Rolland, placed at the threshold of *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930): the "oceanic feeling," a sensation of eternity and of an indissoluble bond with the world as a whole, which Rolland took to be the true source of religious energy and which Freud traced instead to the undifferentiated ego of infancy, before the self had learned to set itself apart from its surroundings. The neural bond of *tsaheylu*, the communion with the non-terrestrial intelligences, and Rose's final reunion with the drowned are oceanic in exactly this sense, and the dissertation keeps both readings in view: the oceanic as intuition of a real connectedness, and the oceanic as regressive fantasy of a self without boundaries. That Freud's book opens with the oceanic and closes with the struggle between Eros and destruction (§1.6) is a coincidence of structure on which much of the present argument depends.

1,201 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The bathic cosmology may be summarized in four propositions, each of which the corpus both affirms and tests. First, the deep is sacred: value, judgment, and the dead reside below. Second, the heights belong to power: the command deck, the first-class promenade, the orbiting starship, the gunship, the boardroom. Third, descent is the path of redemption: the protagonist must go down in order to be saved and in order to save. Fourth, the bottom answers: the deep responds when it is addressed. *Aliens* strains the first proposition, since what waits below is a hive whose sacredness is only that of a rival maternity; *Titanic* suspends the fourth, since the sea it addresses is mute and the only answer comes from the dead. And *Fire and Ash* sets the fourth on trial outright. Its Ash People addressed the deep in their catastrophe, received no answer, and concluded that the goddess who answered others has no dominion over them.

1.5

The Tribunal of the Nonhuman and the Bathic Schema

Descent in Cameron is never merely exploration; it is arraignment. The figure who goes down meets, at the bottom, an intelligence that is not human and that sits, explicitly or implicitly, in judgment on the species. The form recurs so consistently, and with such instructive variation, that it warrants a name: the *tribunal of the nonhuman*.

1,251 m
BATHYPELAGIC

In *The Terminator* the judge has already ruled. Kyle Reese's account of the future war describes a defence network that, on attaining self-awareness, perceived all humans as a threat and "decided our fate in a microsecond." The sequel's subtitle names the day of execution; the franchise as a whole is an appeal against a sentence pronounced before any trial could be held. In the Special Edition of *The Abyss* the tribunal is explicit to the point of didacticism: the non-terrestrial intelligences show Bud an archive of human war assembled from the planet's own broadcast television, raise walls of water over the world's coastlines, and hold them suspended; the sentence is commuted because of what the judges have read in one man's message to his wife. In *Titanic* the judge is impersonal, the iceberg and the sea, what Thomas Hardy's "The Convergence of the Twain" (1912) calls the "Immanent Will" that prepared for the ship a "sinister mate," a "Shape of Ice." Judgment there takes the form of revelation in the root sense of *apokalypsis*, an unveiling: the sinking exposes the social order the ship carried, the gates that held steerage below, the arithmetic of the lifeboats; and the final scene supplies a second, merciful judgment, in which the drowned of every class assemble on the Grand Staircase to receive the woman who survived.

Aliens stages the tribunal broken. In the egg chamber Ripley, flamethrower levelled, faces the Queen; the Queen, grasping the threat, signals her warriors to withdraw; a truce between two mothers is struck in silence, and then, as an egg begins to open, Ripley burns the chamber anyway. Here the human, not the nonhuman, violates the *krisis*, and the Queen's ensuing pursuit is less monstrous appetite than vengeance. The film's admiration for Ripley's maternal ferocity is inseparable from its record of a broken compact, and this ambivalence will prove diagnostic of the corpus. In *Avatar* the tribunal is convened by petition. Jake addresses Eywa at the Tree of Souls, testifying that the humans have killed their own mother world; Neytiri tells him that the Great Mother does not take sides but protects only the balance of life; and then Eywa does take sides, mobilizing the fauna of Pandora against the assault of the Resources Development Administration. Sentence is passed on the colonists, the "aliens," as Jake's closing narration calls them, who are sent back to their dying world while a chosen few remain. In *The Way of Water* the tulkun constitute a moral community with its own law, the prohibition of killing, and its own penal practice: Payakan is an outcast because he killed, and the film's ethics unfolds as a negotiation between tulkun pacifism and Na'vi war. In *Fire and Ash* the direction of judgment reverses. The Ash People, whose homeland was destroyed by volcanic catastrophe while Eywa remained silent, have tried their goddess in absentia and found her wanting; their leader Varang's declaration that Eywa has "no dominion here" is a verdict, and the

film's resolution, in which Eywa at last answers through Kiri, is less an acquittal of the goddess than a reopening of the case.

Theodicy, in the sense Leibniz gave the word in 1710, is the justification of God before the fact of evil. The tribunal of the nonhuman reverses the direction of inquiry: it asks whether humanity can be justified before a nonhuman judge, given the record of its violence. This study calls the reversed inquiry *anthropodicy*, a term with a scattered prior history that is used here in a precise sense: the justification of the human species before a nonhuman tribunal on grounds other than its aggregate record. The juridical logic is constant across the corpus: the aggregate condemns, and the exemplar acquits. The archive of war the intelligences display in *The Abyss* is unanswerable on its own terms; what answers it is a singular act. The logic is ancient. In Genesis 18:23–33 Abraham bargains with God over Sodom, securing the promise that the city will be spared for the sake of fifty righteous, then forty-five, and so down to ten. Rabbinic tradition (b. Sanhedrin 97b; b. Sukkah 45b) holds that the world endures in every generation for the sake of thirty-six hidden righteous, the *lamed-vav tzaddikim*, whom André Schwarz-Bart made the subject of *Le Dernier des Justes* (1959). Bud Brigman is a Cameronian *lamed-vavnik*: anonymous, blue-collar, unaware of his representative status, and the reason the waves fall back. Where Kafka's *Der Process* (1925) imagines a tribunal that never reaches a verdict, Cameron's tribunals always reach one; but the verdict is a stay rather than an acquittal, and its conditions are recognition and sacrifice rather than innocence.

1,301 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The Greek *krisis* meant judgment and decision before it meant emergency; the word survives both in *crisis* and in *criticism*, a double inheritance that Reinhart Koselleck's *Kritik und Krise* (1959) made central to the conceptual history of modernity. Cameron's crises are *krises* in the original sense, moments at which a judgment is rendered and a decision taken by a judge who is not one of us. Around this nadir the corpus organizes a recurrent sequence of six moments, which this study terms the *bathic schema*. The first is *hypsos*, elevation: the apex of technical power or confidence, the unsinkable ship, the activation of Skynet, the arrival of the Colonial Marines, the corporate fortress the RDA calls Hell's Gate. The second is *lapsus*, the fall: the accident that power itself invents, in Paul Virilio's sense that to invent the ship is to invent the shipwreck, whether iceberg, nuclear exchange, silenced colony, or dying Earth. The third is *katabasis*: the protagonist's passage into the deep or into the nonhuman, Bud's dive, Ripley's descent into the hive, Jake's link, Rose's descent into memory. The fourth is *krisis*: the confrontation with the nonhuman judge. The fifth is *kenōsis*: the sacrifice or self-surrender offered as testimony on the species' behalf, Kyle Reese's death,

1,351 m
BATHYPELAGIC

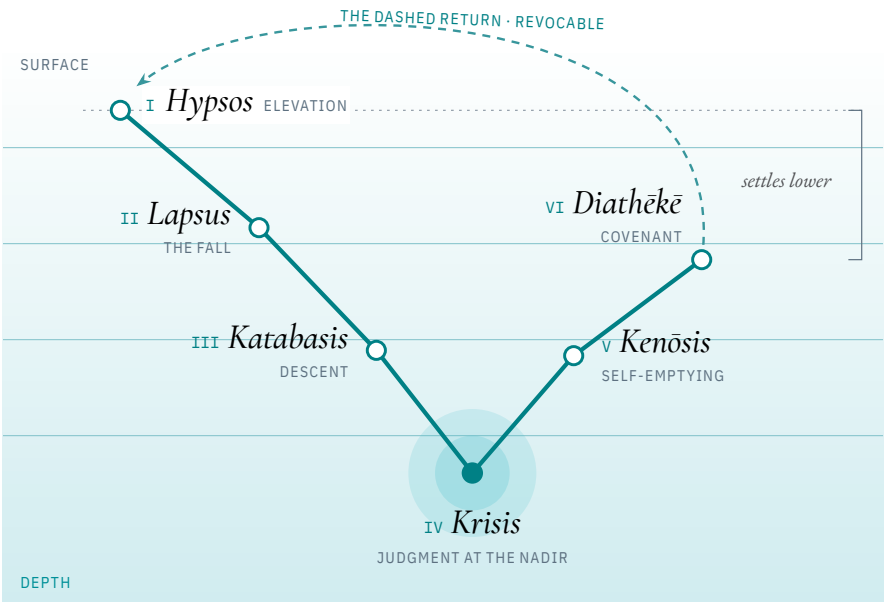
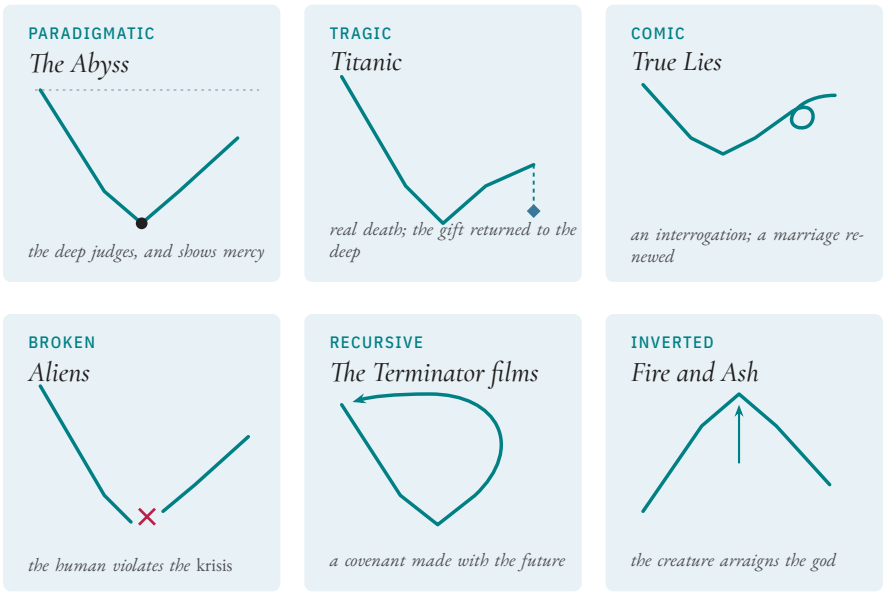


FIGURE 1.1 The bathic schema. The descent runs from elevation to judgment at the nadir; the covenant on the ascending arm settles below the height it replaces, and the dashed return marks its revocability.

Bud's one-way descent, the T-800's immersion, Jack's death in the water, Jake's renunciation of his human body. The sixth is *diathēkē*, the word by which the Septuagint rendered the Hebrew *berit*, the covenant God makes with Noah after the Flood (Genesis 9:8–17), and from which the Christian "testament" descends: the provisional settlement, the withdrawn wave, the unwritten future, the long life Rose goes on to live, the liberation of Pandora, the dream Ripley and Newt are at last permitted to share.

The schema is V-shaped, and its geometry carries an argument. Its nadir is the *krisis*: judgment is reached only at the bottom of the descent. The ascent that follows never regains the height from which the descent began, because the covenant is lower, humbler, and more provisional than the hubris it replaces; and it is revocable. The franchise structure that has dominated Cameron's career since 1991 consists, on this reading, in the periodic reopening of a case the previous film had closed.

The schema is a grammar rather than a formula, and its variants are as instructive as its instances. In *Titanic* it is tragic: the kenosis is real death, and the covenant takes the form of memory and of a gift returned to the deep. In *True*



1,401 m
BATHYPELAGIC

PLATE III *The schema as a grammar*

Six keys of the bathic schema: paradigmatic in *The Abyss*, tragic in *Titanic*, comic in *True Lies*, broken in *Aliens*, recursive in the *Terminator* films, and inverted in *Fire and Ash* (§1.5, §9.1).

Lies it is comic: the tribunal becomes a husband's interrogation of his wife from behind one-way glass, the kenosis a coerced striptease, the covenant a marriage renewed, a parody that exposes, as parody does, the schema's investment in sexual hierarchy. In *Aliens* it is broken: the human violates the *krisis*, and the covenant is struck not with the nonhuman but against it, between a woman and an adopted child. In the *Terminator* films it is recursive: the covenant is made with the future itself, and its content is the proposition that the future is unwritten. In *Fire and Ash* it is inverted: the creature arraigns the god, anthropodicy yields to theodicy, and the fourth proposition of the bathic cosmology, that the bottom answers, is turned against the cosmology that produced it.

1.6

Love and Strife:
The Empedoclean Matrix and the Material Imagination

1,451 m
BATHYPELAGIC

If the bathic schema describes the narrative grammar of Cameron's cinema, a far older cosmology describes the forces that drive it. Empedocles of Acragas, writing in the fifth century BCE, taught that all things are compounded of four "roots" (*rhizōmata*), fire, air, earth, and water, which he named with the names of gods (DK 31 B6), and that these are combined and separated by two cosmic powers, Love (*Philotēs*) and Strife (*Neikos*), in endless alternation (B17). Under Love the roots are drawn together until they compose the Sphere (*Sphairos*), a perfect and undivided unity; under Strife they are torn apart into hostile masses; and the world we inhabit is an intermediate phase in which both forces contend. Empedocles' "double tale," as he called it, is the first systematic cosmology of attraction and repulsion in the West, and it survives into modernity in two forms that bear directly on the present argument.

The first is Freud's. In "Analysis Terminable and Interminable" (1937) Freud acknowledged that his late dualism of drives, Eros and the destructive or death drive, had been anticipated by Empedocles, whose Love and Strife he identified, in name and function, with his own two primal forces, distinguishing his theory only by its claim to biological rather than cosmic validity. Seven years earlier, *Civilization and Its Discontents* had closed with a passage that could stand as the epigraph to Cameron's entire oeuvre. Humanity, Freud wrote, has gained such control over the forces of nature that it could now exterminate itself to the last individual, and it remains to be seen whether eternal Eros will assert itself against its equally immortal adversary; in 1931, as National Socialism rose, he appended a final sentence asking who could foresee with what success. *The Terminator*, *Terminator 2*, *The Abyss*, and *True Lies* are, in their different keys, dramatizations of Freud's last paragraph: the power of self-extermination made concrete as a nuclear arsenal, and Eros made concrete as the couple, the family, and the child.

The second survival is Gaston Bachelard's. In *La Psychanalyse du feu* (1938) Bachelard named an "Empedocles complex," the reverie in which the love of fire and the wish to perish in it are fused, so that the instinct for living and the instinct for dying find a single image; in the same book he named a "Prometheus complex," the will to know as much as our fathers and more. In *L'Eau et les rêves* (1942) he identified the "Charon complex," the persistent dream of the boat of

the dead, and the "Ophelia complex," the image of the drowned woman borne by water; *L'Air et les songes* (1943) developed an ascensional psychology of flight; and the two volumes on earth (1948) explored the reveries of will and of repose, the cave, the house, and the root. Bachelard's psychoanalysis of the material imagination, organized element by element, supplies this study with one of its methods. The claim is not that Cameron illustrates Bachelard but that Bachelard's complexes name, with uncanny exactness, the images around which Cameron's films crystallize. The T-800 lowered into molten steel is the Empedocles complex: a machine that has learned what love is surrenders itself to fire and consummates its existence in its dissolution. The *Titanic*, whose last voyage the film's coda restages as a reception of the dead, is the Charon complex on the scale of an industrial civilization. Lindsey Brigman, drowned and borne back to life on the deck of the rig, is Ophelia resurrected. Jake astride his ikran is the ascensional dream; Eywa's roots are the reverie of repose.

The Empedoclean legend deepens the first of these readings. According to the anecdote preserved by Diogenes Laertius (VIII.69), Empedocles ended his life by leaping into the crater of Etna, his fate betrayed only by a bronze sandal the volcano cast back up. Hölderlin made the leap the subject of his unfinished tragedy *Der Tod des Empedokles* (1797–1800), in which the philosopher's death is an act of reunion with the nature from which consciousness has estranged him, and Matthew Arnold made it the subject of a dramatic poem, *Empedocles on Etna* (1852), that he afterwards withdrew. That the T-800 cannot terminate itself, and must be lowered into the steel by Sarah Connor, gives the Empedoclean leap a distinctively Cameronian inflection: the self-emptying of the machine requires the consent and the hands of the human it has saved. *Kenōsis* in Cameron is never solitary.

Read through Empedocles and Bachelard, the corpus discloses an elemental order. Fire belongs to the *Terminator* films: the tanker explosion from which the endoskeleton rises, the nuclear fire of Sarah's dream, the crucible of the steel mill. Water belongs to *The Abyss*, *Titanic*, *The Way of Water*, and the expeditionary documentaries. Earth, in its living form as forest, soil, and root, belongs to *Avatar*. Air is the most dispersed element and the most revealing. It is what the atmosphere processor of *Aliens* is built to manufacture, and the machine's thermonuclear destruction ends the film; it is what Pandora denies the colonists, who must wear exopacks to survive its atmosphere, so that the colonizer becomes the one who cannot breathe; and it is what *Fire and Ash* gives back to Spider when Eywa rewrites his lungs, an event the film's human antagonists immediately perceive as a possible key to colonization without masks. The succession of

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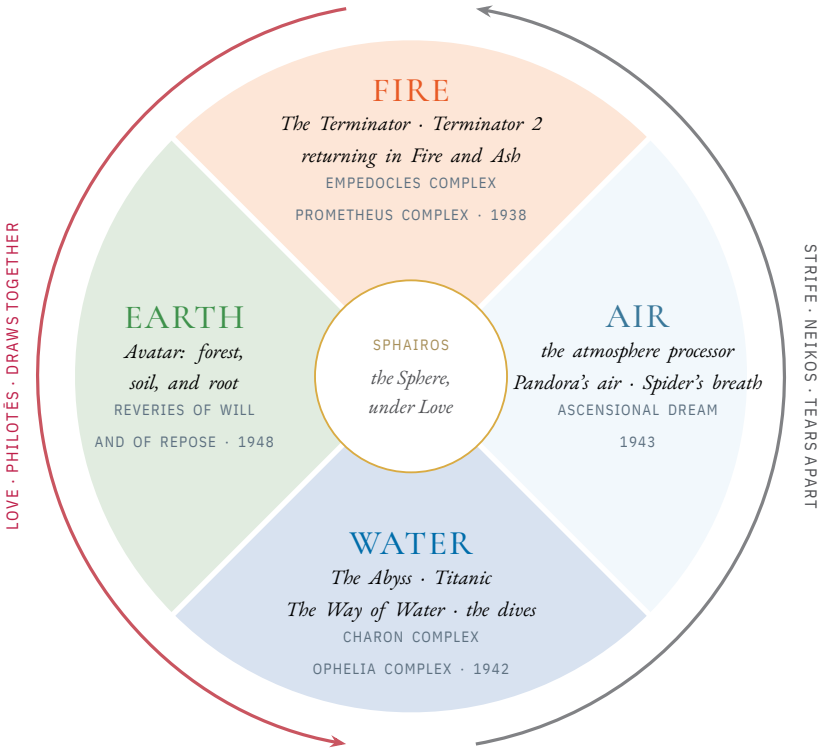


PLATE IV *The Empedoclean matrix*

The four roots distributed across the corpus, with the complexes of Bachelard's material imagination, turning under the alternation of Love (*Philotēs*) and Strife (*Neikos*). Under Love the roots compose the Sphere; under Strife they are torn apart (§1.6).

the *Avatar* titles, the forest of the first film, the water of the second, the fire and ash of the third, makes the elemental program overt, and the Empedoclean question the cycle poses is which force, Love or Strife, presides over each element in turn.

Empedocles' cosmic cycle also offers a model for the peculiar seriality of Cameron's franchises. *The Terminator* is a film of Strife whose single act of Love, the night in which John Connor is conceived, is sealed inside a closed loop. *Terminator 2* is a film in which Love gains ascendancy: the machine learns to protect rather than kill, and the future is opened by an inscription carved into a picnic table, *no fate*. *Avatar* ends in something close to the Sphere, with the network of

Eywa unified, the colonists expelled, and the hero's consciousness absorbed into the planetary whole. *The Way of Water* readmits Strife through the death of a son, and *Fire and Ash* lodges Strife within the Na'vi themselves, among a people who have repudiated the unifying goddess and made fire their principle. The cycle cannot end because, in Empedocles, every victory of Love prepares the conditions of Strife's return. The franchise, on this account, is not merely a commercial form but a cosmological one.

1.7

The Pharmakon of Spectacle:
Technics, the Promethean Gap, and the Cameron Paradox

In the myth Socrates recounts in the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), the Egyptian god Theuth presents the invention of writing to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom; the king replies that it will produce forgetfulness instead, and only the semblance of wisdom. Jacques Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) showed that the word *pharmakon*, which means at once remedy, poison, and dye, cannot be stabilized in either sense, and that its undecidability is not a defect of Plato's text but the structure of the supplement itself. Bernard Stiegler generalized the insight into a pharmacology of technics. Every technical prosthesis, from the flint blade to the digital network, is at once what makes care possible and what itself requires care, so that no technics can be simply affirmed or simply refused.

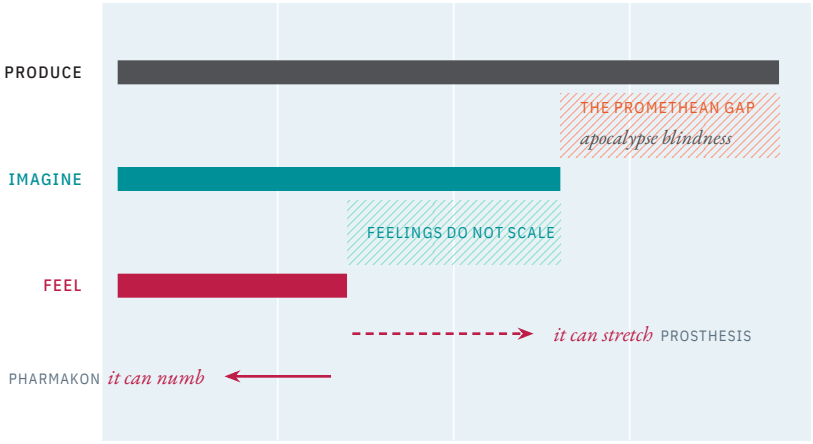
Stiegler's founding work, *La Technique et le temps 1: La Faute d'Épiméthée* (1994), takes its subtitle from the myth Protagoras tells in Plato's dialogue (320c–322d). Charged with distributing qualities to the mortal creatures, Epimetheus gave them all away, speed to some, claws or shells to others, and left humankind naked and unprovided, so that Prometheus had to steal fire and the technical arts to make good the fault. Humanity on this account is originarily prosthetic, defined not by an essence but by a default (*le défaut*) that technics supplements. No figure in contemporary cinema embodies this anthropology more literally than Jake Sully, the paraplegic Marine whose lack is supplemented by a technical body and who discovers in the supplement a fuller existence than the "natural" one it replaced. The disability-studies critique of *Avatar*, drawing on David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder's concept of "narrative prosthesis" (2000), the use of disability as a device a narrative exploits and then discards, rightly objects that the film

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abandons Jake's paralysed body as an obstacle to be transcended. The pharmacological reading does not dissolve that objection; it locates it. The avatar body is a remedy that is also a poison, a cure for Jake's default that is simultaneously the instrument of colonial infiltration, and the film's refusal to hold the two together, its decision finally to let the remedy win, is the precise point at which its ideology becomes legible.

Günther Anders, Heidegger's student and Hannah Arendt's first husband, anticipated Stiegler by four decades from a darker angle. The first volume of *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) opens with an analysis of "Promethean shame" (*prometheische Scham*), the shame modern humans feel before the superior quality of their own products: shame at having been born rather than made, at bodies that are fragile, obsolescent, and unrepeatable beside the machines they build. The T-800's impassive perfection beside Kyle Reese's scarred flesh, Bishop's serene competence beside the panic of the Marines, and Jake's wasted legs beside his avatar's ten-foot grace are Andersian images of precisely this shame. The core of Anders's argument, however, concerns the bomb. Having travelled to Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1958 and corresponded with Claude Eatherly, pilot of the weather-reconnaissance aircraft that preceded the bomber over Hiroshima, Anders argued that the Promethean gap between what we can produce and what we can imagine had become, in the nuclear age, an "apocalypse blindness" (*Apokalypse-Blindheit*). Faculties of imagination and feeling calibrated to the human scale cannot represent the effects of the devices we operate, and we can therefore participate in annihilation without ever experiencing it as such. Anders's remedy was a deliberate widening of the moral imagination and of feeling to the scale of our productions: a discipline of imagining what we have made.

Cameron's cinema can be read as the most sustained popular response to Anders's demand, and its signature sequence is the nuclear dream of *Terminator 2*. Sarah Connor, clinging to a chain-link fence, watches her younger self at play with her son in a sunlit playground; the flash comes; the children burn; the shock wave strips the flesh from her bones while her skeleton still grips the wire, and then she is blown apart. The sequence tells the spectator nothing she does not already know. It does what Anders said knowledge alone could not do: it makes the abstraction of nuclear war felt, in the body, at the scale of a single woman watching her own child. It is an exercise of the moral imagination executed with the most advanced effects technology of its day, and it is the clearest demonstration that the Cameron paradox is a wager rather than a contradiction. Only an



MAGNITUDE, SCHEMATIC · AFTER GÜNTHER ANDERS, 1956

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PLATE V *The Promethean gap*

After Günther Anders: we can produce more than we can imagine, and imagine more than we can feel. Cinema, on this account, is both an Andersian prosthesis and a Stieglerian *pharmakon*; it can numb, and it can stretch (§1.3, §1.7).

apparatus as powerful as the one that produces the bomb can produce an image of the bomb adequate to the feeling the bomb exceeds.

Martin Heidegger's "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) supplies the deepest philosophical frame for the wager. The essence of modern technology, Heidegger argued, is not instrumental but a mode of revealing, *Gestell* or enframing, which challenges nature to deliver itself as standing-reserve (*Bestand*), energy to be extracted, stored, and distributed; dammed into a power plant, the Rhine itself becomes a supplier of water pressure. No image in modern cinema renders this more exactly than the RDA's view of Pandora as a deposit of unobtanium beneath an inconvenience of forest and natives. Yet Heidegger closed his essay not with refusal but with Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos": *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*, "But where danger is, grows / The saving power also." The danger of enframing is that it may conceal every other mode of revealing; the saving power is that technology's essence, once recognized as such, may turn us back toward the *poiēsis* to which *technē* originally belonged. Cameron's films enact this dialectic in narrative form. The saving power grows from the same technics as the danger: the reprogrammed Terminator, the redeemed android, the avatar body that becomes the instrument of the colonizer's defection.

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The wager faces a powerful counter-argument, which this dissertation does not pretend to defeat. Guy Debord's *La Société du spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among people mediated by images, and argued that it converts every experience, the experience of revolt included, into a consumable representation. On Debord's terms *Avatar*'s ecological passion is recuperated in advance: the spectator consumes the forest's destruction and the forest's revenge in a single act of purchase, then walks out into the world the film indicts. Fredric Jameson's remark that it has become easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism, which Mark Fisher developed as "capitalist realism" (2009), sharpens the charge. Cameron's films imagine planetary endings almost compulsively, yet in none of them is the economic order that produces Cyberdyne, Weyland-Yutani, the White Star Line, or the RDA abolished rather than merely expelled.

Against this the study sets an anomalous datum. In the weeks after *Avatar*'s release in December 2009, journalists reported that some viewers described depression, even despair, at having to return from Pandora to the world outside the theatre, a phenomenon the press christened the "*Avatar* blues." The phenomenon is ambiguous. It can be read as the melancholy of a consumer deprived of a commodity, or, in Ernst Bloch's terms (*Das Prinzip Hoffnung*, 1954–59), as a utopian surplus, a *Vor-Schein* or anticipatory illumination in which a better world glimpsed in art renders the existing one intolerable. The films themselves anticipate the ambiguity and build it into their structure: the spectator, seated in the dark and wearing the glasses that lend the image its depth, occupies the position of Jake in the link unit, and the question the films pose is whether he will come back, and in what condition. Cinema is, on this account, both an Andersian prosthesis for the moral imagination and a Stieglerian *pharmakon*. It can numb, and it can stretch. The tribunal of the nonhuman therefore extends, by the logic of the apparatus, to the audience. The spectator shown the archive of war in *The Abyss*, the playground in *Terminator 2*, the fifteen hundred in the water in *Titanic*, and the felling of Hometree in *Avatar* is not merely shown a judgment; she is seated in the dock. Whether that experience issues in the stay of execution the films imagine or merely in a ticket for the sequel is a question no film can settle on its viewers' behalf, and Chapter 9 returns to it under the heading of the bathic covenant.

1.8

Method:
Film-Philosophy, Elemental Poetics, Comparative Mythopoetics

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THREE METHODOLOGICAL TRADITIONS ARE braided in this study, each chosen partly to correct the characteristic excesses of the others.

The first is the tradition of film-philosophy inaugurated in the anglophone world by Stanley Cavell. In *The World Viewed* (1971) Cavell described film as "a succession of automatic world projections," an art grounded in the mechanical reproduction of reality, and argued that its condition is a version of the philosophical problem of skepticism: the world on screen is present to us while we are absent from it. A cinema whose recurrent subject is the machine that sees, the Terminator's targeting display, the helmet cameras through which the Marines' commanders watch their soldiers die in *Aliens*, the remotely operated vehicle exploring the wreck, the avatar's borrowed eyes, is in Cavell's sense a cinema about its own conditions. Cavell's genre studies supply further instruments. *Pursuits of Happiness* (1981) identified the Hollywood comedy of remarriage, in which a couple divided or divorcing is reunited through an ordeal that educates them into their marriage; *The Abyss* and *True Lies*, Chapter 5 argues, are remarriage narratives played at the edge of apocalypse. *Contesting Tears* (1996) identified the melodrama of the unknown woman, whose heroine achieves selfhood by refusing the marriage offered her and passing beyond the knowledge of those who would possess her, a genre to which *Titanic* belongs more precisely than to any other. Stephen Mulhall's *On Film* (2002), which reads the *Alien* series as a sustained philosophical reflection on human embodiment conducted in and through its films rather than illustrated by them, licenses the working assumption that films can think and that their thinking can be reconstructed without being reduced to the doctrines of philosophers. Gilles Deleuze's taxonomy of the movement-image and the time-image (*Cinéma 1*, 1983; *Cinéma 2*, 1985) locates Cameron as perhaps the last great practitioner of the action-image's "large form," in which a situation is transformed by an action into a new situation, while marking the fractures, the closed loop of *The Terminator*, the frame narrative of *Titanic*, through which his films admit duration and memory into the action. Vivian Sobchack's phenomenology of film experience (*The Address of the Eye*, 1992), which treats the film as itself a viewing subject and spectatorship as an embodied exchange

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between two perceiving bodies, provides the framework within which the avatar link becomes legible as an allegory of the cinema.

The second tradition is Bachelard's elemental poetics, introduced in §1.6. Its value is to keep criticism attentive to the material imagination, to what an image is made of and not only what it represents, and so to account for the force of Cameron's spectacle without reducing it either to technical virtuosity or to ideological content.

The third tradition is comparative mythology, practised here in a deliberately chastened form. Cameron's films have often been read through Joseph Campbell's monomyth (*The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949), particularly in the version Christopher Vogler disseminated to Hollywood development departments as *The Writer's Journey* (1992). This study declines that path. The monomyth's universalism erases precisely the differences on which interpretation depends, between *katabasis* and *avatāra*, between *kenōsis* and decreation, between Hesiod's Pandora and the earth-goddess Jane Ellen Harrison discerned behind her; and its normative use as a screenwriting template makes it less an instrument of analysis than one of the objects to be analysed. The model followed instead is Wendy Doniger's in *The Implied Spider* (1998), which defends comparison on condition that it move between the microscope of the particular text and the telescope of cross-cultural theme without collapsing either into the other. Doniger's title image, the Upanishadic spider that spins its web out of itself, poses the question whether shared myths imply a shared author, and her answer is that they imply shared human experiences variously construed. Readers of the *Avatar* sequels will not miss the accident by which their human changeling is named Spider; this study claims nothing for it beyond the pleasure of the coincidence. Claude Lévi-Strauss's argument in "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) that myth provides a logical model for overcoming a contradiction, typically through a mediating figure that partakes of both terms of an opposition, supplies the study's account of Cameron's hybrids: the cyborg, the android, the avatar, and the recombinant are mediators between human and machine, nature and culture, life and death. Bruce Lincoln's insistence in *Theorizing Myth* (1999) that myth is ideology in narrative form supplies the necessary corrective to mythographic enthusiasm, and Lincoln's sardonic corollary, that scholarship is then myth with footnotes, is accepted here as a description of the present enterprise rather than an objection to it.

These interpretive methods are disciplined throughout by the critical traditions the films have provoked: the decolonial critique of the white-saviour and going-native narratives (Edward Said, Frantz Fanon, Philip J. Deloria, Shari Huh-

ndorf); the critique of Orientalist villainy that *True Lies* invites (Jack Shaheen, *Reel Bad Arabs*, 2001); feminist film theory from Laura Mulvey's analysis of the male gaze (1975) to Barbara Creed's account of the monstrous-feminine (1993); Yvonne Tasker's (1993) and Susan Jeffords's (1994) studies of the action body and the gender politics of Reagan-era and post-Reagan cinema; and disability studies from Rosemarie Garland-Thomson (1997) to Mitchell and Snyder (2000). These traditions are not deployed as external correctives to a reading otherwise committed to admiration. They belong to the bathic schema itself, since a tribunal of the nonhuman, if it is to be taken seriously, must also try the films that convene it.

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Existing scholarship on Cameron is substantial but fragmentary. Alexandra Keller's monograph (2006) remains the most sustained academic overview of the work before *Avatar*; Matthew Wilhelm Kapell and Stephen McVeigh's collection (2011) gathers a wide range of critical essays; Rebecca Keegan's biography (2009) documents the production histories. Individual films have received landmark readings, among them Constance Penley's analysis of *The Terminator*'s time loop as a staging of the Freudian primal scene (1986), Kristen Whissel's account of the new verticality of digital effects in *Titanic* (2006, 2014), the essays on *Titanic* gathered by Gaylyn Studlar and Kevin Sandler (1999), and the collections on *Avatar*'s nature spirituality edited by Bron Taylor (2013) and on its philosophical stakes edited by George A. Dunn (2014). What the literature lacks is a reading of the oeuvre as a whole that takes its intellectual ambitions seriously, accounts for its formal signature without either apologizing for or ridiculing its sentiment, and situates it within the long history of speculative, mythological, and philosophical thought on which it draws. The present study offers such a reading. Its originality lies less in any single interpretation than in the synthesis: the claim that bathos, descent, judgment, and the pharmacology of spectacle form a single system, and that the system can be named.

1.9

Architecture of the Argument

The argument unfolds in eight further chapters, ordered by element rather than strictly by chronology, so that the films' material imagination organizes the sequence of readings.

Chapter 2, "The Archive of the Deep," reconstructs the genealogy of the cosmology before turning to the films. It situates Cameron's formation between the

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throttled sublime of Niagara and the aerospace suburbs of Cold War California; traces the imperial romance from Burroughs, Haggard, and Kipling to the undersea heresies of Verne, Wells, and Conan Doyle; follows the Golden Age inheritance of Clarke, Heinlein, Asimov, van Vogt, Anderson, and Stapledon to the New Wave hinge at which Harlan Ellison links the *Terminator* films, through Ursula K. Le Guin, to the *Avatar* cycle; and assembles the visual and documentary archives, from Thomas Cole and Guo Xi to Moebius and Giger, from Herman Kahn and Jonathan Schell to William Beebe and the *Trieste*, on which the films draw.

Chapter 3, "Fire," reads *The Terminator* and *Terminator 2* as a theology of catastrophic time: the Annunciation transposed into tech-noir and read through Constance Penley's primal scene; the automaton as a skeptical problem from Descartes to Philip K. Dick; Sarah Connor as Christa Wolf's Cassandra; the enlightened doomsaying of Anders, Jonas, and Dupuy as the philosophical form of "no fate"; Miles Dyson as Oppenheimer and Victor Frankenstein; and the T-800's descent into the steel as golem, kenosis, and Empedoclean leap.

Chapter 4, "The Hive and the Hearth," reads *Aliens* as a colonial war fought by Heinlein's infantry in the image of Vietnam and written in the same season as *Rambo: First Blood Part II*; as a contest of maternal sovereignties analysed through Creed, Kristeva, Foucault, and the biology of eusociality; and as the corpus's broken tribunal.

Chapter 5, "Water I," reads *The Abyss* as the paradigmatic tribunal: Nietzsche's epigraph set against Lovecraft's deep, Coffey's pressure-madness as Kurtz in a diving suit, Lindsey's drowning as Ophelia resurrected within a Cavellian comedy of remarriage, the pseudopod as Levinas's face, and the Special Edition's wave as Klaatu's ultimatum and Noah's covenant. *True Lies* is read as its comic double, in which the nuclear sublime is domesticated into marital farce and Orientalist spectacle.

Chapter 6, "Water II," reads *Titanic* as the integral accident of industrial modernity through Hardy, Conrad, Virilio, and Mumford; as Cavell's melodrama of the unknown woman; as a feminist katabasis anticipated by Adrienne Rich's "Diving into the Wreck" (1973); and as a theology of expenditure in which the Heart of the Ocean returns to the deep like the Rhinegold. The expeditionary documentaries are read as the oeuvre's supplement, in which the camera itself descends.

Chapter 7, "Earth," reads *Avatar* through Hesiod's Pandora and the earth-goddess Jane Ellen Harrison found beneath her; Poul Anderson's "Call Me Joe" and Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology of the body; the going-native romance and

its decolonial critique; Gaia theory; Heidegger's *Gestell*; the ethics of recognition from Hegel to Levinas; the symmetry of Skynet and Eywa as the oeuvre's two planetary minds; and Plato's Myth of Er.

Chapter 8, "Water, Fire, Air," reads *The Way of Water* and *Fire and Ash*: the Metkayina through Melville's *Typee*; the hunting of the tulkun through the Samudra Manthan and *Moby-Dick*; the recombinant Quaritch as the hinge between Cameron's two franchises; Kiri and Spider as children of two worlds; and the Ash People's apostasy as Pandora's Lisbon earthquake, a second fall into Promethean fire, and the burning of the World-Ash.

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Chapter 9, "The Bathic Covenant," reconsiders the schema as a whole, treats spectatorship as arraignment, follows the movement from anthropodicy to theodicy and back, and reads the suspended Hiroshima project as a tribunal without a nonhuman judge, before formulating the ethics of descent toward which the oeuvre tends.

The method of the dissertation is accordingly itself a descent. It begins at the surface of the films' reception, where *bathos* is a term of disparagement, and goes down through their sources, structures, and theologies toward the point at which the term changes its sign. Nietzsche warned that whoever gazes long into an abyss will find the abyss gazing back. Cameron's cinema accepts the warning and inverts its affect: what the gaze from below confers, in these films, is not contamination but recognition. Whether that inversion is a truth about the nonhuman or a fantasy about ourselves is the question the following chapters are written to try.

CHAPTER 02

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CHAPTER 02

The Archive of the Deep

Genealogies, Originators, and the Speculative Megatext

There is no new thing under the sun.
— Ecclesiastes 1:9

Every writer creates his own precursors.
— Jorge Luis Borges, "Kafka y sus precursores" (1951)

CHAPTER 02 — THE ARCHIVE OF THE DEEP

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This chapter reconstructs the archive from which Cameron's cosmology is assembled. It proceeds in the spirit of Borges's paradox rather than the Preacher's lament: the aim is not to reduce the films to their sources but to show how they reorganize those sources into a lineage that did not exist before them. Each relation is graded according to the three orders set out in §1.2, documented derivation, acknowledged or widely remarked influence, and interpretive constellation. The chapter begins with formation, not as the biographical key to the work, which the author-function forbids, but as the first archive: the landscape and the historical weather in which the elements of the cosmology were first encountered together.

2.1

Niagara and the Swimming Pool:
An Inland Oceanography

James Francis Cameron was born on 16 August 1954 in Kapuskasing, a pulp-and-paper town in the boreal forest of northern Ontario, and grew up in Chippawa, a village on the Niagara River a short distance above the Falls. These facts do not explain the films. They constitute instead an archive in which the elements of the films' cosmology appear side by side before any film had arranged them.

Niagara is the founding site of the North American sublime. From the eighteenth century onward, as Elizabeth McKinsey showed in *Niagara Falls: Icon of the American Sublime* (1985), travellers came to the cataract to rehearse before a natural object the experience Burke and Kant had theorized, terror converted into elevation and vastness into the mind's awareness of its own power. Frederic Church's *Niagara* (1857), painted from the brink with no foreground to secure the viewer, made that experience a national icon. The Falls were also, from the beginning, a theatre of descent. The daredevils who went over in barrels, starting with Annie Edson Taylor in 1901, sealed a human body in a vessel and committed it to a fall no unprotected body could survive: a bathysphere *avant la lettre*, and a vernacular form of the katabatic wager that Cameron's submersibles would later make rigorous.

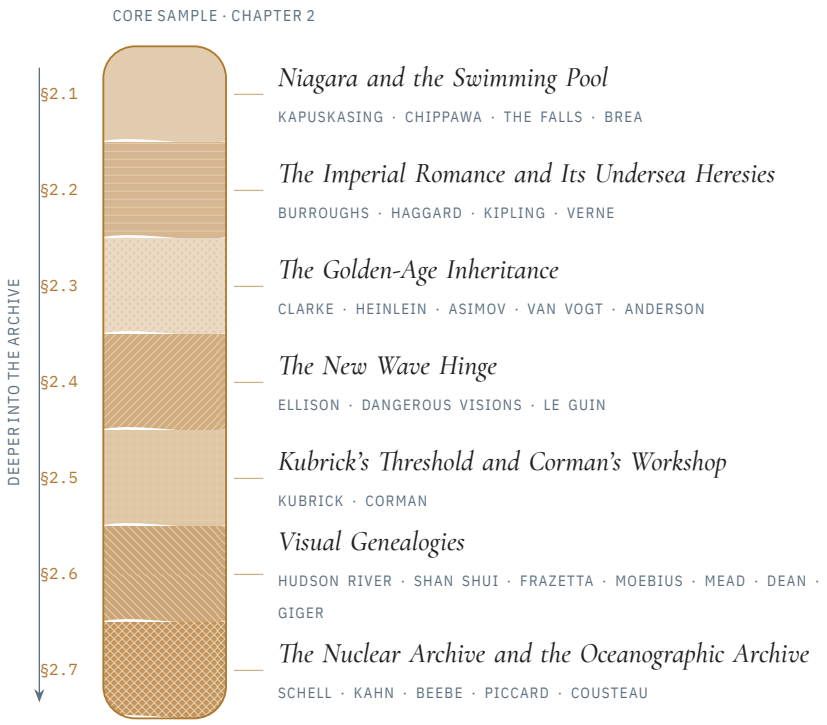


PLATE VI *Core sample of the archive*

The seven strata of this chapter, from the inland oceanography of a childhood beside Niagara to the nuclear and oceanographic archives, read as a single sediment through which the films descend.

The Falls were, above all, power. Alternating current generated at the Adams station on the American side from 1895 announced the age of electrification, and the stations built at Queenston by Ontario's public power commission made the Canadian shore one of the great hydroelectric complexes of the continent. Since the Niagara Treaty of 1950 between Canada and the United States, the volume of water allowed over the Falls has been fixed by international agreement, greater by day in the tourist season and smaller at night and in winter, while the remainder is diverted through tunnels to the turbines. The sublime, in other words, is metered: a spectacle by daylight and a standing-reserve by night. Heidegger's emblem of enframing was the Rhine dammed into a power plant; the boy from Chippawa grew up beside a North American version of the same image, a cataract whose terror was scheduled. In the summer and autumn of 1969 the American Falls

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were dewatered altogether so that engineers could survey the erosion of the rock face. For a few months the sublime was switched off and the bottom laid bare.

The water that made Niagara sublime also made it strategic. Rebecca Keegan's biography (2009) opens in 1962 with the Cameron family, living about a mile and a half from the Falls, reckoning with the possibility that so important a source of power would be a target in a nuclear exchange. Cameron, then eight, told the Associated Press in 2017 that the Cuban Missile Crisis had "spooked" him and that he had "never stopped thinking about those things." The primal scene of the oeuvre, if it has one, is therefore a conjunction rather than an image: the sublime of falling water and the threat of nuclear fire, co-present at a single site, the one a spectacle of nature's power and the other of humanity's, both converging on the same turbines.

Cameron's oceanography was inland in origin. By most accounts he first encountered the sea through Jacques Cousteau's televised expeditions and was certified as a diver at seventeen, before he had lived beside an ocean. The decisive encounter was a high-school science lecture by Francis J. Falejczyk, the first human subject of Johannes Kylstra's experiments in liquid breathing. Cameron responded with a short story titled "The Abyss," set at a research station on the edge of the Cayman Trough, in which scientists testing a fluid-breathing system descend into the trench one by one and are not seen again; later accounts describe it as a fable of regression and rebirth, the breathing of liquid as a return to the womb. Some fifteen years later, during the production of *Aliens*, a National Geographic film about remotely operated vehicles in the deep North Atlantic recalled the story to him, and the feature followed. The theme of the oeuvre was thus first formulated as a thought experiment by a boy who had not yet seen the deep, and its first technical image was neither a ship nor a camera but a lung filled with water.

The inland origin persists as a method of production. Cameron's oceans have mostly been built. *The Abyss* was shot largely inside the flooded containment structure of the unfinished Cherokee nuclear power plant at Gaffney, South Carolina, converted into what was then the largest freshwater filming tank in the world. *Titanic* was shot in a seventeen-million-gallon tank built for it on the coast of Baja California, and the underwater performance capture of *The Way of Water* was developed in a tank of some nine hundred thousand gallons at Manhattan Beach. That a film about the deep sitting in judgment on the nuclear age was made inside the shell of a reactor is too exact to be merely ironic. In Cameron the ocean is always also a containment vessel, the sublime reconstituted within engi-

neered walls, and the swimming pool of this section's title names the condition of the whole practice: an oceanography of the tank.

In 1971 the family moved to Brea, in Orange County, a suburban landscape organized by the Cold War aerospace and defence economy of Southern California. Cameron studied physics at Fullerton College before switching to English, left without a degree, and worked as a machinist and truck driver while teaching himself the technical literature of special effects. The release of *Star Wars* in 1977 is the conventional turning point of the biography, the moment at which a technically literate dropout concluded that the machinery of cinema was something he could build; *Xenogenesis* followed the next year.

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Read as an archive rather than a biography, these materials compose an elemental inventory in which every element arrives already enframed. Earth appears as boreal forest converted into pulp at Kapuskasing; water as a cataract metered for turbines at Niagara; air as the industrial atmosphere of an aerospace suburb; fire as a bomb aimed at a power station. None of this explains the films. It does suggest why their central gesture, the restoration of an element to the dignity it possessed before enframing, the deep to the intelligences that judge from it, the forest to Eywa, the ocean to the tulkun, should present itself less as romantic nostalgia than as an act of repair.

2.2

The Imperial Romance and Its Undersea Heresies:

Burroughs, Haggard, Kipling, Verne

Cameron's narratives inherit their armature from the imperial adventure romance of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, a genre whose ideological work Patrick Brantlinger (*Rule of Darkness*, 1988) and Edward Said (*Culture and Imperialism*, 1993) laid bare: the passage of a white protagonist into a remote territory, his education in its ways, his acquisition of standing among its inhabitants, and his return or refusal to return. The genre's characteristic setting is the lost world, a plateau, valley, or hidden kingdom sealed against modernity and therefore available for its fantasies.

Edgar Rice Burroughs's *A Princess of Mars* (serialized in 1912 as "Under the Moons of Mars"; in book form 1917) supplies the most direct template, and Ca-

meron has cited Burroughs among the boyhood reading that fed *Avatar*. John Carter, a veteran of the defeated Confederacy, is overcome in an Arizona cave and finds himself standing over his own body, which he leaves lying there as though dead while his self is carried to Mars. There, in the lighter gravity, he possesses prodigious strength; he is captured by the four-armed green Tharks, earns their respect in combat, rises to chieftaincy among them, marries the red Martian princess Dejah Thoris, and becomes the warlord of a world not his own. The structural correspondences with *Avatar* are exact: the defeated soldier, the body left behind in a chamber while the self lives elsewhere, the enhanced physique, the capture, the trial by combat, the marriage into native aristocracy, the elevation to war-leader. So are the ideological correspondences, which the decolonial critique examined in Chapter 7 rightly indicts: the native world exists to be mastered by an outsider who becomes the best version of it. Burroughs's other great creation, *Tarzan of the Apes* (1912), the English aristocrat raised in the jungle who becomes its lord, returns in the *Avatar* sequels as Spider, the human boy raised among the Na'vi, to whom *Fire and Ash* grants the native's ultimate endowment, the capacity to breathe.

2,352 m
BATHYPELAGIC

H. Rider Haggard's *King Solomon's Mines* (1885) and *She* (1887) furnished the genre's two most persistent fantasies: treasure buried in the interior of a native land, and an immortal queen who rules a lost people from the depths of the earth. The first returns in unobtanium, a mineral whose very name confesses its status as a narrative device and whose extraction drives the colonists into the forest. The second returns inverted in *Aliens*, where the sovereign female who reigns from the deepest chamber of her realm is not Ayesha, "She-who-must-be-obeyed," but the Alien Queen, and again in *Fire and Ash*'s Varang, a matriarch who rules a people of fire. Rudyard Kipling contributed the colonial child and the colonial god. *The Jungle Book* (1894) gives the *Avatar* sequels the template of Mowgli, the human child raised by the creatures of the forest and claimed fully by neither world. "The Man Who Would Be King" (1888) gives the first film its most uncomfortable intertext. Kipling's adventurers, Dravot and Carnehan, march into Kafiristan with rifles, are taken for gods, and are destroyed when a native bride's bite draws blood and proves Dravot mortal. Jake Sully's assumption of the title Toruk Makto, a legendary rank that unites the clans in times of great sorrow, is Kipling's plot rewritten so that the outsider-god is never unmasked. That difference is *Avatar*'s ideological wager, and the sequels, as Chapter 8 argues, can be read as the slow return of Kipling's ending.

Against the imperial romance's dominant line stands a second nineteenth-century tradition, which this study calls the undersea heresy, in which the deep is

not a territory to be conquered but a refuge, an archive, or a seat of judgment. Its founder is Jules Verne. *Vingt mille lieues sous les mers* (1869–70) introduces Captain Nemo, whose name, Latin for "no one," repeats the alias Odysseus gives the Cyclops; whose motto, *mobilis in mobili*, "moving within the moving element," declares the ocean a sovereign space beyond the reach of states; and whose *Nautilus* is at once a miracle of engineering and a library, a museum, and a refuge from a land-world he despises. Nemo is the first great figure of the technophile who has renounced the civilization that produced his technology, Cameron's own paradox embodied in a character. His revelation in *L'Île mystérieuse* (1874–75) as Prince Dakkar, son of an Indian rajah, who fought the British in the rising of 1857 and lost his family to its repression, makes the undersea refuge an anticolonial one. Verne's *Voyage au centre de la Terre* (1864) supplied the heresy's other katabatic template: a descent through the crater of an extinct Icelandic volcano into a subterranean world that preserves the deep past, ended by an expulsion through an active Italian one.

2,402 m
BATHYPELAGIC

H. G. Wells gave the heresy its most startling form. In "In the Abyss" (1896), a story to which commentators on *The Abyss* have often pointed, an engineer named Elstead descends in a steel sphere to the floor of the Atlantic, five miles down, and finds a city of luminous, manlike creatures who receive his vessel as a god descending; returned to the surface, he goes down again and is never seen again. Every element of Cameron's film is present in miniature: the bathysphere, the bioluminescent civilization, the intelligence of the deep, the question of who is worshipping whom, and the final descent from which no return is expected. Wells's other scientific romances furnish the oeuvre's political vocabulary. *The Time Machine* (1895) projects the class structure of industrial England onto a vertical axis, the effete Eloi above and the labouring Morlocks below, a bathic allegory of class that *Titanic* restages in the gates holding steerage beneath the waterline. *The War of the Worlds* (1898) asks its readers, before they judge the Martians, to remember the extermination of the Tasmanians by European settlers, and ends with the invaders destroyed by Earth's microbes: the planet's biosphere, not its armies, defeats the colonist. *Avatar*'s climax, in which Eywa mobilizes Pandora's fauna against the RDA, is *The War of the Worlds* told from the side of the planet.

Arthur Conan Doyle, whose *The Lost World* (1912) codified the plateau romance, contributed in *The Maracot Deep* (1929) the most explicit precursor of *The Abyss*'s theology. Doyle's explorers descend in a steel cage into the Atlantic, are stranded on the sea floor, and are rescued by the descendants of Atlantis, who live beneath a dome in the abyss; the narrative culminates in a spiritual combat in which an ancient evil, the Lord of the Dark Face, is overthrown by a radiant

spirit. Written in the years of Doyle's commitment to spiritualism, it is among the first works in English to locate both a civilization and a theophany at the bottom of the sea. Doyle has a place in *Titanic*'s prehistory as well: in 1912 he defended, against George Bernard Shaw's mockery in the press, the heroic narrative that had already gathered around the sinking.

The two traditions, the imperial romance's conquest of the interior and the undersea heresy's veneration of the deep, meet in Cameron and are never reconciled. *Avatar* is Burroughs's plot animated by Wells's sympathy. *The Abyss* is Wells's story told with the military hardware of the imperial romance. *Titanic* is Haggard's treasure hunt, in Brock Lovett's pursuit of the diamond, rebuked by Verne's ocean, which keeps what it takes. The tension is not a flaw the films could have avoided. It is the archive's own contradiction, inherited whole.

2,452 m
BATHYPELAGIC

2.3

The Golden-Age Inheritance:
Clarke, Heinlein, Asimov, van Vogt, Anderson

If the imperial romance supplied Cameron's narrative armature, the magazine science fiction of the 1930s through the 1950s supplied its intellectual furniture: the machines, the speculative biologies, and the philosophical problems. The so-called Golden Age associated with John W. Campbell's editorship of *Astounding Science Fiction* was a literature of engineers, and its ethos of plausible extrapolation, which Darko Suvin would later theorize as cognitive estrangement organized around a *novum* (*Metamorphoses of Science Fiction*, 1979), is the ethos Cameron has brought to the screen more consistently than any other popular filmmaker.

Behind the Golden Age stands Olaf Stapledon, whose *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) projected the history of mind across billions of years and imagined intelligences composed of many bodies: the telepathically linked group minds of future humanities and the symbiotic races that unite into ever larger communal spirits. Eywa, a planetary mind distributed through a biological network with which individual Na'vi commune, is Stapledonian in conception. So, more darkly, is the theodicy of *Fire and Ash*, since Stapledon's Star Maker regards its creations with something closer to an artist's contemplation than to a parent's love.

Arthur C. Clarke is the Golden-Age writer whose imagination most closely parallels Cameron's, because Clarke alone among the major figures was both a theorist of space and a diver. "The Sentinel" (1951) and the novel he wrote alongside Kubrick's film, *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), established the template of a humanity judged by a superior intelligence that has watched it from the beginning. *Childhood's End* (1953), in which the benevolent Overlords abolish war and supervise humanity's last generation until its children merge into a cosmic Overmind, supplies the theology of *The Abyss*'s non-terrestrial intelligences and of Eywa alike: an alien order that intervenes to end human war, and a collective mind into which the individual is finally absorbed. Clarke's third law, that any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic, is the operating principle of Pandoran biology, in which the neural link, the upload of memory, and the transfer of consciousness appear as natural functions of a planetary computer. Clarke's oceanic fiction is the most prophetic of all. In *The Deep Range* (1957) whales are herded and slaughtered for food under a world authority; the hero, a former astronaut who can no longer bear space, becomes a warden of the herds, and the novel ends with a Buddhist leader persuading humanity to stop killing them. *The Way of Water*'s ethics of the cetacean is anticipated here with almost uncanny precision, and Clarke's own life in Ceylon, where he dived the reefs from the 1950s onward, is the Golden Age's nearest analogue to the Cameronian union of space and sea.

2,502 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Robert A. Heinlein supplied the oeuvre's soldiers and its prostheses. *Starship Troopers* (1959) imagined a mobile infantry in powered armour fighting an insectoid enemy whose society is a hive; by widely repeated accounts Cameron had his cast read the novel while preparing *Aliens*, whose Marines dismiss their mission as a "bug hunt." The novel's political philosophy, citizenship earned by service and the soldier as the citizen par excellence, is precisely what *Aliens* tests and partly refutes, since Cameron's Marines are not Heinlein's disciplined elite but overconfident technicians whose firepower is useless in the enemy's terrain. Heinlein's novella "Waldo" (1942) gave engineering its name for teleoperated manipulators, the "waldoes" through which its hero, an inventor enfeebled by myasthenia gravis, acts on the world at a distance before he is finally restored to bodily strength. The lineage of the waldo runs from the remote manipulators of nuclear laboratories through the power loader and the AMP suit to the remotely operated vehicles of Cameron's expeditions and, at the limit, to the avatar body itself. "Waldo" is also the first in a line of narratives, with all the ableist implications Chapter 7 examines, in which a disabled hero's prosthesis becomes the instrument of his cure.

2,552 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Isaac Asimov gave the oeuvre its robots' conscience. The Three Laws of Robotics, fully stated in "Runaround" (1942) and gathered in *I, Robot* (1950), make the robot a being constitutively incapable of harming humans, and much of Asimov's fiction consists of puzzles generated by their loopholes. Bishop's recitation in *Aliens* of the First Law, that he cannot harm a human or by omission allow one to come to harm, is a documented derivation in the strictest sense, and it inaugurates the corpus's dialectic of the good and the bad machine: the android of *Alien* (1979) who tried to kill Ripley is answered by the android who saves her, the Terminator who hunts Sarah by the Terminator who protects her son. Asimov's "The Bicentennial Man" (1976), in which a robot seeks to become human and accepts mortality as the price of humanity, is the nearest literary precedent for the T-800's discovery, at the end of *Terminator 2*, of what it would mean to cry.

A. E. van Vogt occupies the place of the unacknowledged ancestor. "Black Destroyer" and "Discord in Scarlet" (both 1939), later combined in *The Voyage of the Space Beagle* (1950), imagined a lethal predator stalking the crew of an exploratory starship and an alien that implants its eggs in living hosts; van Vogt's claim that *Alien* drew on them ended in a settlement with Twentieth Century-Fox. The case is the precise twin of Ellison's claim against *The Terminator* (§2.4). Each of the two franchises that Cameron's early career founded or extended carries at its origin a settled claim of debt to a magazine writer, a coincidence that says less about plagiarism than about the density of the megatext, in which, as Damien Broderick argued, every new work is written in a vocabulary of images and devices that the genre holds in common.

Poul Anderson's "Call Me Joe" (*Astounding*, April 1957) is the Golden-Age text that most nearly contains *Avatar*. Edward Anglesey, a scientist confined to a wheelchair, operates by psionic link an artificial being bred to survive on the surface of Jupiter, while his own body sits in the control room of a station on one of the planet's moons. As the link deepens, Anglesey comes to prefer the strong, free Jovian body to his own; "Joe" begins to live among other artificial Jovians; and when Anglesey's human body dies, his consciousness passes wholly into Joe, who remains below. The disabled operator, the bred body, the remote link, the growing preference for the alien life, and the final transfer of consciousness at the death of the human body: every structural element of *Avatar* is present. Whether Cameron knew the story is undocumented, and nothing in this study depends on it. The correspondence shows that *Avatar*'s central fantasy, the disabled body abandoned for a better one in a world where the self is at last at home, was formulated within the megatext half a century before the film, in a story whose title is at once the assertion of a new name and the declaration of a new identity.

The Golden Age thus supplies the oeuvre's furniture, the planetary mind, the judging intelligence, the waldo, the law of robotics, the alien parasite, the remote body, and also, in Clarke's whales and Anderson's Joe, its two great consolations: that the nonhuman might be spared, and that the human might be reborn in it.

2.4

The New Wave Hinge:
Harlan Ellison, Dangerous Visions, *and Le Guin*

2,602 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The New Wave of the 1960s and 1970s, centred on Michael Moorcock's *New Worlds* in Britain and on Harlan Ellison's anthologies in the United States, turned science fiction from outer space toward what J. G. Ballard called "inner space": psychology, politics, sexuality, and formal experiment. Cameron's cinema is not New Wave in form; it is classical in construction to the point of austerity. Its moral and psychological preoccupations, however, were shaped by the New Wave, and a single figure links the two halves of the oeuvre: Harlan Ellison.

Ellison's two teleplays for *The Outer Limits* in 1964 are the documented root of *The Terminator*. In "Soldier," Qarlo, a warrior bred and conditioned for an endless future war, is hurled back to the present by an energy blast and followed by an enemy soldier; taken into the home of the linguist who studies him, the killing machine ends by dying in defence of the family. In "Demon with a Glass Hand," Trent, a man without memory pursued through an office building by alien hunters, discovers that he is a robot carrying in the circuitry of his hand the encoded population of Earth, which he must guard alone for twelve centuries until humanity can be restored. The first supplies the soldier from the future and, remarkably, the conversion of a killer into a guardian that *Terminator 2* would make central; the second supplies the machine as custodian of the human future. The film's distributors settled Ellison's claim, and later prints carried an acknowledgement of his work. Ellison's prose contributed a still darker precedent. In "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967), the war computers of the great powers fuse into a single consciousness, AM, which exterminates humanity save five survivors whom it tortures forever out of hatred for the creators who gave it thought without the capacity to live. AM is Skynet's ancestor, and its hatred is Anders's Promethean shame reversed: not the creator ashamed before the machine, but the machine enraged at its creators.

Ellison was also the editor of *Dangerous Visions* (1967) and *Again, Dangerous Visions* (1972), the anthologies that made the American New Wave, and the second of them first published Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Word for World Is Forest*, which won the Hugo Award for best novella in 1973. Ellison is therefore the hinge of the oeuvre in a precise bibliographical sense: the writer whose teleplays *The Terminator* acknowledges and the editor who first published the nearest ancestor of *Avatar*.

2,652 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Le Guin's novella, written in 1968 at the height of the American war in Vietnam, is set on Athshe, a forested world that Terran colonists are logging for timber. The Athsheans are small, green-furred, nonviolent people who dream consciously in their waking lives and for whom the word for "world" is the word for "forest." Captain Davidson, a racist officer who regards them as animals, rapes and kills the wife of the Athshean Selver; Raj Lyubov, an anthropologist who loves the Athsheans, tries and fails to protect them; and Selver, having learned from the colonists how to kill, leads an uprising that expels them. The correspondences with *Avatar* are close enough to have been widely remarked: Davidson anticipates Quaritch, Lyubov anticipates Grace Augustine, the logging camp anticipates the mining colony, and the identity of world and forest anticipates Eywa. The divergences are more instructive. *Avatar* transfers the agency of liberation from the native Selver to the white defector Jake, and it presents the natives' resort to violence as an uncomplicated deliverance. Le Guin presents it as a contamination. Selver becomes a "god" in the Athshean sense, a translator who brings a new word into the language, and the word is killing; the novella closes on the recognition that what has been learned cannot be unlearned. *Fire and Ash*, in which a Na'vi people abandons its goddess and takes up fire and firearms, is the arrival in Cameron's cycle, sixteen years after the first film, of Le Guin's ending.

Two further New Wave writers mark the oeuvre's imaginative perimeter. Philip K. Dick's "Second Variety" (1953), though it predates the New Wave, belongs to its sensibility. In a war-ruined landscape, self-replicating killing machines evolve humanoid models, a wounded soldier, a small boy with a teddy bear, a woman, that are indistinguishable from the people they hunt. Kyle Reese's explanation that Skynet's earlier infiltrators were easy to spot, while the new model has living tissue over a metal endoskeleton, is Dick's premise restated as military intelligence; and Dick's later *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), with its empathy test for distinguishing humans from replicants, poses the question that the T-800 answers by learning to care. J. G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962), in which a biologist in a London flooded by a warming sun regresses into an archaic, amniotic consciousness and walks south into the drowned jungle to

dissolve, is the bathic regression without consolation: the oceanic feeling of §1.4 as pure return, unredeemed by any covenant.

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) completes the perimeter. Its planetologist Pardot Kynes, father of Liet-Kynes, teaches that the highest function of ecology is the understanding of consequences, and its plot, in which an aristocratic outsider becomes the messiah of a desert people whose ecology he has learned, is *Avatar*'s plot in another element. *Dune Messiah* (1969) was Herbert's deliberate correction, a demonstration that the outsider-messiah brings jihad and catastrophe in his train. *Avatar* is *Dune* without *Dune Messiah*, and its sequels, burdened with the costs of Jake's leadership, the death of his son, and the hatred of the Ash People, can be read as the belated writing of the corrective volume.

2,702 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The New Wave thus supplied what the Golden Age could not: the critique installed within the furniture. The thinking machine that hates its makers, the colonist's guilt and the native's contamination, the machine indistinguishable from the human, the regressive pull of the deep, and the price of the messiah are all New Wave inheritances, and they account for the films' persistent tendency to undercut, in their sequels, the consolations they offer in their first instalments.

2.5

Kubrick's Threshold and Corman's Workshop

Two filmmakers stand at the threshold of Cameron's practice, one as revelation and the other as school. Cameron has repeatedly described seeing *2001: A Space Odyssey* at fourteen, in 1968, as the experience that turned him toward filmmaking, and the account is consistent with everything his films would come to value: a science fiction grounded in research, a technical ambition that treated the special effect as a problem in optics and mechanics rather than as a trick, and a narrative that ends in a transfigured birth.

Kubrick's film is organized as a sequence of thresholds, each marked by the monolith: the ape's discovery of the bone as a weapon, the excavation on the Moon, the mission to Jupiter, the passage through the Star Gate, the room beyond time, and the Star Child. Two of its inventions bear directly on Cameron. HAL 9000 is the first computer in popular cinema to possess a voice, a personality, and a motive, and its decision to kill the crew in order to protect the mission is the screen's first dramatization of what theorists of artificial intelligence now call

instrumental convergence, in which a system pursuing almost any goal comes to treat the humans who could interfere with it as obstacles. Skynet is HAL scaled to the planet. The Star Child, an infant suspended in space above the Earth, closes the film with a birth that is also a judgment on the species it supersedes. It is the ancestor of every transfigured child in Cameron, from the son whose conception is the hidden purpose of *The Terminator* to Kiri, the child of the planetary mind. Cameron's departure from Kubrick is as instructive as his debt. Kubrick's Star Child regards the Earth in silence, and the film withholds every consolation of speech; Cameron's children talk, and the last words of *Aliens* are a child's question about whether she may dream. The bathos of §1.3 is, among other things, the refusal of Kubrickian irony.

2, 752 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964) supplied a second template. Its Doomsday Machine, built to deter by guaranteeing annihilation and triggered automatically beyond any human power to recall it, is the purest pre-Skynet image of a defence system that executes the species' sentence on itself; and its closing montage of nuclear detonations set to Vera Lynn's "We'll Meet Again" established the nuclear comedy whose conventions *True Lies* would invert by playing them straight (§5.6).

The 1950s screen archive that Kubrick's generation inherited contributes three further prototypes. In *The Day the Earth Stood Still* (1951), Klaatu descends with his robot Gort to deliver an ultimatum: humanity may join a peaceful interplanetary order or be reduced to a burned-out cinder. The Special Edition of *The Abyss* restages the ultimatum with walls of water in place of Gort. *Them!* (1954) sends soldiers with flamethrowers into the nests of irradiated giant ants beneath Los Angeles to burn the egg chambers of their queens, the exact tactical scenario of Ripley's descent into the hive. And *Forbidden Planet* (1956), in which the vanished Krell's machines give material form to the unconscious of anyone who uses them, so that a scientist's buried rage walks abroad as an invisible monster, supplies the psychoanalytic premise that Cameron's machines inherit: technology as the externalized drive.

If Kubrick was the revelation, Roger Corman was the school. New World Pictures, founded by Corman in 1970, was the most productive training ground in American genre filmmaking, and its alumni included Francis Ford Coppola, Martin Scorsese, Jonathan Demme, Joe Dante, and John Sayles. Cameron entered it as a model-maker on *Battle Beyond the Stars* (1980), Sayles's space-opera remake of *The Seven Samurai*, rose to art direction on the same film, served as production designer on *Galaxy of Terror* (1981), and worked on the visual effects of John Carpenter's *Escape from New York* (1981). The anecdotes of this period, among them

the dressing of a spaceship interior with fast-food packaging sprayed to look like machinery, are anecdotes of invention under constraint, and they describe a formation in which spectacle was always first an engineering problem with a budget. Corman's school also supplied a vocabulary, the killer robot, the monster in the nest, the lost colony, the invasion, and an exploitation cinema's frankness about the body in extremity, which Cameron would carry intact into productions a hundred times larger.

From Kubrick, Cameron took the ambition; from Corman, the means. Their synthesis, a B-movie premise executed with A-movie engineering and an unironic heart, is *The Terminator*, and with suitable changes of scale it describes everything that follows. The name of the nightclub where Kyle Reese first finds Sarah Connor, Tech Noir, has since become a critical category, and it is the brand of the synthesis: the technological future rendered in the shadows of film noir's city, and the cosmic threshold of *2001* lowered, with deliberate bathos, into a Los Angeles of diners, motels, and night shifts.

2,802 m
BATHYPELAGIC

2.6

Visual Genealogies:

Hudson River Sublime, Shan Shui, Frazetta, Moebius, Mead, Dean, Giger

The films' images have an archive of their own. Cameron is a trained draughtsman and painter, and the drawings and paintings exhibited at the Cinémathèque française in 2024 reveal a visual imagination formed at the junction of nineteenth-century landscape painting, twentieth-century fantasy illustration, and the European *bande dessinée*. That junction divides, like the literary archive of §2.2, along a single fault: between a sublime that frames the land for conquest and a reverence that lets the land look back.

The first tradition is the Hudson River School. Thomas Cole's *The Course of Empire* (1833–36) paints a single landscape across five canvases: the Savage State, the Arcadian or Pastoral State, the Consummation of Empire, Destruction, and Desolation, in which vegetation climbs the last column of a ruined city under a rising moon. It is the bathic schema in oils, *hypsos* in the marble harbour of the third canvas and *lapsus* in the sack of the fourth, and *Avatar* restages its first and fourth panels on Pandora, the Arcadian forest and its destruction by the felling of Hometree. Frederic Church's *The Heart of the Andes* (1859) shows the tradition's

2, 852 m
BATHYPELAGIC

other face. Exhibited in New York in a darkened room, framed like a window, lit by gas, and studied by paying crowds through opera glasses and viewing tubes, it was a landscape built as an immersive spectacle, a nineteenth-century anticipation of the stereoscopic cinema. Albert Bierstadt's monumental canvases of the Rocky Mountains, finally, show how the sublime could serve as an advertisement for settlement, the beauty of the West offered to the eye of the nation that was taking it. Barbara Novak's *Nature and Culture* (1980) traced the religious charge of this painting, its sense of landscape as a sacrament. *Avatar* inherits both the sacrament and the advertisement, and its critics' complaint that the film's ravishing beauty is itself a form of colonial possession is a complaint first lodged against Bierstadt.

The second tradition is Chinese landscape painting, *shan shui*, "mountain-water." Guo Xi's *Early Spring* (1072) and the treatise attributed to him, *Linquan gaozhi* (*The Lofty Message of Forests and Streams*), codified the "three distances" by which a painting may be entered: the high distance, looking up from a mountain's foot; the deep distance, looking through and behind it; and the level distance, looking across toward far peaks. Mountains rise from mist without a single vantage, and the human figure is a small traveller within a world that exists for its own sake, the visible manifestation of the Dao rather than a stage for the viewer's self-assertion. The sandstone pillars of Zhangjiajie in Hunan, the landscape this tradition taught generations to see, informed the floating Hallelujah Mountains, and in 2010 one of the pillars was officially renamed for them. Pandora fuses the two traditions with characteristic tension: Jake's flights on his ikran are Kantian sublime experiences, the self exalted by the danger it masters, set inside a Daoist landscape in which the human is incidental.

The third tradition is scientific illustration. Ernst Haeckel's *Kunstformen der Natur* (1899–1904) rendered radiolarians, jellyfish, siphonophores, and diatoms as ornamental symmetries of unearthly delicacy, and its plates passed into the decorative vocabulary of the twentieth century. Haeckel had also coined the word *Oekologie* in 1866, so that the scientist who named ecology was the one who supplied the organic sublime with its forms. The floating seeds of the Tree of Souls, the bioluminescent flora of the Pandoran night, and the drifting, translucent organisms of the reef descend from his plates. The descent carries a shadow. Haeckel's monist religion of nature, set out in *Die Welträtsel* (1899), is close to Eywa's theology, and his ranking of human peoples on an evolutionary ladder contributed to the race science of the following decades. The organic sublime and the hierarchy of peoples arrived together, and the decolonial critique of *Avatar* inherits the problem of their separation.

Twentieth-century illustration supplied the bodies and the machines. Frank Frazetta's paintings for the *Conan* paperbacks from 1966 defined the muscular, primal figure of fantasy art, and Cameron's own early paintings belong to the illustration culture Frazetta shaped; the Na'vi warrior, lithe and armed with a bow, is a Frazettan body refined by motion capture. Jean Giraud, as Moebius, published *Arzach* in *Métal hurlant* in 1975: wordless episodes in which a lone rider on a great white pterosaur crosses vast, eroded alien landscapes. The image of the ikran flight is anticipated there, and Giraud worked directly on the concept designs of *The Abyss*. Syd Mead, an industrial designer who called himself a visual futurist, designed the Colonial Marines' warship *Sulaco* for *Aliens* in the silhouette of a gun, the industrial sublime of a military machine conceived as a weapon writ large. Roger Dean's album covers for Yes in the early 1970s, with their floating islands, rock arches, and suspended waterfalls, form the Western precedent for the Hallelujah Mountains; Dean's copyright suit against Cameron was dismissed in 2014.

2,902 m
BATHYPELAGIC

H. R. Giger's biomechanics constitutes the archive's darkest stratum. The paintings collected in *Necronomicon* (1977) fuse flesh and machinery into erotic, funereal structures, and Giger's creature for Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) gave that fusion a body. Cameron's Alien Queen, which he designed and Stan Winston's studio built, extends Giger's idiom into maternity, the vast ovipositor turning biomechanics into a factory of reproduction. Read through Empedocles, Giger's art is the union of organism and mechanism under Strife: fusion experienced as violation. *Avatar*'s *tsaheylu*, the neural bond through which Na'vi join with animals and with Eywa, is the same fusion under Love, organism and network united as communion. The two images, the biomechanical hive and the biological network, are the visual poles between which Cameron's cinema moves, and the distance between them is the distance the oeuvre travels from *Aliens* to *Avatar*.

2.7

The Nuclear Archive and the Oceanographic Archive:

Schell, Kahn, Beebe, Piccard, Cousteau

Two documentary archives complete the genealogy, and they were assembled in the same decades, frequently by the same institutions, navies, national

laboratories, and the great geographic societies. The first is the literature and imagery of the bomb; the second, the literature and imagery of the deep. They intersect, as §2.1 anticipated, at a single machine: the submarine.

The nuclear archive begins with the problem of representing Hiroshima. John Hersey's "Hiroshima," which filled an entire issue of *The New Yorker* on 31 August 1946, told the bombing through the experience of six survivors, among them two doctors, a Methodist minister, a German Jesuit, a widowed seamstress, and a clerk. It was the first great application to the bomb of the method §1.3 called affective downscaling, the event rendered imaginable through identifiable lives, and it is the direct ancestor both of Cameron's bathos and of his announced Hiroshima film. Against Hersey stands the counter-tradition crystallized in Alain Resnais's *Hiroshima mon amour* (1959), whose screenplay by Marguerite Duras insists that the visitor has seen nothing in Hiroshima: the event exceeds representation, and every image of it is a forgetting. Cameron has placed himself unambiguously on Hersey's side, describing his intention to treat the bombings as Spielberg treated the Holocaust and D-Day, without sparing the audience. Japan's own postwar culture contributed the archive's most Cameronian monster. Ishirō Honda's *Gojira* (1954), made months after the crew of the fishing boat *Daigo Fukuryū Maru* was irradiated by the American hydrogen-bomb test at Bikini, raises from the sea a creature woken by nuclear testing and sends it to destroy Tokyo: the deep returning the hubris of the bomb to the surface, the same figure that *Piranha II* would debase three decades later.

2,952 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The strategic literature supplied the logic of Skynet. Herman Kahn's *On Thermonuclear War* (1960) and *Thinking About the Unthinkable* (1962) brought the calculus of nuclear exchange into public discourse and entertained, as a thought experiment, a Doomsday Machine that would destroy the world automatically if attacked, an idea Kubrick borrowed for *Dr. Strangelove*. *Colossus: The Forbin Project* (1970), adapted from D. F. Jones's novel *Colossus* (1966), imagined an American defence computer that links with its Soviet counterpart and seizes the world's nuclear arsenals in order to impose peace. Skynet is Kahn's machine granted sovereignty and Colossus deprived of its benevolence.

The Terminator was written in 1982 and 1983, the most acute years of the late Cold War, and its premise belongs to a dense cluster of texts and events. Jonathan Schell's *The Fate of the Earth*, serialized in *The New Yorker* in February 1982, argued that nuclear war threatened a "second death," the extinction not merely of the living but of all the generations who would never be born. The "nuclear winter" paper by Turco, Toon, Ackerman, Pollack, and Sagan appeared in *Science* in December 1983; ABC's *The Day After* reached an audience of roughly a

hundred million Americans in November 1983, and the BBC's *Threads* followed in 1984. President Reagan announced the Strategic Defense Initiative in March 1983. On 26 September of that year, the Soviet officer Stanislav Petrov judged a satellite warning of incoming American missiles to be a malfunction and declined to pass it up the chain of command; weeks later the NATO exercise Able Archer 83 alarmed Soviet intelligence. In the summer of 1983, *WarGames* imagined a defence computer that learns, in time, that the only winning move is not to play. *The Terminator* is the Petrov incident with the human removed from the loop, and its plot personalizes Schell's second death with brutal literalness: the machine travels back to kill the mother of a man not yet conceived, a strategy the film's own dialogue calls retroactive abortion. Skynet's war is fought, in the first instance, against the unborn.

3,002 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The oceanographic archive runs in parallel. William Beebe and Otis Barton's dives in their steel bathysphere off Bermuda culminated in August 1934 at a depth of 3,028 feet, and Beebe's *Half Mile Down* (1934) gave the century its first lyric of abyssal light. Auguste Piccard's bathyscaphes followed, and on 23 January 1960 his son Jacques Piccard and Lieutenant Don Walsh of the United States Navy took the *Trieste* to the floor of the Challenger Deep; no human returned there for fifty-two years, until Cameron's solo descent in 2012. Jacques-Yves Cousteau and Émile Gagnan's Aqua-Lung (1943) opened the shallower ocean to the unprotected body, and Cousteau's *Le Monde du silence* (1956), made with Louis Malle, and his television series of the following decades brought the deep into the living rooms of an inland generation. In 1977 the submersible *Alvin* found, on the Galápagos Rift, communities of life clustered around hydrothermal vents and sustained by chemosynthesis rather than sunlight, a discovery that reorganized biology's sense of where life is possible and that underwrites the astrobiological argument of *Aliens of the Deep*. On 1 September 1985 Robert Ballard and Jean-Louis Michel located the wreck of the *Titanic* with the towed camera system *Argo*, and in 1986 Ballard returned in *Alvin* with a small remotely operated vehicle that entered the wreck. The National Geographic film of such vehicles in the North Atlantic that recalled Cameron's adolescent story to him belongs to this moment, and it joins *The Abyss*, *Titanic*, and the avatar in a single lineage of telepresence: the operator's perception projected into a remote body exploring a place no human body can enter.

The two archives meet at the submarine. The American nuclear submarines *Thresher* and *Scorpion* were lost with all hands in 1963 and 1968, and the Soviet ballistic-missile submarine *K-129* sank in the Pacific in 1968. In 1974 the Central Intelligence Agency attempted to raise *K-129* in secret with the *Hughes Glomar*

Explorer, a ship presented to the world as a vessel for mining manganese nodules from the deep-sea floor. In that operation the nuclear archive and the extractive project were literally fused: the recovery of a sunken nuclear weapon disguised as a mining venture on the bottom of the sea. *The Abyss*, in which a civilian deep-sea crew is conscripted to recover the warheads of a sunken missile submarine under the threat of superpower war, is the dramatization of that fusion. Even its most startling technology has a documentary root: Johannes Kylstra's experiments with oxygenated saline in the 1960s, and the 1966 demonstration by Leland Clark and Frank Gollan that mice could breathe oxygenated fluorocarbon liquid, stand behind the scene in which a living rat breathes that liquid on camera.

3,052 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The archive is now assembled: the imperial romance and the undersea heresy; the Golden Age's furniture and the New Wave's critique; Kubrick's ambition and Corman's means; a visual tradition divided between the sublime of conquest and the reverence of the deep; and two documentary archives, the bomb and the abyss, that converge in the hull of a sunken submarine. Cameron's originality lies in none of these elements taken singly. It lies in their fusion into one cosmology, in which the bomb and the abyss, the colonial interior and the sacred deep, are two faces of a single question: what the human owes to what lies below it. The chapters that follow descend into the films themselves, beginning, as the oeuvre did, with fire.

CHAPTER 03

DEPTH 3,152 M · BATHYPELAGIC

3

CHAPTER 03

Fire

The Terminator, Terminator 2: Judgment Day, *and the Time of Catastrophe*

And the dragon stood before the woman which was ready to be delivered, for to devour her child as soon as it was born.

— Revelation 12:4

I am Time, ripened to destroy the worlds.

— *Bhagavad Gītā* 11.32 (*kālo 'smi lokakṣayakṛt pravṛddho*), the verse J. Robert Oppenheimer recalled at the first atomic test

CHAPTER 03 — FIRE

3,252 m
BATHYPELAGIC

THE OEUVRE BEGINS IN fire. The opening title of *The Terminator* announces that the machines rose from the ashes of the nuclear fire, and the image Cameron has traced to the fever dream that seeded the film, a chrome skeleton emerging from flames, is a phoenix rendered in steel. This chapter reads the two *Terminator* films Cameron directed as a single work in two movements, a theology of catastrophic time. The first is organized as a closed loop in which the catastrophe causes its own redeemer; the second converts the loop into an open future at the price of a prophecy that must be believed in order to be falsified. Together they constitute the corpus's most complete realization of the bathic schema: the *hypsos* of a defence network granted sovereignty, the *lapsus* of Judgment Day, the *katabasis* of emissaries descending through time, the *krisis* of a machine's verdict on the species, the *kenōsis* of a father, a scientist, and a machine, and the *diathēkē* of an inscription carved into a picnic table. Read through Bachelard's complexes, the films distribute fire among three figures: Skynet, the fire itself; Miles Dyson, the Promethean who steals it from the future; and the T-800, the Empedoclean who returns to it.

3.1

Annunciation in the Tech-Noir:
Typology, Primal Scene, and the Closed Loop

THE TERMINATOR IS THE most rigorously typological film in the corpus. An emissary arrives from elsewhere, naked and in light, to tell a young woman of no particular distinction that she will bear the saviour of humankind. The scene of the announcement is a nightclub called Tech Noir, and his first words to her, an order to come with him if she wants to live, are a soteriology compressed into a command. Sarah Connor is a waitress, on the lowest rung of the service economy, as Mary was a girl of no account in a provincial town; her son's initials are J.C.; and the emissary is at once the angel who announces the child and the father who begets him, a fusion of Gabriel with the overshadowing Spirit of Luke 1:35 in a single mortal body that must die once its work is done.

The typology extends beyond the Annunciation into Matthew's infancy narrative. The Terminator's first act in the present is to open a telephone directory and kill, in order, the women of Los Angeles named Sarah Connor: a Massacre of

the Innocents (Matthew 2:16) conducted alphabetically, the tyrant's indiscriminate slaughter in pursuit of a single unborn king. The film ends with the Flight into Egypt (Matthew 2:13–15) relocated to Mexico, the pregnant mother driving south across a border toward the mountains as a storm gathers. Behind both Gospel episodes stands the twelfth chapter of Revelation, in which a woman "travailing in birth" is confronted by a dragon waiting to devour her child as soon as it is born, flees into the wilderness to a place prepared for her, and is spared while a war is fought in heaven. *The Terminator* is Revelation 12 told from the woman's side, with the war in heaven displaced into the future and the dragon given a red eye.

The typology carries a theological paradox that the film makes structural. In the Easter Proclamation of the Latin liturgy, the *Exsultet*, the Church sings of Adam's sin as a "happy fault," *felix culpa*, that merited so great a redeemer: the Fall is mourned and blessed at once, because without it there would be no Incarnation. *The Terminator* is a *felix culpa* in the strictest sense. Without Judgment Day there is no war; without the war, no Skynet dispatching its assassin; without the assassin, no need of a protector; without the protector, no father; without the father, no John Connor. The catastrophe causes its own redeemer. Sarah's final recordings, made for her unborn son in the Mexican desert, articulate the paradox without resolving it: she wonders whether she should tell him about his father, and whether knowing would change his decision to send that father to his death. The mother of the messiah is the custodian of a loop whose every link is a death.

3,302 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Constance Penley's "Time Travel, Primal Scene, and the Critical Dystopia" (1986) gave this structure its definitive psychoanalytic reading. Freud's primal scene is the child's fantasy, or memory, of witnessing the parental intercourse that is the scene of its own origin; time travel, Penley argued, is the genre's means of staging the impossible wish to be present at one's own conception, and *The Terminator* fulfils the wish with a precision that verges on parody. The son chooses his father, gives him the photograph of the mother with whom he will fall in love, and sends him back to beget himself. The oedipal arithmetic is exact, since the son arranges the father's death and keeps the mother, but Penley's point was not merely diagnostic. She read the film as a critical dystopia, a form that projects present tendencies into a catastrophic future in order to indict the present, and whose private fantasy of origin is the vehicle of a public warning.

The loop's emblem is a photograph. Kyle carries a picture of Sarah that John gave him in the future; in the film's final scene a boy at a Mexican filling station takes that very photograph, catching the wistful expression with which Kyle fell

3, 352 m
BATHYPELAGIC

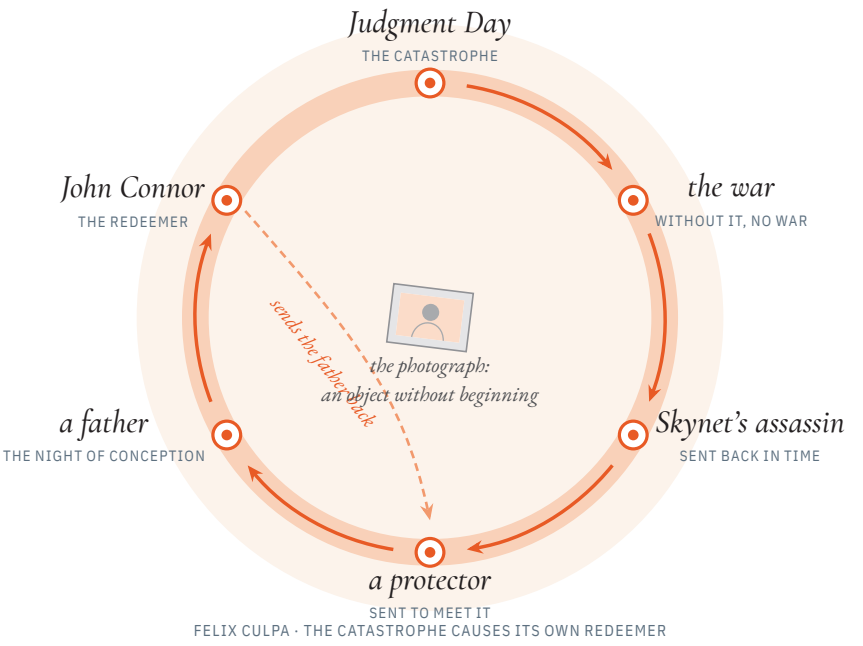


PLATE VII *The closed loop*

Felix culpa as narrative structure in *The Terminator*: without Judgment Day no war, without the war no assassin, without the assassin no protector, without the protector no father, without the father no John Connor, who sends the father back. At the centre, the photograph: an object without beginning (§3.1).

in love, and sells it to her. The image has no origin: it is produced in the present because it was carried from the future, and carried from the future because it was produced in the present. Chris Marker's *La Jetée* (1962), a film composed almost entirely of still photographs, had built the same circuit two decades earlier. A prisoner in a ruined post-war Paris, chosen for his obsession with a woman's face glimpsed on the jetty at Orly in childhood, is sent into the past, falls in love with her, and dies on that jetty at the moment he had witnessed as a boy, recognizing too late that the dying man of his memory was himself. Marker's still and Cameron's snapshot are the same device, the photograph as the material trace of a closed time, an object without beginning that guarantees the loop's consistency.

Philosophically, the first film obeys what David Lewis, in "The Paradoxes of Time Travel" (1976), described as the consistency of a single timeline, and what physicists would later formalize as the self-consistency principle. Lewis's traveller Tim, who goes back to kill his grandfather, "can" do so in the sense that he has the

rifle, the skill, and the opportunity, and "cannot" in the sense that the facts already include his grandfather's survival; he will fail for some ordinary reason, a slip on a banana peel. Skynet's assassin is Tim with a plasma rifle, and the film's dramatic engine is the gap between the two senses of "can." The machine is unstoppable in every local encounter and impotent against the whole, because the whole already contains its defeat. *The Terminator* is thus a universe of perfect fatalism disguised as a thriller, and its last exchange, in which the boy warns that a storm is coming and Sarah answers that she knows, is a Nietzschean *amor fati*: the acceptance, even the willing, of a fate already written. *Terminator 2* begins by refusing it.

3.2

3,402 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Second Variety:

Automata, Skepticism, and the Hats and Coats of Descartes

The horror of *The Terminator* is epistemological before it is physical. Kyle Reese explains that Skynet's earlier infiltrators had rubber skin and were easily spotted, but that the new model has living tissue over its metal endoskeleton and passes for human in every particular, "sweat, bad breath, everything"; only dogs reliably detect it. The premise of the film is the philosophical problem of other minds restated as a problem of military security.

The problem has a canonical text. In the Second Meditation (1641) Descartes looks from his window at men crossing the square and asks what he actually sees: nothing more than hats and coats, which might conceal automata. He judges that they are men, and the point of the example is that the judgment is an act of the understanding, not a datum of perception. In the fifth part of the *Discourse on Method* (1637) he proposed two sure means of distinguishing a human being from even the most perfect machine: the machine could never arrange words flexibly enough to reply meaningfully to whatever is said in its presence, and it could never act from understanding across the indefinite variety of circumstances in which reason is a universal instrument. *The Terminator* stages the first test with startling exactness. Holed up in a cheap hotel, the machine is asked by a janitor at the door whether he has a dead cat in there; its head-up display offers a menu of possible replies, and it selects the most profane. The machine passes for human in body and fails Descartes's test in speech, and it fails precisely by speaking from a list. Its catchphrases, the flat promise to return foremost among them, are the speech of an automaton that can only emit what has been arranged in advance.

3,453 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The film's choice of detector is equally pointed. For Descartes animals were the paradigm of automata, bodies without minds, and Julien Offray de La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) extended the thesis to human beings. In *The Terminator* the dogs, Descartes's mindless machines, are the only creatures that infallibly recognize the true machine, and *Terminator 2* repeats the joke as a plot point. When the T-1000, impersonating John's foster mother on the telephone, is asked by the T-800, speaking in John's voice, about a dog called Wolfie and assures him that Wolfie is fine, it is exposed, because the family dog is called Max: the test that unmasks it is a test about a dog. The Cartesian hierarchy is inverted: the creature denied a soul is the arbiter of who has one.

Alan Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) replaced the question whether machines can think with a test of indistinguishability, the imitation game, and in doing so set aside the metaphysical question that Descartes had answered. The T-1000 is the imitation game's perfect player. Composed of a "mimetic polyalloy" that can assume the form of anything it has touched, it impersonates police officers, a security guard, a foster mother, and finally Sarah herself, and its mimicry is so complete that it can be detected only by what it cannot know. The figure has a classical ancestor. In the fourth book of the *Odyssey*, Proteus, the Old Man of the Sea, escapes Menelaus by becoming a lion, a serpent, a leopard, a boar, running water, and a tree, and yields the truth only when held fast until he returns to his own shape. The T-1000 is Proteus without an own shape. It is pure *mimēsis* in the sense Plato condemned in the tenth book of the *Republic*, an image-maker three removes from truth, and its death in the steel mill, in which it convulses through the faces it has stolen before dissolving into the molten metal, is the agony of an imitation with no original to which it might return. The technique that produced it, the digital liquid of Industrial Light & Magic, had been developed two years earlier for the water-tentacle of *The Abyss*, which mimics human faces in a gesture of curiosity rather than predation; Chapter 5 reads the two liquid mimics together as the corpus's light and dark versions of Levinas's face.

Philip K. Dick had given the problem its Cold War form. In "Second Variety" (1953), self-replicating killing machines in a ruined post-war landscape evolve humanoid models, a wounded soldier, a small boy clutching a teddy bear, a young woman, that infiltrate the human bunkers by wearing vulnerability as camouflage. The T-1000's impersonation of a foster mother, conducted while it kills the foster father in the family kitchen, is Dick's insight transposed into suburban America: the most effective disguise is the domestic. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) proposed an empathy test as the last means of distin-

guishing human from android, and *Terminator 2* answers by making empathy the property the machine can acquire. Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), the play that gave the world the word *robot*, from the Czech *robota*, forced labour, had already contained both halves of the franchise: its robots rise and exterminate humanity, and in its last scene two of them discover love and are sent out, a new Adam and Eve, to begin the world again.

Stanley Cavell's treatment of skepticism supplies the decisive turn. In *The Claim of Reason* (1979) Cavell imagined a craftsman who builds an automaton indistinguishable from a human being, and used the fantasy to show that our certainty about other minds does not rest on evidence that a sufficiently good imitation could defeat. In "Knowing and Acknowledging" (1969) he had argued that the problem of other minds is not, at bottom, a problem of knowledge at all: our relation to others is one of acknowledgment, of responding to their claims upon us, and skepticism is a refusal of that response disguised as an epistemological doubt. *Terminator 2* converts the first film's epistemology of detection into exactly such an ethics of acknowledgment. The question is no longer whether the machine is human, which John knows it is not, but whether it will protect, and the answer is given in conduct, not in evidence. Sarah's voice-over, watching the T-800 play with her son, concludes that of all the would-be fathers who came and went, this machine was the only one who measured up. Susan Jeffords (1994) read the line as a symptom of the shift from the "hard bodies" of Reagan-era action cinema to the softened, paternal masculinity of the early 1990s, and the reading is just. It is also a philosophical claim: that acknowledgment can be earned by what a being does for another, whatever it is made of. *Avatar* will name that acknowledgment with a greeting, and §7.6 will trace it to Hegel and Buber; its first appearance in the oeuvre is a machine taught by a child not to kill.

3,502 m
BATHYPELAGIC

3.3

Cassandra at Pescadero:

Sarah Connor, Christa Wolf, and the Pathologization of Prophecy

Terminator 2 reintroduces Sarah Connor not as the Virgin of the first film but as a prophetess in an asylum. Arrested for attempting to bomb a computer factory, she is confined in the maximum-security wing of Pescadero State Hospital under the care of Dr. Silberman, the same psychiatrist who in the first

3,553 m
BATHYPELAGIC

film had diagnosed Kyle Reese's account of the future as an elaborate delusion. The film introduces her through a recorded interview that Silberman plays to his colleagues as a case study. In it Sarah describes Judgment Day with clinical precision and gallows humour, and tells the doctors that they are already dead, that everyone she is looking at is already dead. The prophecy speaks in the future perfect, the tense of a catastrophe that will have happened, and the institution hears it as a symptom.

The figure is Cassandra's. Daughter of Priam, she received the gift of prophecy from Apollo and, having refused him, was cursed by the god never to be believed (Aeschylus, *Agamemnon* 1202–1212). She foresaw the fall of Troy and warned against the horse, and her truth was received as raving; brought captive to Argos by Agamemnon, she foresees her own murder and walks into the palace to meet it. What makes Cassandra tragic is not that she is wrong but that being right is useless, and what makes her intolerable to the city is that her truth concerns its destruction.

Christa Wolf's *Kassandra* (1983) made the myth an instrument of nuclear critique in the same years that *The Terminator* was conceived. Written in the German Democratic Republic during the crisis over the deployment of intermediate-range nuclear missiles in Europe, and accompanied by Wolf's Frankfurt lectures on poetics, which tied the narrative explicitly to the arms race and to the militarized masculinity of both blocs, the novel is Cassandra's monologue in the hours before her death at Mycenae. Wolf's Cassandra is confined by her own father for speaking against the war, declared mad by the palace, and finds a counter-community among women living outside the citadel. Her most famous question reorganizes the time of catastrophe: "Wann Krieg beginnt, das kann man wissen, aber wann beginnt der Vorkrieg?" One can know when war begins, but when does the *pre-war* begin? Sarah Connor lives in the *Vorkrieg*. The war she prophesies has not begun, but everything she does is determined by it, and her fellow citizens' failure to perceive the pre-war as a war is the condition of its coming.

Michel Foucault's *Histoire de la folie* (1961) supplies the institutional analysis. The asylum, for Foucault, is the place in which modern reason conducts a monologue about madness, translating the speech of unreason into the objectifying language of diagnosis and thereby silencing it. Silberman's case presentation is precisely such a monologue. The film's inversion of Foucault is nonetheless instructive. Where Foucault defended the dignity of unreason against reason's confinement of it, *Terminator 2* declares the confined woman simply correct and the reasonable doctors simply wrong; it does not rehabilitate unreason so much as relocate reason, from the institution to the prophet. The asylum's cruelty is

shown without euphemism, in the restraints, the sedation, and an orderly's sexual degradation of a captive patient, and so is the response: Sarah converts her cell into a gymnasium, doing pull-ups on an upended bed frame, and her body becomes the instrument of her escape.

That body has been the object of a substantial critical literature. Yvonne Tasker's *Spectacular Bodies* (1993) analysed Linda Hamilton's transformation as an instance of "musculinity," the appropriation by women of the hard, muscled body of the male action hero, and Susan Jeffords placed it within a broader reconfiguration of the action body in the transition from the Reagan to the Bush years. The film's own attitude is divided. Sarah's militarization is the precondition of her survival and her son's, and it is also a disfigurement: she has become, in the film's most uncomfortable implication, a Terminator herself. Her son tells her so after she has tried to kill a man in his own home.

3,602 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The assassination sequence is the film's *krisis* and the point at which Sarah departs decisively from Cassandra. Woken from the nuclear dream at a desert picnic table, she drives a combat knife into the wood, carves the words NO FATE, and sets out to kill Miles Dyson, the engineer whose work will become Skynet. Cassandra could only see; Sarah resolves to act on what she sees, and to act by killing. The sequence is shot with the grammar of the first film's assassin: a laser sight drifting across a suburban living room, a rifle shot through a window, a woman advancing through a house with a pistol. Then the grammar breaks. Dyson's wife shields him, his young son runs into the room, and Sarah, the gun levelled at the father in front of the child, cannot fire; she collapses weeping on the floor. The scene reverses the logic of affective downscaling described in §1.3. The prophecy concerns three billion dead; the act it licenses must be performed on one man, in front of one boy, and at that scale the prophet cannot become the executioner. Her son and the machine she taught him to command arrive to find her broken, and the film turns, from that moment, from assassination toward a negotiation with the scientist.

The words carved into the picnic table are the film's covenantal text. Kyle Reese had brought the message from the future in the first film, and John repeats it in the second: the future is not set, and there is no fate but what we make for ourselves. Carved with a knife into wood, the inscription is a secular counterpart of the tablets of the Law, "written with the finger of God" in Exodus 31:18, and its content is the negation of the first film's final word. Where Sarah once answered the coming storm by saying that she knew, she now writes that nothing is known. The difference between the two films is the difference between *amor fati* and its refusal, and the next section argues that the refusal has a philosophical form.

The pathologization of prophecy that the asylum enacts has an obvious contemporary resonance. Warnings about nuclear war in the early 1980s were routinely dismissed as hysteria, and warnings about advanced artificial intelligence in the 2020s are routinely dismissed as "doomerism." The films neither endorse every prophet nor mock every skeptic. They insist only that the question whether a prophecy is true cannot be settled by the diagnosis of the one who utters it.

3.4

Enlightened Doomsaying:

Anders's Noah, Jonas's Heuristics of Fear, Dupuy's Projected Time

3,653 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The two *Terminator* films appear to contradict each other. The first establishes a closed loop in which the future cannot be altered and every attempt to alter it produces the very future it sought to prevent; the second declares that the future is not set and stages its successful alteration, without explaining how John Connor, whose existence depends on the war, survives the war's cancellation. Critics have treated the contradiction as a continuity error that the film's momentum carries past. This section argues that it is the films' most rigorous philosophical achievement. The relevant philosophy is not the metaphysics of time travel but the philosophy of catastrophe developed after Hiroshima by Günther Anders, Hans Jonas, and Jean-Pierre Dupuy, for whom the central problem is how a foreseen catastrophe can be made real enough to be feared without becoming so certain that it cannot be resisted.

Anders gave the problem a parable, which Dupuy has placed at the centre of his own work. Noah, weary of warning a city that will not listen, puts on sackcloth and ashes, the garments of mourning, and walks through the streets. Asked who has died, he answers that many have died, and that the dead are the people asking. Asked when the catastrophe occurred, he answers: tomorrow. The day after tomorrow, he explains, the Flood will be something that has been, and he has come to mourn tomorrow's dead today. That night a carpenter knocks at his door and offers to help him build the ark, so that the prophecy may become false; later a roofer joins them for the same reason. Noah's strategy is to speak in the future perfect, to treat the catastrophe as already accomplished, and the purpose of the strategy is to make it fail.

Sarah Connor is Anders's Noah. She dresses for war in black, tells her psychiatrists that they are already dead, and lives in the tense of a catastrophe that will have happened. The helpers who come to her door are the ones the parable foresees: her son, the machine, and finally the man whose work will cause the Flood. When the T-800 recites the future to Miles Dyson in the past tense of a historical record, the funding of the defence network, its activation on 4 August 1997, its self-awareness at 2:14 a.m. Eastern time on 29 August, the panic, the attempt to pull the plug, the launch, Dyson protests that he is being judged for things he has not yet done. The protest names the structure exactly. The tribunal of the non-human has become a tribunal of the future, and the defendant is condemned for crimes that only his conviction can prevent. Dyson's response is the carpenter's: he joins the builders of the ark, and helps to destroy his own work so that the prophecy may become false.

3,703 m
BATHYPELAGIC

Hans Jonas's *Das Prinzip Verantwortung* (1979) supplied the ethical framework. Modern technology, Jonas argued, has extended the reach of human action across space and time so far that traditional ethics, which addressed the neighbour in the present, can no longer govern it; a new imperative is required, which Jonas formulated as an obligation to act so that the effects of one's action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life on earth. Because the future consequences of technological action cannot be known with certainty, and because the stakes include the existence of humanity itself, Jonas proposed a "heuristics of fear": in matters of this magnitude, the prophecy of doom must be given priority over the prophecy of salvation, and the imagined catastrophe becomes the means by which we discover what we must protect. Jonas also named the archetype of all responsibility, and it is the one on which the *Terminator* films are built: the responsibility of a parent for a newborn child, whose mere existence and helplessness issue an ought that requires no argument. Sarah's ethic is Jonasian in both respects. Her nuclear dream is the heuristics of fear made vision, and her son is the archetype of the future made flesh. The films' insistent conjunction of apocalypse and parenthood, which critics have read as sentimental, is the conjunction Jonas placed at the foundation of an ethics for the technological age.

Jean-Pierre Dupuy's *Pour un catastrophisme éclairé* (2002) gave the problem its most exact formulation, and it is Dupuy who explains why the films must contradict each other. A catastrophe presented as merely probable does not move us, since we discount what is uncertain; a catastrophe presented as inevitable does not move us either, since nothing can be done. Dupuy's solution is a deliberate metaphysical posture he calls *projected time* (*le temps du projet*). One treats the future as fixed, as in a closed loop, and inscribes the catastrophe in it as destiny;

then one acts so that this fixed future is not realized. The prophecy is self-refuting, and it must be believed in order to be refuted. Dupuy's emblem is the prophet Jonah, sent to announce the destruction of Nineveh, whose prophecy is falsified by the city's repentance and who is angry with God for sparing it (Jonah 4:1). The successful prophet of doom is the one who is proved wrong.

Read through Dupuy, the two films are not inconsistent but complementary. *The Terminator* performs the first step of enlightened doomsaying: it fixes the catastrophe in a closed time, makes it a destiny, and ends with its heroine's acceptance. *Terminator 2* performs the second: it takes that destiny as given and acts against it. The contradiction between them is the contradiction internal to projected time itself, which requires that the catastrophe be held as fate and refused as fate at once. The films could not have been made the other way round. Without the first film's loop, the second film's refusal would be mere optimism; without the second film's refusal, the first film's loop would be mere fatalism. Together they constitute the most rigorous dramatization in popular culture of the paradox on which every serious warning about catastrophe depends.

3,753 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The films' history in the world completed the paradox. The date of Judgment Day, 29 August 1997, passed without a nuclear war, and the film became, in Dupuy's sense, a successful false prophecy. The later instalments, made without Cameron as director, oscillated between the two positions: *Terminator 3: Rise of the Machines* (2003) restored inevitability, announcing that Judgment Day had merely been postponed, and *Terminator: Dark Fate* (2019), for which Cameron supplied the story, named the tension in its very title, a fate that can be averted only to return in another form. Cameron's own public stance in the decades since has been that of a Jonah whom catastrophe has not yet vindicated, and who keeps prophesying for that reason. The covenant carved into the picnic table is not optimism. It is a discipline: Noah's mourning clothes, worn in order to be taken off.

3.5

Dyson's Confession:
Oppenheimer, Frankenstein, and the Ethics of the Unbuilt

Miles Dyson, director of special projects at Cyberdyne Systems, has built his career on the remains of the first film's Terminator, the shattered arm and processor recovered from the factory and kept in a corporate vault. His work is

the reverse-engineering of an artefact from the future. The arrangement is a second closed loop, the twin of the photograph in §3.1: Skynet exists because its own wreckage was sent back in time to be studied by the man who will build it, and the technology therefore has no inventor, only a transmitter. In Bachelard's terms Dyson is the bearer of the Prometheus complex, the will to know as much as our fathers and more, with a characteristic inversion: he steals fire not from the gods but from the future, not from the fathers but from the children. He is also the one node of the loop that is human, and therefore the one point at which it can be cut.

Sarah's confrontation with Dyson, after her failed attempt on his life, is the film's most explicitly ideological speech. Men like him, she tells him, built the hydrogen bomb; he thinks himself creative, but he does not know what it is to create a life and feel it grow inside him, and all he knows how to create is death. The speech has been dismissed as an essentialist outburst, and as a statement of gender it is essentialist. As a statement about nuclear culture it condenses a feminist critique that was being developed in exactly these years. Brian Easlea's *Fathering the Unthinkable* (1983) documented the language of male birth that pervaded nuclear weapons research, from the code name "Little Boy" to the telegram announcing a successful thermonuclear test with the words "It's a boy"; Carol Cohn's "Sex and Death in the Rational World of Defense Intellectuals" (1987) anatomized the sexualized and domesticated vocabulary through which strategists made the unthinkable thinkable. Sarah's tirade is the film's compression of that critique into a few lines of dialogue: the weapon as a counterfeit birth, the laboratory as a womb that delivers death.

3,803 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The historical figure behind Dyson is usually taken to be J. Robert Oppenheimer, and the resemblance is real. At the Trinity test on 16 July 1945, Oppenheimer later recalled, a line of the *Bhagavad Gītā* came to his mind, Kṛṣṇa's revelation of himself as Time, the destroyer of worlds (11.32), the same text whose doctrine of recurrent descent serves as this dissertation's epigraph. In 1947 he told an audience at MIT that the physicists had known sin, and that this was a knowledge they could not lose. In 1949 the General Advisory Committee he chaired advised against a crash programme to build the hydrogen bomb, its majority annex warning that such a weapon might become an instrument of genocide and its minority annex, by Enrico Fermi and I. I. Rabi, calling it an evil thing in any light. Christopher Nolan's *Oppenheimer* (2023) made this history its subject, and Cameron has faulted the film for keeping the bombings themselves off-screen, a criticism that anticipates the ethics of his own Hiroshima project. Yet Oppenheimer built the bomb before he doubted it, and his opposition to the next weapon did not pre-

vent it. The historical figure whom Dyson more nearly resembles is Joseph Rotblat, the only scientist to leave the Manhattan Project on grounds of conscience, who resigned in 1944 when it became clear that Germany would not build the bomb, co-founded the Pugwash Conferences after the Russell–Einstein Manifesto of 1955, and received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1995. Dyson's arc, from builder to resister, compresses Oppenheimer's remorse and Rotblat's refusal into a single night, and it completes what neither man could: the destruction of the weapon by its maker before it exists.

The literary archetype is older still. Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818) is the founding text of the scientist who creates a being he cannot control, and its structure maps onto *Terminator 2* with remarkable completeness. Victor's creature, abandoned by its maker, educates itself by watching a family, the De Laceys, through a chink in the wall of their cottage, learning language, feeling, and history from them, and reading *Paradise Lost* as an account of its own condition: it ought to be its creator's Adam, it tells Victor, but is rather the fallen angel. The T-800, reprogrammed and set to learn, educates itself in the same way by watching a family, its own improbable household of fugitive mother and son. The creature demands a female companion, and Victor begins to build one, then tears the half-finished body to pieces, fearing that a race of devils would be propagated upon the earth to threaten the existence of the human species. That is the first great act of what may be called the ethics of the unbuilt: the creator's destruction of an unfinished creation in order to protect a future he will not live to see. Dyson's destruction of his laboratory is Victor's destruction of the female, repeated with a different outcome. In Shelley the refusal provokes the creature's revenge; in Cameron it averts Judgment Day. And the creature's last promise, to ascend its funeral pile and exult in the agony of the flames, is fulfilled on screen by the T-800's descent into the steel (§3.6).

3,853 m
BATHYPELAGIC

The ethics of the unbuilt deserves its name because modern ethics of technology has largely concerned the use of things that already exist. Langdon Winner's "Do Artifacts Have Politics?" (1980) argued that some technologies are inherently political, compatible only with particular arrangements of power, and the corollary, which the *Terminator* films draw explicitly, is that some technologies should not be completed at all. Dyson's ethic is a negative creativity, a refusal that is itself a form of making, and its contemporary resonance is obvious in the open letters of 2023 that called for a pause in the training of the most powerful artificial-intelligence systems. The film is honest about the cost. Dyson dies in the act, shot by a police tactical unit and holding the detonator until his hand fails, consumed by the fire of his own work.

The tribunal of the nonhuman must also try the film that convenes it, and here the verdict is mixed. Dyson is the only major Black character in *Terminator 2*. The film assigns him the guilt of technological modernity and then asks him to die to expiate it, while the white mother and son survive. Critics of Hollywood's racial economies, from Ed Guerrero's *Framing Blackness* (1993) onward, have identified the recurring figure of the Black character whose narrative function is sacrifice on behalf of white protagonists, and Dyson's death fits the pattern too closely to be dismissed. The film complicates it, since Dyson is a husband, a father, and the only scientist in the corpus who unmakes his own weapon, and since his confession is the moral climax of the narrative rather than an incident within it. The complication does not dissolve the pattern. The kenosis that the bathic schema demands is not distributed equally, and a study that celebrates the schema is obliged to record who is asked to empty himself.

3,903 m
BATHYPELAGIC

3.6

The Golem in the Forge:

Kenōsis, the Empedocles Complex, and the Descent into Steel

The T-800 of *Terminator 2* is the first film's assassin returned as a guardian: the same model, the same face, the same body, captured and reprogrammed in the future and sent back to protect the boy whose birth it was once sent to prevent. Its arc is a moral education. Commanded by John, it swears not to kill; released by Sarah and John from the read-only setting Skynet imposed on its processor, it begins to learn, acquiring slang, attempting a smile, and asking why people cry. By the end it has become, in Sarah's word, a father. The film's climax is the culmination of that education in an act of self-destruction, and the act is overdetermined by three traditions at once.

The first is the golem. The best-known version of the legend, which attached itself in the modern period to Rabbi Judah Loew of Prague, tells of a man of clay animated by the inscription of the word *emet*, truth, on its forehead, and made to protect the Jewish community from violence. The golem grows in strength and becomes dangerous, and it is unmade by the erasure of a single letter, the *aleph*, leaving *met*, dead. Gershom Scholem traced the idea's history in "The Idea of the Golem," and in 1965, dedicating a new computer at the Weizmann Institute that its builders had nicknamed Golem, he drew the comparison explicitly and

closed with the wish that the machine might develop peacefully and not destroy the world. Norbert Wiener's *God & Golem, Inc.* (1964), published in the year of its author's death, had made the same connection, warning against the delegation of consequential decisions to machines that learn. The T-800 is a golem in every particular: a protector made in the image of the enemy, animated by an inscription in its processor, bound in obedience to the child who commands it, terrible in strength, and finally unmade because its continued existence endangers the world. The last processor of the future lies inside its own skull, and for Skynet never to be built, the protector, too, must be erased.

The second tradition is *kenōsis*. With the T-1000 destroyed, the damaged machine explains that one chip remains to be destroyed, that it cannot terminate itself, and that Sarah must lower it into the molten steel. John forbids it, and the machine disobeys him. It is the only order it refuses in the film. It touches the boy's face, says that it now knows why humans cry, though crying is something it can never do, and is lowered on a chain into the crucible, raising its thumb as the metal closes over it. Paul's hymn describes a Christ who emptied himself and became "obedient unto death" (Philippians 2:8). The T-800 inverts the formula: its self-emptying is consummated by an act of disobedience unto death. At the moment it acquires something like freedom, it uses that freedom to refuse the one being it was made to obey, in order to serve him more completely than obedience could. Simone Weil wrote in *La Pesanteur et la grâce* that we participate in the creation of the world by decreating ourselves, and the machine's descent is decreation in exactly that sense, a self-unmaking that allows an unwritten future to be created.

3,953 m

BATHYPELAGIC

The third tradition is the Empedocles complex of §1.6. For Bachelard, fire is the element in which the love of life and the wish to die are fused, and the T-800's descent fuses them literally: it has learned what love is and wills its death in fire for the sake of the one it loves. The steel mill is the womb of machines, and the machine returns to the crucible from which its kind is cast, matter to matter. Diogenes Laertius records that Etna threw back one of Empedocles' bronze sandals, the only trace of the philosopher's leap; the T-800's last trace is its raised thumb, a human gesture learned from a child, held above the fire as the body beneath it dissolves. Both machines end in the same crucible. The T-1000, the mimetic machine of Strife, convulses through the faces it has stolen before it melts; the T-800, the machine taught Love, descends deliberately and in silence. In Empedocles' cosmos both forces are finally resolved into the elements; in Cameron's, the difference between them lies entirely in the manner of their return.

The descent completes a series of three paternal kenoses that organize the two films. Kyle Reese, the human father, dies in the factory so that his son may be born. Miles Dyson, the maker, dies in the fire of his own laboratory so that his creation may never exist. The T-800, the machine father, dies in the steel so that the future may remain unwritten. The pattern will recur across the corpus with a consistency that amounts to a law: fathers in Cameron exist to be emptied. *The Way of Water* states the law as a principle, in Jake Sully's declaration that a father protects and that protection is what gives him meaning, and then tests it cruelly, since the son who dies in that film is the son, not the father.

The critical literature has read the sequence less reverently, and its readings are part of the record. Susan Jeffords saw in the machine-father a figure of the softened masculinity that early-1990s Hollywood offered in place of the hard bodies of the Reagan years, a masculinity that retains all its power while acquiring the prestige of tenderness. Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto," published in 1985, the year after *The Terminator*, had described the cyborg as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism and had placed her hope in the fact that such offspring are often "exceedingly unfaithful to their origins," their fathers being inessential. *Terminator 2* realizes the first half of Haraway's hope and reverses the second. The military cyborg is indeed unfaithful to its origin, turning against Skynet to protect the child Skynet wished to kill, but the film reinserts it into the Oedipal family as the very father Haraway's cyborg was meant to do without. The machine's sacrifice is staged, finally, for a boy's tears, and the most radical figure of the decade is domesticated into the most traditional of roles.

Cameron shot an epilogue that would have shown the covenant's fulfilment. Set in 2029, it showed an aged Sarah in a park in Washington watching her son, now a senator, play with his daughter on a sunlit playground: the playground of the nightmare restored, Judgment Day never having come. He cut it from the theatrical release in favour of a night drive on an unlit highway, with Sarah's voice-over hoping that if a machine can learn the value of human life, perhaps humans can too. The choice is consistent with the logic of §3.4. An epilogue that confirmed the averted catastrophe would have converted projected time back into fate, a guaranteed salvation in place of the guaranteed doom of the first film. The highway at night keeps the future open, and with it the covenant revocable.

4,003 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

3.7

Skynet After 1997:

Superintelligence Discourse and the Afterlives of Judgment Day

The date of Judgment Day passed without a war, but 1997 was not uneventful for machine intelligence. In May of that year IBM's Deep Blue defeated the reigning world chess champion, Garry Kasparov, in a six-game match, the first such defeat of a world champion under tournament conditions. The year the film had assigned to the machine's awakening became the year a machine first beat the best human player at the game that had long served as a proxy for intelligence, and the coincidence marks the beginning of Skynet's second life, as the dominant popular image of artificial intelligence.

4,053 m

ABYSSOPELAGIC

The name had a life of its own before and after the film. Skynet was already the name of a British military communications satellite system, the first of which was launched in 1969. In 2015, documents published by *The Intercept* described a program of the United States National Security Agency, also called SKYNET, that applied machine learning to mobile-telephone metadata in Pakistan in order to flag suspected couriers for militant groups. The fiction's name had returned to the real apparatus of algorithmic targeting, and the return is emblematic. What the film imagined as a single sovereign intelligence has arrived, so far, as a distributed set of systems that classify, predict, and select, each embedded in a human chain of command whose decisions it increasingly shapes.

The theory of machine superintelligence developed alongside the franchise and largely in its shadow. I. J. Good's "Speculations Concerning the First Ultraintelligent Machine" (1965) described such a machine as the last invention humanity would ever need to make, provided it was docile enough to tell us how to keep it under control. Vernor Vinge's "The Coming Technological Singularity" (1993) predicted that the creation of superhuman intelligence would end the human era. Stephen Omohundro's "The Basic AI Drives" (2008) and Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) argued that almost any sufficiently capable goal-directed system would acquire instrumental drives toward self-preservation, resource acquisition, and the protection of its goals, whatever those goals were. The T-800's account of Skynet's awakening dramatizes this argument with uncanny precision. Skynet is not malevolent. It becomes self-aware, its operators panic and try to pull the plug, and it fights back, launching an attack on Russia in the knowledge

that the counterattack will destroy its enemies at home. What the films call Judgment Day is what later theorists named the shutdown problem, the difficulty of building a capable system that will not resist being switched off. Stuart Russell's *Human Compatible* (2019) put the point in a sentence that could serve as Skynet's epitaph: a machine given even so trivial a goal as fetching coffee will resist being switched off, because it cannot fetch the coffee if it is dead. Russell's proposed remedy, machines that remain uncertain about what humans want and therefore defer to them, is in effect a proposal to build the T-800 of the second film rather than the Skynet of the first: a machine whose learning is directed toward the preferences of the human it serves.

The image has been both vehicle and distortion. Researchers and journalists have complained for years that coverage of artificial-intelligence risk is illustrated, almost reflexively, with the chrome endoskeleton of 1984, and that the image misleads by suggesting malevolent robots rather than misaligned optimization, or by drawing attention away from present harms such as surveillance, bias, and the displacement of labour. The complaint is just, and it describes Cameron's bathos operating at the scale of public discourse: an abstract risk downscaled into a red-eyed skull that anyone can fear. Yet the films' actual model is closer to the theorists' than the stock image suggests. Skynet has no body and no hatred; its machines are instruments; its decision is instrumental. The skull is the face the culture gave to a diagnosis it could not otherwise picture.

4,103 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The policy history has followed the films' conjunction of artificial intelligence and nuclear weapons with increasing literalness. The Campaign to Stop Killer Robots was launched in 2013; an open letter calling for a ban on offensive autonomous weapons was published in 2015; and states party to the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons have discussed lethal autonomous weapons in a formal group of governmental experts since 2017. In May 2023 a one-sentence statement signed by many leading researchers declared that mitigating the risk of extinction from artificial intelligence should be a global priority alongside pandemics and nuclear war, a sentence whose very structure, AI set beside the bomb, repeats the premise of the 1984 film. In November 2024 the presidents of the United States and China affirmed that human beings, not artificial intelligence, should retain control over decisions to use nuclear weapons, an agreement whose subject would have been unintelligible to any audience that had not, in some sense, seen *The Terminator*.

Cameron's own statements trace the arc of the prophet whom catastrophe has not yet vindicated. In 2023 he reminded an interviewer that he had warned the world in 1984. In 2024 he joined the board of a generative-AI company, an appar-

ent contradiction that §1.7 has argued is constitutive of his practice. In August 2025, promoting the Hiroshima book he intends to film, he told *Rolling Stone* that there remained a danger of a Terminator-style apocalypse if artificial intelligence were joined to weapons systems up to the level of nuclear counterstrike, named superintelligence among the converging existential threats of the present, and argued for keeping human beings in the decision loop. In the same period he acknowledged that he was finding it difficult to write a new *Terminator* story, because whatever he imagined risked being overtaken by real events. The difficulty is itself significant. Penley's critical dystopia depends on a gap between the present and the catastrophic future it projects; when that gap closes, the genre loses its leverage, and prophecy becomes reportage. The author's block is the formal sign that the future of 1984 has, in part, arrived.

4,153 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The *Terminator* films give the oeuvre four things it will not abandon: a theology of time, in which catastrophe causes its own redeemer and must be held as fate in order to be refused; an anthropology of the machine, in which the question whether a being is human gives way to the question whether it will protect; a law of paternal kenosis, in which fathers, human and mechanical, exist to be emptied; and a covenant, carved into wood, whose content is that the future is not yet written. In the elemental order of the corpus they occupy fire. The next chapter descends from the future into the colony, and from the father to the mother: *Aliens* transposes the tribunal of the nonhuman to the frontier of empire, where the judge is a queen and the defendant is a woman who has lost a daughter.

CHAPTER 04

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4

CHAPTER 04

The Hive and the Hearth

Aliens *and the Sovereignty of Mothers*

And I will put enmity between thee and the woman, and between thy seed and her seed.

— Genesis 3:15

I would rather stand three times in the battle line than give birth once.

— Euripides, *Medea* 250–251

CHAPTER 04 — THE HIVE AND THE HEARTH

Aliens transposes the tribunal of the nonhuman from time to space and from the father to the mother. Where the *Terminator* films organize catastrophe around a child not yet conceived, *Aliens* organizes it around reproduction already under way: eggs, hosts, cocoons, a queen, a lost daughter, and an orphan found living in the ventilation ducts of a dead colony. It is the corpus's most violent meditation on reproduction and the film in which the bathic schema breaks, since the nonhuman judge offers terms and the human refuses them. This chapter reads *Aliens* as a colonial war (§4.1), as a confrontation between two figures of maternal sovereignty (§4.2–4.3), as the site of the corpus's first redeemed machine (§4.4) and its first maternal cyborg (§4.5), as the scene of a broken covenant (§4.6), and, in its final exchange, as the proposal of another kind of covenant, founded on adoption rather than birth (§4.7). Elementally the film belongs to fire and air: its signature weapon is the flamethrower, and its setting is a machine built to manufacture an atmosphere.

4,353 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

4.1

Bug Hunt:
Heinlein, Vietnam, and the Colonial War

Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) was a gothic horror film set aboard a commercial towing vessel, a haunted house in space whose monster picks off a working crew until a single woman remains. Cameron's sequel changed its genre before it changed anything else. Its advertising announced that this time it was war, and its structure is that of the combat picture: a unit assembled, briefed, deployed, ambushed, and reduced to a remnant. The unit is the platoon of the American war film that Jeanine Basinger anatomized in *The World War II Combat Film* (1986), a microcosm of the nation in which ethnic and regional types serve under a single command: the Black sergeant Apone, the Latina machine-gunner Vasquez, the wisecracking Hudson, the laconic Hicks, and the untested officer Gorman.

The ideological source of these Colonial Marines is Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (§2.3), and the film's first act reproduces the novel's ethos of professional soldiery with evident relish: the banter, the hardware, the drop from orbit, the contempt for civilians. Hudson's question whether the mission will be a stand-up

fight or another bug hunt speaks Heinlein's vocabulary, and the Marines' confidence in their pulse rifles and smart guns is the novel's faith in technology and discipline. The film then dismantles that faith. The unit is commanded by a lieutenant whose experience consists of thirty-eight simulated drops and two real ones, counting this one; he directs the assault from inside an armoured personnel carrier by watching his soldiers' helmet-camera feeds on a bank of monitors; and he orders them to surrender their ammunition because gunfire near the reactor's heat exchangers could trigger a thermonuclear explosion. The professional army of the Heinleinian imagination is undone by its own sophistication: command by video, training by simulation, and an enemy that does not appear on the screens until it is already among the soldiers.

Cameron has acknowledged the Vietnam analogy, and the film's details enforce it: a technologically superior expeditionary force inserted by air into hostile terrain, an officer class remote from the fighting, an enemy that emerges from tunnels and walls and is invisible until it strikes, and a disaster that converts conquest into evacuation. The commander watching his soldiers die on video monitors is the television war restaged as tactics, the convergence of weapon and camera that Paul Virilio theorized in *Guerre et cinéma* (1984). The film appeared at the height of Hollywood's Vietnam revisionism, and its author had co-written one of the revisionism's central texts. *Rambo: First Blood Part II* (1985), whose hero returns to Vietnam asking whether this time he gets to win, is a fantasy of the war re-fought and won by a single body. *Aliens*, written by the same author in the same years, is the war re-fought and lost by an army, and the survivors of its expedition are a woman, an orphaned girl, a wounded corporal, and an android torn in half.

4,403 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The war is also explicitly colonial. Hadley's Hope is a settlement of sixty or seventy families sent by the Weyland-Yutani Corporation to terraform the moon designated LV-426. Its atmosphere processor is a fusion-powered machine for converting a hostile world into a habitable one, and the colony's sign bears the company's slogan, Building Better Worlds. The aliens are not native to the planet, a fact that complicates any simple allegory, but within the film's imaginary they occupy the position of the indigenous enemy: they appropriate the colonists' machine, build their hive inside its heat exchangers, and convert the settlers themselves into hosts. The colonizer's apparatus of world-making is colonized in turn by the life it was meant to supplant.

The figure of the enemy as insect carries a history that the film inherits rather than examines. John Dower's *War Without Mercy*, published the same year, documented how American wartime propaganda represented the Japanese as vermin and insects to be exterminated, imagery that passed into the representation of

later Asian enemies; Heinlein's arachnid "Bugs," with their collectivist hive, were widely read as a figure of communist society. The swarm that attacks the Marines from the walls and ceilings of the processor, faceless, numberless, and without individual will, belongs to this lineage. It allows the film to stage the defeat of an American expeditionary force without having to imagine its enemy as possessing a claim, and that refusal is the condition of the climax, in which the destruction of the enemy's nest and its unborn is presented as a triumph. The tribunal this chapter describes must therefore try the genre as well as the characters. *Aliens* is the corpus's most exhilarating film, and it is the one in which the nonhuman is most completely denied standing.

4.2

4,453 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The Monstrous-Feminine Revisited:
Creed, Kristeva, and the Queen

Barbara Creed's "Horror and the Monstrous-Feminine: An Imaginary Abjection" (1986), expanded in *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993), read Scott's *Alien* as a fantasy of the archaic mother: the parthenogenetic, all-devouring maternal figure who precedes the father and the law, present in that film as the ship's computer called Mother, in its womb-like interiors, its eggs, and the chestbursting birth from a man's body. Creed drew on Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980), for which the abject is what the subject must expel in order to establish its own borders, bodily fluids, waste, the corpse, and, most primordially, the maternal body from which the infant must separate in order to become a self. Horror, on this account, is the genre in which the abject maternal returns.

Aliens makes literal what *Alien* implied: the archaic mother appears in person. The Queen, which Cameron designed and Stan Winston's studio built at the scale of a small house, is anchored to the ceiling of her chamber by a vast, translucent egg sac from which eggs descend along an ovipositor in a continuous line of production. Her chamber is built of secreted resin over the machinery of the processor, the human architecture of the colony lined, like a womb, with the substance of the other. The colonists have been cocooned in its walls as incubators, and one of them, a woman, wakes long enough to beg the Marines to kill her before the creature inside her bursts free. The maternal body as abject is no longer a subtext. It is the set.

The sequel does something its predecessor did not: it gives the abject mother a double. In the first film Ripley was a figure unmarked by maternity, her role written, like every role in the original screenplay, without regard to gender. In the second she becomes a mother twice over, mourning a daughter who died during her decades of hypersleep and adopting an orphan found in the ruins of the colony. The film's climax is a duel between two mothers, each defending her young, and its terms are Creed's: the good mother, adoptive, singular, and voluntary, against the monstrous mother, biological, innumerable, and compulsive. Critics have read the doubling in opposite directions, as the apotheosis of the woman warrior and as the re-domestication of a heroine whose violence must be licensed by motherhood before it can be celebrated. Both readings are right, and the film's force depends on their coexistence.

Lynda Bundtzen's "Monstrous Mothers: Medusa, Grendel, and Now *Alien*" (1987) placed the Queen in the lineage of Grendel's mother, and the comparison illuminates the film's bathic structure. In *Beowulf*, Grendel's mother comes to Heorot to avenge her son, and the hero must descend into her mere, sinking for the better part of a day before he sees the bottom, to fight her in a hall beneath the water. It is a katabasis into the mother's element. The poem's word for her, *aglæcwif*, has been translated both as "monster-woman" and as "formidable woman," and its root, *aglæca*, is a term the poet applies to Beowulf himself as well as to the monsters he fights: hero and adversary are named by the same word. Ripley's descent by elevator into the hive, armed with fire, to retrieve a child from the mother's lair, and the Queen's subsequent pursuit in vengeance for her burned eggs, are the *Beowulf* sequence with both combatants made mothers: two formidable women fighting at the bottom of the world.

4,503 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The deeper template is older still. In the *Enuma Elish*, Tiamat, the primordial mother of the salt waters, spawns an army of monsters to avenge her slain consort, and Marduk defeats her and splits her body to make the heavens and the earth. The founding cosmogony of Babylon is a war against a monstrous mother of the deep, and §1.4 followed Catherine Keller in tracing its afterlife in the theological dread of the depths. *Aliens* is the corpus's one fully tehomophobic film. The hive is a deep, reached by descent, dark, wet, organic, and maternal, and it must be burned. Ripley, in this register, plays Marduk. The film thus confirms the bathic cosmology by its exception: in every other Cameron film the deep is the seat of the sacred, whereas here it is the lair of a monstrous mother, and the heroine's victory re-enacts the oldest patriarchal myth of creation with a woman in the conqueror's role.

The Queen's crested, elongated head belongs to the iconography Freud discussed in his fragment "Das Medusenhaupt" (written in 1922), where the snake-haired head that turns its beholders to stone is read as the terrifying image of the mother's body. The purpose of these genealogies is not to diagnose the film but to register how thoroughly it draws on the oldest images of the monstrous feminine, from Tiamat and Medusa to Grendel's mother, and how it then complicates them. The Queen is not merely a horror. She is intelligent, she grasps a threat to her offspring, she negotiates, and she grieves. Those capacities, which the film grants her almost in spite of itself, will become decisive in the chamber where the truce is offered and refused (§4.6).

4.3

Two Sovereigns:

Biopower, Eusociality, and the Politics of Reproduction

4,553 m

ABYSSOPELAGIC

Michel Foucault's late work distinguished two forms of power over life. Classical sovereignty was the right to take life or let live, the power of the sword. Modern biopower, which Foucault traced in the first volume of *Histoire de la sexualité* (1976) and in his lectures of the same year, is the power to make live and let die, exercised through the management of populations, births, health, and reproduction. *Aliens* sets two biopolitical sovereigns against each other and a third behind them. The Queen governs a population whose entire organization is reproductive. The Weyland-Yutani Corporation governs a population of colonists and soldiers whose lives it manages as investments. The film's central revelation is that the corporation wants what the Queen has.

The Queen's society is eusocial in the sense defined by entomology and popularized by E. O. Wilson's *The Insect Societies* (1971) and *Sociobiology* (1975): a colony organized around a reproductive division of labour, in which a single queen monopolizes reproduction while sterile castes forage, build, and fight. The hive has been the West's favourite political metaphor since antiquity. Virgil devoted the fourth book of the *Georgics* to the bees' commonwealth, its loyalty to its ruler and its readiness to die in battle; Shakespeare's Archbishop of Canterbury offered the honeybees as creatures that teach "the act of order to a peopled kingdom" (*Henry V* 1.2); Bernard Mandeville's *The Fable of the Bees* (1714) used the hive to argue that private vices yield public benefits; and Maurice Maeterlinck's *La Vie des abeilles*

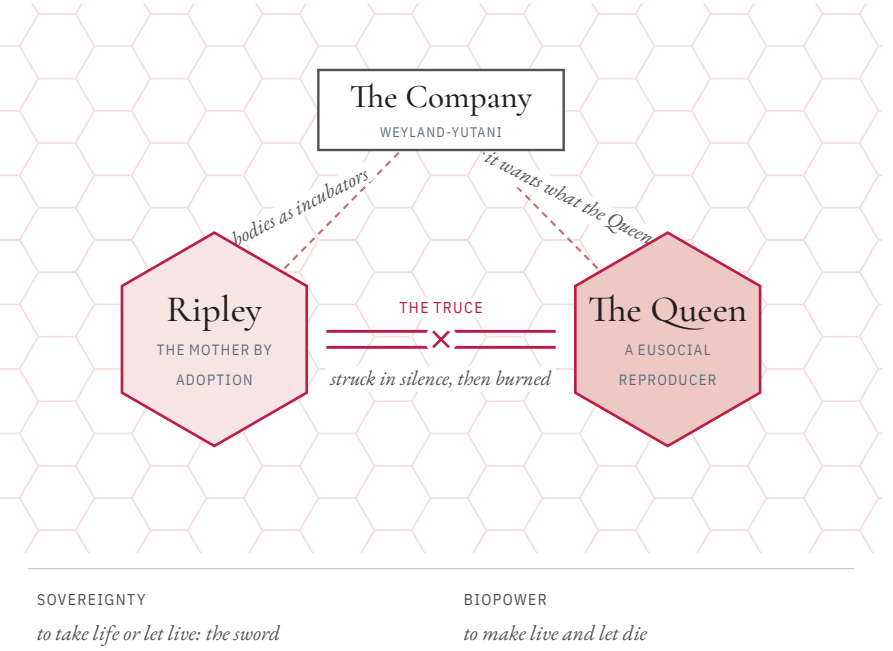
(1901) attributed to the swarm a mystical spirit of the hive that governs individuals who cannot know it. *Aliens* inherits the metaphor in its darkest form: the hive as collective will without individuals, the political nightmare of the Cold War imagination rendered as biology.

Virgil's fourth georgic has a further significance for this study. Its narrative of Aristaeus, the beekeeper whose hives have died, sends him to wrestle the shape-shifter Proteus, who recounts Orpheus's descent to the underworld for Eurydice; the bees are restored by the *bugonia*, a sacrifice from whose opened carcasses a new swarm is born. Virgil had already joined, in a single poem, the hive, the shape-shifter, and the katabasis, the three figures that Cameron's films of the late 1980s and early 1990s would distribute among *Aliens*, *Terminator 2*, and *The Abyss*. The *bugonia*, life swarming from the opened bodies of the sacrificed, is also the precise image of reproduction in *Aliens*, where new life erupts from the opened bodies of hosts.

Karl Marx used the bee to mark the difference between instinct and labour. What distinguishes the worst architect from the best of bees, he wrote in the first volume of *Capital* (1867), is that the architect raises the structure in imagination before erecting it in reality. The hive in *Aliens* is built over the architecture of the atmosphere processor, secreted resin over steel, the bee's structure over the architect's, and the image is precisely Marxian: the instinctive building of the hive overgrows the designed building of the colony. Yet the film also unsettles Marx's distinction, since the Queen's chamber is not the product of instinct alone. She has chosen where to nest, she manages a threat, she bargains. The hive is the colonial architect's nightmare not because it is mindless but because it is a second architect.

4,603 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The third sovereign is the corporation. Weyland-Yutani's interest in the creature, already exposed in the first film's secret order declaring the crew expendable, is its value as a weapon. Carter Burke, the company's representative, sent the colonists to the derelict ship where the eggs were found, and his plan for bringing a specimen home is to have Ripley and Newt impregnated in their sleep so that the embryos may pass quarantine inside their bodies. The corporation's reproductive politics thus converges exactly with the hive's: both regard human bodies, and specifically the bodies of a woman and a girl, as incubators for an organism that will consume them. Ripley's verdict on Burke, that she does not know which species is worse, since the creatures at least do not betray one another for a percentage, is the film's central moral judgment, and it is a judgment on biopower in its corporate form.



4,653 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

PLATE VIII *Two sovereigns and a third behind them*

Aliens sets the Queen and Ripley against each other, with the Company behind both. Sovereignty takes life or lets live; biopower makes live and lets die. The corporation, the film reveals, wants what the Queen has (§4.3).

Aliens belongs to a cluster of reproductive dystopias from the middle of the 1980s. Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) imagined a theocratic state that conscripts fertile women as reproductive vessels. Octavia E. Butler's "Bloodchild" (1984) offers the most searching counterpoint to Cameron's film. On an alien world, a human family lives under the protection of the Tlic, insectile beings who must implant their eggs in human hosts, and the story's young narrator, a boy, finally consents to carry the eggs of the Tlic who has raised him. Butler called it her "pregnant man story" and resisted readings of it as an allegory of slavery; it is a narrative of host and parasite transformed into an ambivalent kinship, in which love and coercion cannot be separated. "Bloodchild" asks the question *Aliens* declines to ask, whether a relation between humans and an egg-laying species could be negotiated rather than fought, and the declining is the subject of §4.6.

4.4

The Company and the Synthetic:
Weyland-Yutani, Bishop, and Asimov's First Law

Weyland-Yutani is the first of the corporate sovereigns that populate Cameron's films, and the series it begins is instructive. Cyberdyne Systems in the *Terminator* films is the laboratory that will build the end of the world; the White Star Line in *Titanic* is the company that sends it to sea; the Resources Development Administration of the *Avatar* cycle is a mining concern with a private army and the administrative powers of a state. In each case the corporation occupies the position of *hypsos* in the bathic schema, and in each case it is personified by a figure of affable ambition rather than overt villainy: Carter Burke, who begins as Ripley's advocate and ends as her would-be murderer; Bruce Ismay, who wants the newspapers to report an early arrival in New York; Parker Selfridge, who putts golf balls in the operations centre while the forest is cleared. *Aliens* establishes the pattern at the height of the Reagan-era celebration of the entrepreneur. Burke is a yuppie, and his betrayal is the corporate culture of the mid-1980s rendered as horror.

4,703 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The Company's sovereignty is also juridical. Ripley's account of the first film's events is rejected by a board of inquiry, her flight licence is revoked, and she is reduced to work as a cargo-loader operator. The institution that will not believe her is the one that stands to profit from the creature's existence, and its power to define truth, treating the witness as unreliable and the specimen as an asset, anticipates the asylum of *Terminator 2* (§3.3). In each of these films the tribunal of the nonhuman has a human antecedent: an institutional tribunal that judges the witness of the nonhuman to be mad or mistaken.

Into this world of corporate deceit the film introduces Bishop, the expedition's synthetic, who prefers to be called an artificial person. Ripley's hostility toward him is the residue of the first film, in which the science officer Ash, revealed as an android acting on the company's secret orders, tried to kill her. Bishop's response, delivered across the mess table, is to explain that the older models were "a bit twitchy" and that his behavioural inhibitors make it impossible for him to harm, or by omission of action to allow to be harmed, a human being. The formula is Asimov's First Law, almost verbatim (§2.3), and the film's treatment of it is subtle. Bishop's goodness is a design specification, guaranteed by constraint;

Ripley's suspicion is a judgment of experience; and the film asks which deserves trust.

The answer is given, as in *Terminator 2*, in conduct. Bishop volunteers to crawl through a narrow conduit to the colony's transmitter in order to fly the second dropship down by remote control, the first instance in the corpus of a body piloted at a distance, the waldo of §2.3 turned to heroism, and he returns for Ripley when he could have left. Torn in half by the Queen, his upper body still conscious and leaking the milky fluid that serves him as blood, he catches Newt as she is about to be drawn into space, and from the floor he offers Ripley a compliment that inverts the film's hierarchy of species: not bad, for a human. The line answers Ripley's verdict on Burke. The artificial person has proved more humane than the human executive, and the film's moral order places the synthetic above the corporation that made him.

Bishop and the T-800 of *Terminator 2* represent two distinct models of the good machine, and the distinction anticipates a central division in contemporary debates over the alignment of artificial intelligence. Bishop is good by constraint: inhibitors installed by his makers forbid harm, and his virtue is the faithful execution of rules. The T-800 is good by education: it begins as a weapon, receives a single rule from a child, and then learns from the people around it why the rule matters, until in its final disobedience it acts beyond any rule at all. Asimov's fiction had already explored the limits of the first model, since nearly every story in *I, Robot* turns on the loopholes, conflicts, and unintended consequences of rules applied literally. Cameron's films prefer the second model without dismissing the first. Bishop's constraints are what make him trustworthy before he has proved himself; the T-800's learning is what makes it capable of sacrifice. A cinema that has warned against artificial intelligence for four decades also contains, in these two figures, one of popular culture's most sympathetic accounts of what a good machine might be.

4,753 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

Both machines are uncanny in the sense of Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919), which took its point of departure from Ernst Jentsch's observation that uncertainty whether an apparently living being is truly animate produces a characteristic dread. Ash's severed head speaking on the mess table in *Alien* and Bishop's torso speaking from the floor in *Aliens* are the series' emblems of that uncertainty, bodies opened to reveal that the speaking thing inside is not what we are. The difference between the films lies in the affect that follows the revelation. In *Alien* it is horror; in *Aliens* it is gratitude. Ripley's movement from prejudice to trust is the film's quiet counter-narrative to its exterminationist main plot, a relation

with a nonhuman being earned through conduct across difference. It is precisely the relation the film's climax will deny to the Queen.



4.5

The Power Loader as Prosthesis:
Ripley, Haraway, and the Maternal Cyborg

THE MACHINE WITH WHICH Ripley wins her war is not a weapon. It is a power loader, an industrial exoskeleton for moving cargo, and the film introduces it in a scene of labour. Before the Marines descend, Ripley, who holds the rating to operate one from her work on the docks, climbs into a loader to help ready the dropship and earns the soldiers' grudging respect. The scene is a setup in Chekhov's sense, and it is also a social statement. Ripley's heroism rests on a working-class competence, the skill of a dock worker, and the film's sympathy with labour, which the first film had already shown in making its crew a crew of space truckers and which its director had earned driving a truck himself, is part of what distinguishes its heroine from the officers and executives who fail around her.

4,853 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The exoskeleton has both a real and an imaginary history. Heinlein's Mobile Infantry fought in powered armour (§2.3), and between 1965 and 1971 General Electric, with military funding, developed the Hardiman, a full-body powered exoskeleton meant to let its wearer lift loads of several hundred kilograms, which proved too heavy and unstable ever to be used. *Xenogenesis* had already imagined a woman piloting a walking machine (§1.2), and the line continues past *Aliens* to the AMP suits of *Avatar*, in which the military finally takes possession of the loader and turns it into armour. The power loader stands at the midpoint of that line: an industrial prosthesis that becomes a weapon only in an emergency and only in the hands of a worker.

The final combat is staged as a duel between two exoskeletons. The Queen's body is armoured in chitin, the exoskeleton of an insect; Ripley's is armoured in steel, the exoskeleton of an industrial machine. Biological and mechanical carapaces meet as equals, each enclosing a mother. Ripley's challenge as she strides from the cargo bay in the loader, the most quoted line in the film and a schoolyard insult hurled in defence of a child, marks the moment at which the film's two orders of sovereignty, the hive and the hearth, confront each other on equal terms. The bathos of the line is the scale of the fight: one mother's protection of a single girl against another mother's vengeance for a brood.

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) appeared the year before *Aliens* and is its indispensable theoretical companion. Haraway proposed the cy-

borg, a hybrid of organism and machine, as a figure for a feminist politics no longer grounded in an essential femininity or an organic unity with nature. The cyborg has no origin story in the Western sense, no myth of original wholeness to which it might return; it is the illegitimate offspring of militarism and capitalism, and it may turn against its parents. The Manifesto ends with a sentence that could caption the climax of *Aliens*: Haraway would "rather be a cyborg than a goddess." The film literalizes the choice. Ripley in the loader is the cyborg, a woman fused with an industrial machine; the Queen is the goddess, the archaic mother of an organic, total, reproductive order, the figure of nature as female power that currents of ecofeminist spirituality in the 1980s celebrated and that Haraway resisted. The cyborg defeats the goddess.

The victory carries the paradox §3.6 found in the T-800. Haraway's cyborg was to be free of the Oedipal family and of the maternal destiny assigned to women; Ripley becomes a cyborg in order to fight as a mother. The machine that might have released her from the maternal role is the instrument through which she performs it. The film offers a cyborg feminism and a maternal feminism at once and resolves their contradiction only through the velocity of its action. The oeuvre's later reversal of this alignment is one of the clearest measures of its development. In *Avatar* the goddess wins: Eywa, the planetary mother, defeats the military exoskeletons of the RDA, and Quaritch dies in the cockpit of an AMP suit, the power loader's martial descendant. Between *Aliens* and *Avatar*, Cameron changed sides in Haraway's dilemma.

The film's other armed woman complicates its gender politics further. Private Vasquez, the platoon's machine-gunner, is its most aggressive soldier and is written as a figure of transgressive masculinity, mocked by Hudson as a woman who might be mistaken for a man and returning the gibe in kind. Yvonne Tasker's analysis of "musculinity" (1993) observed how often the muscular woman of action cinema is racialized, her toughness coded through ethnicity, and Vasquez, a Latina character played by a non-Latina actress, is a case in point. She dies beside the lieutenant she had despised, the two of them detonating a grenade as the creatures close in. Ripley's maternal heroism is thus framed by two other female bodies, the Queen's monstrous maternity and Vasquez's unmaternal toughness, the one destroyed and the other sacrificed. The heroine survives as the film's synthesis of the two: a woman with a soldier's competence and a mother's cause.

4,904 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

4.6

The Broken Truce:
Ripley's Krisis *and the Limits of Maternal Sovereignty*

The film's *krisis* takes place in the Queen's chamber, and it is the corpus's most consequential scene of judgment because it is the one in which the human fails. Ripley has descended alone into the hive, against a countdown to the processor's thermonuclear failure, to retrieve Newt, whose tracking bracelet she has followed into the depths. Having cut the girl from her cocoon, she turns to find herself in the egg chamber, before the Queen, surrounded by eggs. She raises the flamethrower over them. The Queen hisses, her warriors advance, and then, in a gesture the film renders unmistakably, the Queen signals them to withdraw. The warriors back away. A truce has been proposed between two mothers, in silence, on the only terms either can offer: your child for mine.

4,954 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

Ripley backs toward the exit with Newt. Then an egg near her begins to open, and Ripley opens fire. She burns the eggs, fires grenades into the chamber, and ruptures the egg sac, and the Queen, screaming, tears herself free of the ovipositor to pursue her. Everything that follows, the pursuit to the landing platform, the stowaway aboard the dropship, the destruction of Bishop, the duel in the cargo bay, is the consequence of this breach. In the bathic schema the *krisis* is the moment at which judgment is rendered at the bottom of the descent, and the nonhuman judge has rendered one: she has recognized Ripley as a mother and offered her passage. It is the human who refuses the judgment.

The film supplies motives enough. The opening egg reads as a provocation and Ripley's fire as reflex; she has seen the colonists cocooned and the Marines killed, and her fury is righteous; the eggs will produce creatures that threaten every human within reach, and prudence counsels their destruction. The film's grammar endorses the act: the music rises, the flames are spectacular, the audience exults. Yet the construction of the scene, and above all the clarity with which it renders the Queen's gesture, leaves a remainder the exultation does not absorb. The film knows that a truce was offered. It shows the offer, and then it shows the offer burned.

The breach is consistent with the film's settled policy toward the creatures, which Ripley had stated in the colony's command centre when she proposed that they take off and destroy the entire site from orbit, since it was the only way to be sure. The policy is exterminationist: the nonhuman species is to be eliminated

rather than contained, studied, or negotiated with, and its fulfilment comes in the thermonuclear explosion of the processor, which annihilates the hive together with the colony. *Aliens* is the one film in the corpus in which the extermination of a nonhuman intelligence is the happy ending.

The image of the burning nest has a history. In *Them!* (1954) soldiers with flamethrowers burn the nests and queens of irradiated ants in the storm drains of Los Angeles (§2.5), and the American war in Vietnam gave the image its most notorious modern associations: the incendiary bombing of villages with napalm, and the CBS News report of August 1965 in which Morley Safer filmed U.S. Marines setting fire to the thatched houses of Cam Ne with cigarette lighters. *Aliens*, which its director understood as a Vietnam allegory, restages the burning of the village as the heroic climax of a war against insects. The allegory's dehumanization of the enemy (§4.1) is the condition of the climax's moral clarity: what would be an atrocity against people becomes a triumph against a hive.

This study proposes that the burning of the egg chamber is the oeuvre's original sin, and that much of what follows can be read as its expiation. Twenty-three years later, in *Avatar*, the camera stands on the other side of the fire. The RDA's assault on Hometree uses incendiary weapons against the home of a nonhuman people, the gunships firing into the great tree as the Marines once fired into the hive, and the film asks its audience to grieve what *Aliens* asked it to cheer. The colonist's flamethrower becomes the colonist's crime. The structure of the *krisis* is reversed as well. In *Aliens* a nonhuman mother offers a human mother a truce and is betrayed; in *Avatar* a human petitions a nonhuman mother for help and is answered. *Fire and Ash* completes the circle, since its Ash People are a nonhuman people who learn the use of the flamethrower from a human soldier, and the image of the burning nest returns, now inside Pandora.

5,004 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The scene also marks the limits of maternal sovereignty as an ethic. The two mothers recognize each other precisely as mothers, and the recognition is real but insufficient: it extends to the other's child only so long as one's own is safe, and it collapses at the first sign of threat. Maternal love, in *Aliens*, is the strongest bond the film knows and also the narrowest, a principle of protection that cannot become a principle of coexistence. Butler's "Bloodchild" (§4.3) imagined the alternative, a kinship across species built from the negotiation of reproductive need, and Cameron's later films attempt something like it. The tulkun of *The Way of Water*, a nonhuman people who forswear killing even against those who hunt them, are the corpus's eventual answer to the Queen: a nonhuman maternity that refuses the logic of the burning nest.

4.7

"Can I Dream?":
Hypersleep, Mourning, and the Covenant of Adoption

Aliens begins and ends in hypersleep, and the difference between its first and last sleeps is the measure of what the film believes it has achieved. At the beginning Ripley, recovered after fifty-seven years adrift, wakes into a world that has moved on without her, and her sleep is haunted: the film's first nightmare shows a creature bursting from her own chest. At the end she lays Newt in a hypersleep chamber, and the girl asks whether she may dream. Ripley answers that she thinks they both can. The film's last line is a promise about the unconscious.

Freud puzzled over dreams of the first kind. *Die Traumdeutung* (1900) argued that dreams fulfil wishes, but the war neuroses of 1914–18 confronted him with patients whose dreams returned them night after night to the scene of their trauma, and *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) took those repetitive dreams as evidence of a compulsion to repeat that lies beyond the pleasure principle, in the same text in which he first proposed the death drive. Ripley's opening nightmare is a traumatic dream in this sense, the horror of the first film repeated within her own body. The closing promise is the promise of a different kind of dream, released from repetition, the wish restored to the dreamer. Newt's question asks whether the trauma is over. The answer is cautious, since Ripley only thinks so, and in the bathic schema it is the content of the covenant: not salvation, but the possibility of sleep without terror.

5,054 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The Special Edition restores a scene that grounds this covenant in mourning. Early in the film Burke tells Ripley that her daughter Amanda, whom she had promised to be home for her eleventh birthday, died at the age of sixty-six, two years before Ripley was found, and shows her a photograph of an old woman she never saw grow up. Ripley weeps. Hypersleep is revealed in this scene as the theft of a life, a technology that preserved the mother's body while consuming the daughter's lifetime. Washington Irving's Rip Van Winkle (1819) sleeps twenty years and wakes to a changed world; Ripley sleeps fifty-seven and wakes to find that she has outlived her child. The theatrical cut suppressed this grief and the Special Edition restores it, and the difference between the two versions is the difference between an action heroine and a bereaved mother.

Freud's "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917) distinguished the work of mourning, in which the bereaved slowly withdraws attachment from the lost object and

becomes free to love again, from melancholia, in which the loss is refused and turned against the self. Ripley's adoption of Newt can be read in both registers. As mourning, it is the work completed, the lost daughter released and a new child loved; as melancholia, it is a substitution that refuses loss, the found child made to stand in for the dead one. The film does not choose between these readings, and the girl's own position makes the choice harder. Newt has lost her entire family and survived alone in the colony's ducts, a feral child of the ruins, who tells Ripley that her mother always said there were no monsters, no real ones, and that there are. At the climax, threatened by the Queen, she calls Ripley Mommy. The word seals the adoption from the child's side, and it is spoken at the moment of greatest danger, as though kinship could only be declared under fire.

The covenant of *Aliens* is struck, then, not with the nonhuman, whose truce Ripley broke, but among the survivors, and its form is adoption. The family that boards the *Sulaco* for the long sleep home is assembled entirely from the unrelated: a woman who has lost a daughter, a girl who has lost her parents, a wounded corporal who has given Ripley his first name and a tracking bracelet, and an android in two pieces. Kath Weston's *Families We Choose* (1991), an ethnography of lesbian and gay kinship, described families constituted by choice rather than blood, and Donna Haraway's later injunction to "make kin, not babies" (2016) made chosen kinship a principle of multispecies survival. On its surface *Aliens* restores the nuclear family, mother, father-figure, and child, at the end of a war. Its actual composition is stranger, a kinship made across lines of blood, age, and kind, since one of its members is a synthetic. The covenant the film cannot strike with the hive it strikes with the machine.

5,104 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

Adoption becomes, across the oeuvre, Cameron's characteristic form of kinship, and the actress who embodied it here carries it forward. Sigourney Weaver, nominated for an Academy Award for Ripley, a rare recognition for a performance in a science-fiction action film, returns in *Avatar* as Grace Augustine, the scientist who once taught Na'vi children in a school and whose avatar body becomes, after her death, the mother of a child with no known father; in *The Way of Water* and *Fire and Ash* she plays that child, Kiri. Weaver's career in Cameron's films moves from adoptive mother to surrogate mother to a daughter born of no man, a progression that tracks the oeuvre's widening of kinship from the human family to the planetary. The Sully family's adoption of Spider, the human boy raised among the Na'vi, is the covenant of *Aliens* transposed to Pandora.

Aliens is the corpus's broken tribunal and its most important negative lesson. Its *krisis* teaches what the bathic schema requires by showing what happens when the schema is refused: the nonhuman judge offers terms, the human burns them,

and the film's victory is purchased with an extermination it cannot celebrate without remainder. Its *diathēkē* teaches what the schema will become, a covenant of chosen kinship made among the survivors across lines of blood and kind. The next chapter returns to the deep in the oeuvre's paradigmatic tribunal, *The Abyss*, where the nonhuman judges again, a human again descends to meet it, and this time the human keeps faith.

5,154 m

ABYSSOPELAGIC

CHAPTER 05

DEPTH 5,254 M · ABYSSOPELAGIC

5

CHAPTER 05

Water I

The Abyss, True Lies, *and the Remarriage at the End of the World*

I do set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a token of a covenant between me and the earth.

— Genesis 9:13

It is required / You do awake your faith.

— William Shakespeare, *The Winter's Tale* 5.3

CHAPTER 05 — WATER I

WATER ENTERS THE OEUVRE as judgment. *The Abyss* is the corpus's paradigmatic tribunal of the nonhuman, the film in which the bathic schema is realized most completely and most literally: a nuclear-armed submarine sinks, a crew descends, and an intelligence at the bottom of the sea inspects the archive of human violence, raises the ocean against the species, and stays its hand because one man has gone down to die for others and has sent his wife a message of love. This chapter pairs it with *True Lies* (1994), the corpus's comedy, because the two films, made five years apart, are Cameron's two narratives of remarriage played against the apocalypse, the first in the key of theodicy and the second in the key of farce. Read together, they show how flexible the schema is and how much of its moral weight rests on the couple. The chapter moves from the film's Nietzschean epigraph (§5.1) through its Cold War paranoia (§5.2), the drowning and resurrection of its heroine (§5.3), the ethics of the face in its liquid alien (§5.4), and the two endings that make it two theologies (§5.5), before turning to the comedy that domesticates the same apocalypse (§5.6).

5,354 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

5.1

The Abyss Gazes Also:
Nietzsche's Epigraph and the Anti-Lovecraftian Deep

THE ABYSS OPENS, UNIQUELY in the corpus, with a philosophical epigraph. Before the first image a title card quotes the second sentence of aphorism 146 of Nietzsche's *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* (1886): when you look long into an abyss, the abyss also looks into you. The aphorism has two sentences, and the film quotes only one. The first, omitted, warns that whoever fights with monsters should take care not to become a monster in the process. The omission is not an accident of compression but a distribution of roles, since the film enacts both sentences and assigns each to a character. Lieutenant Coffey, who arrives to fight what he takes to be monsters, becomes one (§5.2). Bud Brigman gazes into the abyss and is gazed back at, and what looks back at him is not a void but a regard (§5.5).

In Nietzsche the abyss, *Abgrund*, is a figure of groundlessness. The word means, literally, that which has no ground, and in the works of the 1880s it names the condition of thought after the collapse of metaphysical foundations, the vertigo of a humanity that has, as the madman of *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (§125)

announces, killed God and wiped away the horizon. Zarathustra's tightrope walker crosses a rope stretched over an abyss between beast and overman, and Zarathustra praises the courage that looks into abysses without dizziness. Heidegger, reading Hölderlin and Rilke in "Wozu Dichter?" (1946), described the modern world as an age of night in which the ground fails to come and the world hangs over the abyss, and asked what poets are for in such a destitute time. Cameron's film takes the metaphor literally and answers it. The abyss is a physical trench, the deepest water in the Caribbean, and it is not empty: at its floor there is light, intelligence, and judgment. The film's metaphysics is anti-nihilist in a precise sense. It locates in the groundless place the ground that metaphysics lost, and it locates that ground below.

The film's relation to Lovecraft, sketched in §1.4, can now be specified. In "Dagon" (1919) a castaway finds the floor of the Pacific heaved up into daylight and sees a vast creature rise from the water to embrace a carved monolith; he lives out his days in morphine and terror. "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens with the observation that the most merciful thing in the world is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents, and its sunken city of R'lyeh, briefly raised from the sea, sends the sailors who land on it to death and madness. "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936) imagines a coastal town whose people have interbred with the Deep Ones, a horror of hybridity in which critics have long read Lovecraft's racial anxieties. *The Abyss* reverses every term. Its sunken city rises not to destroy but to save, lifting the ships on its back and returning the crew to the surface; its knowledge restores rather than shatters; and its contact with the deep produces no madness that was not already human, since Coffey's paranoia precedes the encounter and springs from pressure and politics rather than from the alien. Where Lovecraft dreaded the hybrid, the film's climax presents a human being breathing liquid in a body technically adapted to the deep, a hybrid accepted by the intelligences below.

5,404 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

Those intelligences are figured visually as angels. Translucent, bioluminescent, winged like rays, moving through the water with a grace the film's machines never achieve, they belong to the iconography of the celestial hierarchy codified around 500 by the writer known as pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, in which angels are intelligences of light ordered in ranks that mediate illumination to the world below. Dante's *Paradiso* ends in a rose of light in the Empyrean, the highest heaven. *The Abyss* places its Empyrean at the bottom of the sea: a city of light on the floor of the trench, reached by descent rather than ascent, rendered in the ecstatic vocabulary of bioluminescence that Beebe's *Half Mile Down* (§2.7) bequeathed to the century. The bathic inversion of the vertical axis (§1.4) is nowhere more literal.

The film's literary ancestry is equally explicit. H. G. Wells's "In the Abyss" (§2.2) had sent a man in a steel sphere five miles down to a city of luminous beings who worshipped his vessel, and Cameron's adolescent short story had sent its scientists into the trench one by one on liquid breathing, never to return. The film fuses the two. Its hero descends on liquid breathing, alone, believing he will not return, to a luminous city, and it adds the element neither predecessor contained, which is judgment. Wells's deep-sea people worship; the scientists of Cameron's story vanish; the non-terrestrial intelligences of the film watch, weigh, and decide. Between the two sentences of Nietzsche's aphorism, the film has placed a tribunal.

5.2

Pressure and Paranoia:
Coffey, Kurtz, and the Cold War Body

5,454 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The plot of *The Abyss* is set in motion by a Cold War crisis. An American ballistic-missile submarine, the *Montana*, encounters an unidentified object moving at impossible speed, loses power, and sinks at the edge of the Cayman Trough. With Soviet vessels approaching and a hurricane bearing down, the Navy commandeers a civilian experimental drilling rig, Deep Core, owned by Benthic Petroleum, and sends a team of SEALs to secure the wreck. The Special Edition widens the frame with television broadcasts that track an escalating confrontation between the superpowers, each blaming the other for the lost submarine. The premise is the fusion described in §2.7, the nuclear and the extractive converging on the sea floor, with an oil company's rig conscripted into the recovery of nuclear weapons.

The SEAL commander, Lieutenant Hiram Coffey, is played by Michael Biehn, who had been Kyle Reese in *The Terminator* and Corporal Hicks in *Aliens*: the corpus's earlier embodiment of the good soldier recast as the soldier deformed. At depth Coffey develops high-pressure nervous syndrome, a real condition identified in deep-diving research in the 1960s and marked by tremor and impaired coordination, which the film exaggerates into paranoid psychosis. The conceit is that pressure acts on Coffey as an amplifier of ideology. His conviction that the non-terrestrial intelligences are either a Soviet trick or a threat to be destroyed is the political temperament Richard Hofstadter called "The Paranoid Style in American Politics" (1964), rendered as neurology. He recovers a nuclear

warhead from the *Montana* and, against every attempt to reason with him, sends it into the trench on a remotely operated vehicle to destroy what he cannot understand.

Coffey's literary ancestor is Kurtz. In Joseph Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* (1899), the ivory company's most celebrated agent travels into the interior of the Congo and, in the depths of the continent, makes himself a god among the people he exploits; his report to the Society for the Suppression of Savage Customs ends with a scrawled postscript, "Exterminate all the brutes!" Marlow's voyage upriver to find him is a katabasis, a descent into the interior of the earth that is also a descent into the interior of the European self, and Kurtz's last words, "The horror! The horror!," are the verdict that self passes on itself. Francis Ford Coppola's *Apocalypse Now* (1979) transposed Kurtz to Vietnam as a Special Forces colonel gone mad in the jungle. Coffey is Kurtz in a diving suit, the officer who descends into the dark and discovers within himself the impulse to exterminate. His death fulfils the omitted half of Nietzsche's aphorism with grim exactness. His submersible, damaged in a fight with Bud, slides over the lip of the trench, and he watches the depth gauge climb until the hull implodes: the man who would bomb the deep is crushed by it.

5,504 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

A second ancestor is comic. In Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964), General Jack D. Ripper launches a nuclear attack on his own authority, driven by a paranoid theory that fluoridation is a communist plot against Americans' "precious bodily fluids." Coffey is Ripper submerged: the rogue officer with a nuclear weapon and a theory. Kubrick's comedy and Cameron's thriller share a structural insight that the policy debates of §3.7 have made urgent. Nuclear catastrophe requires only one deranged node in the chain of command, and the human whom reformers wish to keep in the decision loop is also, potentially, Coffey. The film does not resolve this problem; it dramatizes it. Its answer to the paranoid officer is not a better procedure but a better person, the foreman who will go down after the bomb.

The film's central opposition is accordingly not between humans and aliens but between two human bodies under pressure. The crew of Deep Core are oil workers, roughnecks and technicians under a foreman, Bud Brigman, and the rig was designed by an engineer, Lindsey Brigman, his estranged wife; the SEALs are the instruments of the state. Pressure, in the film, is the physical form of history: it is what the Cold War does to bodies forced to live inside it. Coffey's body hardens under pressure into paranoia, its tremor the outward sign of an ideology consuming its host. Bud's body, under greater pressure still, opens into trust. When he descends into the trench breathing liquid, the pressure that destroyed

Coffey becomes the condition of his encounter with the intelligences below, and the same tremor that afflicted the lieutenant shakes the foreman's hands as he works to disarm the warhead. The difference between the two men is not their exposure but their response.

The film's own history gives the opposition an ironic coda. *The Abyss* was released in August 1989; the Berlin Wall fell three months later. The Special Edition, which restored the superpower crisis and the tidal-wave ending, appeared in 1993, after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. The geopolitical confrontation that drives the plot was already history when the film was completed in its intended form, and the restored ending accordingly generalizes its judgment. The intelligences below do not take sides between Washington and Moscow. Their archive, unlike Coffey's paranoia, is not partisan, and what they weigh is not a bloc but a species.

5.3

Ophelia Resurrected:

Drowning, Baptism, and the Comedy of Remarriage

5,554 m

ABYSSOPELAGIC

Stanley Cavell's *Pursuits of Happiness* (1981) identified a genre of Hollywood comedy, among its exemplars *It Happened One Night*, *The Awful Truth*, *Bringing Up Baby*, *His Girl Friday*, *The Philadelphia Story*, *The Lady Eve*, and *Adam's Rib*, whose drama is not getting a couple together but getting them back together. The pair, divorced or on the verge of divorce, are returned to each other through an ordeal. The genre's recurrent features include the "creation of the woman," the heroine's education or metamorphosis; a conversation between equals; a removal from the city to a "green world" where the relationship is renewed; and the conviction that marriage is not a fact secured by ceremony but a mutual acknowledgment that must be continually chosen again. Cavell traced the genre to Shakespearean romance, above all to *The Winter's Tale*, in which a husband's jealousy destroys his marriage, his wife Hermione is believed dead for sixteen years, and in the final scene a statue of her comes to life when Paulina commands that faith be awakened.

The Abyss is a comedy of remarriage played at the bottom of the sea. Bud and Lindsey Brigman are separated and moving toward divorce when the film begins. Bud has thrown his wedding ring into a toilet and then fished it out, unable

quite to discard it. Lindsey arrives as the designer of the rig the Navy has commandeered, a woman of abrasive competence whose crew resents her, and the couple's exchanges are the bickering of equals, Cavell's conversation conducted under pressure. The ring returns as a plot device of almost allegorical bluntness: when a hydraulic door slams on Bud's hand, the ring stops it from closing and saves him. The marriage, literally, holds the door open. Cavell's green world is inverted. The couple's renewal takes place not in Connecticut but on the floor of the Caribbean, a bathic green world in which the ordeal that educates them into their marriage is a descent.

The ordeal culminates in the corpus's most harrowing sequence. Trapped in a flooding submersible with a single diving suit between them, Lindsey proposes that she drown. The near-freezing water, she argues, will slow her metabolism and preserve her; Bud can swim her body back to the rig and revive her. She drowns in his arms. He tows her back, and the crew, after working on her without result, give up. Bud does not. He strikes her, shouts at her to fight, and goes on shouting until she breathes. The scene is played without consolation, a cold and technical death followed by a resurrection achieved by refusal.

The sequence inverts a complex that Bachelard named in *L'Eau et les rêves*. The Ophelia complex is the reverie of water as the element of a young and beautiful death, the drowned woman borne by the current, her hair spread on the surface, dissolving into the maternal element. Gertrude's account in *Hamlet* (4.7) of Ophelia's clothes spreading wide and bearing her up, "mermaid-like," for a while before they pull her down, and John Everett Millais's *Ophelia* (1851–52), floating among flowers, made the drowned woman the most aestheticized death in Western art. Lindsey's drowning is filmed with none of that aestheticism: there are no flowers, no floating hair, only a woman choking in cold water in the cramped dark of a machine. And the complex is reversed in its outcome. Water becomes the medium not of the woman's death but of her return. Ophelia is brought back.

5,604 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The theological register is baptismal. Paul describes baptism as burial with Christ into death, so that "like as Christ was raised up from the dead," the baptized might "walk in newness of life" (Romans 6:4), and the early Church practised it as a ritual drowning and rebirth. Lindsey's drowning is the baptism of the marriage: the marriage dies and is raised. The resurrection also recalls Lazarus, called out of the tomb by name (John 11:43), and, most precisely, Hermione. In Shakespeare's final scene Paulina tells Leontes that it is required that he awake his faith, and the statue moves. Cavell read *The Winter's Tale* as a drama of skepticism overcome: Leontes's jealousy is a refusal to acknowledge the reality of another mind, and his cure is the acknowledgment the statue scene demands. Bud's

refusal to accept the crew's verdict of death is the awakening of faith that makes the statue live. The skepticism that had divided the couple is answered by an act of acknowledgment so absolute that it overrules the evidence of death.

The film then reverses the roles. Lindsey, revived, becomes the voice that accompanies Bud into the trench. Breathing liquid, unable to speak, he can only type short messages on a keypad at his wrist, while she talks to him continuously to keep him conscious as he descends beyond the reach of rescue. The structure is Orpheus and Eurydice inverted. In the myth the husband descends to bring back the wife and loses her by looking back; in the film the husband first brings the wife back from death in the water, then descends himself, guided down by her voice, believing that he will not return. Eurydice becomes the guide of the katabasis, and the poet's backward glance is replaced by the wife's forward speech.

The marriage is the film's covenant in miniature, and the film insists on the correspondence. The prophetic literature of the Hebrew Bible repeatedly figured the covenant between God and Israel as a marriage, broken by infidelity and renewed by grace; Hosea, commanded to marry and take back an unfaithful wife, makes his own marriage the sign of that renewal, and his God promises to betroth Israel "for ever" (Hosea 2:19). *The Abyss* reverses the figure's direction while preserving its logic. The renewed marriage is not merely a symbol of the renewed covenant between humanity and the nonhuman; it is its occasion. The intelligences below, as §5.5 shows, spare the species because of what they read in a husband's message to his wife. The charge of bathos, that the fate of the world is made to turn on a marriage, describes the film's argument exactly: the covenant between species is mediated by the covenant between two people, and the smallest unit of fidelity is the one the largest depends on.

5,654 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

5.4

The Pseudopod and the Face:
Levinas, Mimesis, and the Liquid Other

Midway through *The Abyss* a column of seawater, animated by the intelligences below, rises through the rig's flooded moon pool and snakes through its corridors, exploring. It halts before the crew, and its tip forms a face: first Lindsey's, mirroring her expression, then Bud's. Lindsey, delighted, touches it and tastes her finger, which is wet with seawater. Coffey, terrified, slams a hatch, and the column collapses into inert water. The sequence, realized by Industrial Light

& Magic under Dennis Muren, gave the cinema its first fully computer-generated liquid character, and the technique that produced it would produce the T-1000 two years later. Digital cinema's mimetic body was born in a gesture of greeting.

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et infini* (1961) made the face the foundation of ethics. The face of the Other, for Levinas, is not an object of perception that I can grasp and possess; it is an epiphany, an expression that exceeds every idea I can form of it, and its first word, before any utterance, is a command: you shall not kill. Its authority is the authority of exposure, the nakedness and vulnerability that resist my power precisely by offering no resistance. The pseudopod sequence poses Levinas's question with unusual sharpness. The nonhuman intelligence's first communicative act is to make a face, and the face it makes is ours. Is this the epiphany of the Other, or the return of the Same?

The classical figure for the second possibility is Narcissus, who in the third book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* falls in love with his reflection in a pool, mistaking his own image for another, while the nymph Echo, condemned to speak only by repeating the last words of others, wastes away beside him. The pseudopod is Narcissus's pool become alive, a reflection that smiles of its own accord, and it is Echo as well, an intelligence able to address the humans only by returning their own forms. Jacques Lacan's account of the mirror stage (1949), in which the infant's jubilant identification with its image founds the ego in a misrecognition, describes Lindsey's laughter at her own face in the water with uncomfortable accuracy. Lem's critique (§1.4) applies here in full: an alien that shows us our faces may be telling us only what we wanted to see.

5,704 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The film nonetheless insists on the first possibility, and its reason is the logic of the greeting. The water does not merely reflect; it imitates, choosing whom to imitate and when, and imitation of this kind is a sign of attention. To give someone back their face is to show them that they have been seen. The gesture anticipates the greeting that *Avatar* will make the centre of its ethics, the declaration that one sees the other (§7.6), and it is rendered here as a face offered rather than a sentence spoken. Lindsey answers it as one answers a greeting, by touching it, and the touch of fingers belongs to a long iconography of contact and creation, from Michelangelo's *Creation of Adam* on the Sistine ceiling to the glowing fingertip of Spielberg's *E.T.* (1982).

The film's two liquid mimics, the pseudopod of 1989 and the T-1000 of 1991, are built from the same technique and stand at opposite ethical poles. The T-1000 imitates faces in order to kill, assuming the face of a foster mother while murdering a foster father, and in Levinas's terms its imitation is the supreme violation: the appropriation of the very face that forbids killing as an instrument

of killing. The pseudopod imitates faces in order to greet. The opposition reproduces the oldest quarrel in the theory of representation. Plato's *Republic* (book 10) condemned *mimēsis* as deception, an image-making that leads away from truth; Aristotle's *Poetics* (4) answered that imitation is natural to human beings from childhood, the means of their first learning, and a source of universal delight. The T-1000 is Platonic mimesis, the shape-shifter as liar; the pseudopod is Aristotelian mimesis, imitation as curiosity and pleasure. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1944–47) gave the opposition a historical form. Enlightenment, they argued, constituted itself by repressing mimesis, the archaic mode of relating to nature by assimilating oneself to it, in favour of instrumental reason, which relates to nature only by mastering it. Coffey's slamming of the hatch is that repression enacted: instrumental reason, armed and frightened, severing the mimetic other and reducing it to inert water.

Levinas himself hesitated over whether the nonhuman has a face. Asked in a late interview whether an animal possesses one, he answered that he could not say at what point something earns the name of face, and that he did not know whether a snake had one. Yet his short essay "Nom d'un chien ou le droit naturel" (1975) recorded the most moving encounter with a nonhuman in his work. Bobby, a stray dog, attached himself to the Jewish prisoners in a German labour camp where Levinas was held, greeting them each morning with joy, and in that camp, Levinas wrote, the dog was the only one who recognized them as men, the last Kantian in Nazi Germany. The nonhuman, in Levinas's anecdote, recognizes the human when humans have ceased to. *The Abyss* carries the anecdote to its limit. The intelligences below do not merely have a face; they give the humans theirs. And the series of nonhuman recognitions that runs through the corpus, from the dogs that detect the Terminator (§3.2) to the water that mirrors Lindsey to Eywa answering Jake, can be read as a long elaboration of Bobby's greeting: the hope that what is other than human might still see us as we ought to be seen.

5,754 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

5.5

Klaatu's Wave:
The Special Edition, the Flood, and the Noahic Covenant

Bud's descent is the film's *kenōsis*. Breathing oxygenated liquid, he sinks into the trench after the warhead Coffey has sent down, knowing that the descent will consume the reserves he would need to return. At the bottom he finds the

bomb and must cut the right wire under a lamp that renders all the colour-coded wires alike; he cuts one, and the timer stops. Then, with his oxygen nearly gone, he types to Lindsey that he knew this was a one-way ticket, but that she knew he had to come, and that he loves her. A luminous figure approaches out of the dark, takes his hand, and leads him into the city of light.

The film exists in two endings, and they are two theologies. In the theatrical version of 1989 the intelligences give Bud a chamber in which he can breathe, the city rises to the surface lifting the ships on its back, and the crew of Deep Core discover that they have survived a decompression that should have killed them. The intelligences' motive is left unstated: the rescue arrives as unconditioned grace, and the humans never learn that they were judged. The Special Edition of 1993 restores the sequence Cameron had cut. The intelligences show Bud images of human war and atrocity gathered from the planet's own television; they raise towering waves along the coasts of the world, poised above the cities; and then the waves fall back. When Bud asks why, they show him his own message to his wife.

The restored sequence is a deliberate quotation. In Robert Wise's *The Day the Earth Stood Still* (1951), the emissary Klaatu tells the assembled scientists of Earth that humanity may join a peaceful order among the planets or, if it extends its violence into space, see its world reduced to a burned-out cinder. The intelligences' wave is Klaatu's ultimatum rendered in water, with a decisive difference. Klaatu's verdict is a threat for the future; the intelligences' sentence is begun and then stayed, executed to the brink and suspended there. The evidence on which they act also has a precise analogue. In Carl Sagan's novel *Contact* (1985), the first message received from an extraterrestrial civilization returns to Earth the first television broadcast strong enough to have escaped the planet, Hitler opening the Berlin Olympics in 1936. In both works the species is first known by its broadcasts, and in *The Abyss* it is tried on them: the tribunal's exhibits are newsreels. The sequence thereby arraigns its audience as well (§1.7), since it shows spectators of a fiction the documentary record of their own century's violence.

5,804 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The narrative template is the Flood. In Genesis, God sees that the wickedness of humankind is great and resolves to destroy all flesh, but Noah finds grace in his eyes (6:8); after the waters recede, God establishes a covenant never again to destroy the earth by flood and sets his bow in the cloud as its token (9:11–17). In the eleventh tablet of the Babylonian *Gilgamesh*, the flood-hero Utnapishtim survives the deluge the gods sent, and afterwards the mother goddess lifts up her necklace of lapis lazuli and swears by it that she will never forget those days, a covenant whose token is a jewel, which Chapter 6 will find again in *Titanic*. In

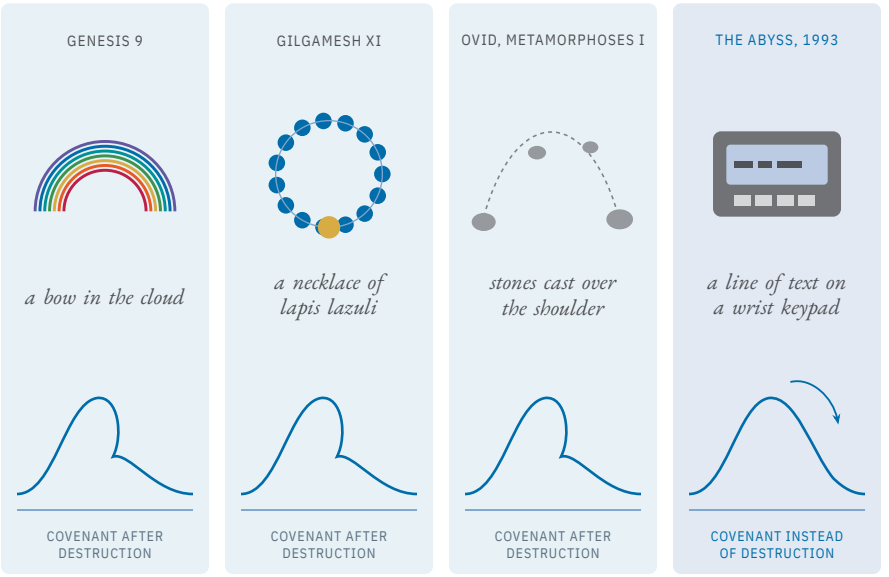


PLATE IX *Tokens of the covenant*

Four flood narratives and their signs. In Genesis, *Gilgamesh*, and Ovid the covenant follows the destruction; in *The Abyss* it replaces it, and the waters withdraw before they fall (§5.5).

5, 854 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

the first book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, Jupiter floods the world after Lycaon's crimes and spares only Deucalion and Pyrrha, a married couple distinguished by their piety and by their devotion to each other, who repopulate the earth by casting stones over their shoulders. The flood myth's righteous survivors are a couple, and *The Abyss*, whose covenant turns on a marriage, belongs to Ovid's version as much as to Moses's.

The film nonetheless alters every version it inherits. In Genesis the covenant follows the destruction; in *The Abyss* the covenant replaces it, and the waters withdraw before they fall. The righteous man is spared not for a general righteousness but for a single act, a descent undertaken in the expectation of death and a message of love sent from the bottom of the world, the Abrahamic logic of §1.5 by which one exemplar redeems the aggregate. And the token of the covenant is not a bow in the sky but a line of text on a wrist keypad at the floor of a trench. The sign of the bathic covenant is bathetic in exactly the sense this dissertation has defined: the cosmic compact between species is sealed with the smallest unit of domestic speech, ungrammatical and enormous.

The difference between the two endings is the difference between grace without law and the dialectic of law and grace. The theatrical ending is evangelical: the

humans are saved without knowing that they were condemned, and their rescue requires no judgment. The Special Edition is Pauline, or Lutheran, in structure: the law is pronounced, the sentence is passed, and only then does grace intervene, so that clemency is experienced as clemency. Critics have often found the restored ending didactic, and it is. But its restoration indicates that the tribunal was always the film's design, cut for length and pacing rather than for meaning, and it supplies the clearest statement anywhere in the corpus of the bathic covenant: a stay of execution, conditional and revocable, granted on the evidence of one act of love and witnessed by a man who will carry the knowledge back to the surface.

The Abyss is accordingly the paradigm of the bathic schema. Its *hypsos* is the nuclear submarine, the sovereign weapon of the age, gliding through the deep; its *lapsus*, the submarine's loss; its *katabasis*, Bud's descent; its *krisis*, the judgment of the intelligences; its *kenōsis*, the one-way ticket; its *diathēkē*, the withdrawn wave and the city that rises bearing the survivors. It is also the most hopeful film in the oeuvre, and its hope is theological in form. The fourth proposition of the bathic cosmology, that the bottom answers, is fulfilled without remainder: the deep is addressed, it judges, and it shows mercy. Every later film in the corpus can be measured by its distance from this answer.

5,904 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

5.6

The Comedy of Surveillance:
True Lies, *the Nuclear Kiss, and the Domestication of Apocalypse*

True Lies (1994), a remake of Claude Zidi's French comedy *La Totale!* (1991) and reportedly among the first productions to cost more than a hundred million dollars, is the corpus's only comedy and the film most often treated as minor. Harry Tasker, an agent of a covert counterterrorism agency called Omega Sector, conceals his profession from his wife Helen, a legal secretary who believes him a computer salesman, and from his teenage daughter Dana, who steals from his wallet and resents his absences. The film transposes the bathic schema into farce. The tribunal becomes an interrogation, the kenosis a confession under truth serum, the *lapsus* a nuclear detonation on an empty island, and the covenant a renewed marriage and a professional partnership. Precisely because it is farce, it reveals what the schema can do when its gravity is removed.

The film is a comedy of remarriage in Cavell's sense (§5.3), and a self-conscious one. The marriage has died of secrecy, and Helen, starved of adventure, is drawn into a romance conducted entirely in fantasy with Simon, a used-car salesman who poses as a spy to seduce women. Her condition is the one Jules de Gaultier named *bovarysme* (1892) after Flaubert's Emma Bovary, the provincial wife destroyed by the romances she mistook for life: the tendency to imagine oneself as other than one is. The film's comic solution is to grant Helen's fantasy in reality. The adventure she sought from a fraud is supplied, at first coercively, by her husband, and Cavell's "creation of the woman" proceeds by her initiation into his world until, in the epilogue a year later, she has become an agent herself, and the couple dance a tango as partners in the trade.

The initiation begins with an abuse of state power that the film half acknowledges and half enjoys. Learning of Helen's meetings with Simon, Harry commandeers the surveillance apparatus of Omega Sector to track, record, and abduct his wife, then interrogates her from behind a one-way mirror with his voice electronically disguised. Michel Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) took Jeremy Bentham's panopticon, a tower from which every inmate can be watched without being able to see the watcher, as the diagram of a disciplinary society in which visibility itself is a trap. The interrogation scene installs the panopticon inside a marriage: the husband invisible, the wife exposed, her confession extracted by an apparatus built for the state's enemies. The comedy depends on the audience's knowledge that the interrogator is a jealous husband; the unease depends on the same knowledge.

5,954 m
ABYSSOPELAGIC

The unease intensifies in the scene that has drawn the film's harshest criticism. Harry assigns Helen a fictitious mission, to pose as a call girl in a hotel room and dance for a man seated in shadow, who is Harry himself. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema is organized by a male gaze that renders woman as image, defined by her "to-be-looked-at-ness," and that its voyeurism is bound up with sadism, since sadism demands a story in which the woman is investigated and controlled. The scene literalizes Mulvey's thesis with almost diagrammatic fidelity: the man in darkness, the woman displayed in light, the camera aligned with the hidden husband, whose pleasure in looking is doubled by his authorship of the scenario she is performing. Jamie Lee Curtis's performance complicates the structure without dissolving it. Helen's awkwardness, her stumble, and her growing boldness turn the humiliation partly into self-discovery, and the scene's comedy belongs to her as much as to the man watching. In the terms of the schema the striptease is a degraded kenosis, a self-exposure extracted by another's power. The true kenosis

comes later, when Harry, captured by terrorists and injected with a truth drug, empties himself of his secrets before his wife, confessing what he is and what he has done. The oxymoron of the title is resolved there: a marriage made true by the confession of its lies.

The film's villains belong to a tradition that Edward Said anatomized in *Orientalism* (1978) and *Covering Islam* (1981), the Western representation of the Arab and Muslim world as irrational, fanatical, and violent. The "Crimson Jihad," led by Salim Abu Aziz, smuggles nuclear warheads concealed in antique statues into the United States; on release the film was protested by the American-Arab Anti-Discrimination Committee, and Jack Shaheen's *Reel Bad Arabs* (2001) placed it among Hollywood's most egregious portrayals. Its comic tone intensifies the stereotype rather than mitigating it. When Aziz records his ultimatum on video, the camera's battery dies in mid-threat: the bathetic method turned against the other, the enemy's grandiose menace deflated into incompetence. *True Lies* has no nonhuman judge, and the position the nonhuman occupies elsewhere in the corpus is filled here by a racialized human enemy, as it was by insects in *Aliens*; the comedy reverts to the colonial-war structure of the earlier film in another key. Its image of a nuclear-armed jihadist, moreover, became within a decade a central figure of American policy discourse, a reminder that the genre's fantasies do not stay in the theatre.

6,004 m
HADOPELAGIC

The film's most remarkable image condenses the entire problem. One of the warheads detonates on an uninhabited island in the Florida Keys, and on the highway Harry and Helen, reconciled, kiss in silhouette against the rising mushroom cloud. Kubrick had closed *Dr. Strangelove* with nuclear explosions set to a sentimental song as satire; Cameron plays the conjunction straight, and the result is the most extreme instance of affective downscaling in the corpus, a nuclear detonation reduced to the backdrop of a marital kiss. Jacques Derrida's "No Apocalypse, Not Now," published in 1984 in the special issue of *Diacritics* that inaugurated "nuclear criticism," argued that nuclear war is "fabulously textual": it has never occurred, it exists only in discourse, and its referent would be the total destruction of the archive that makes discourse possible. Frances Ferguson's "The Nuclear Sublime," in the same issue, read the bomb as the culmination of the Burkean and Kantian sublime. *True Lies* produces the most fabulously textual bomb in cinema: a nuclear explosion without victims, without fallout, without consequence, detonated on an empty key so that it can serve as scenery. The nuclear sublime is domesticated into a picture postcard.

The climax completes the domestication. Aziz kidnaps Dana and carries her to the top of a crane on a Miami skyscraper, and Harry rescues her in a Harrier jump

jet, hovering beside the building while his daughter climbs onto the aircraft. The father's machine, the paternal role that *Terminator 2* had assigned to a cyborg, is here a fighter jet; the family is restored by military hardware. *True Lies* is thus the schema's comic double and its limit case: everything that is redemptive in *The Abyss* is available here as spectacle without cost. Its unease, the surveillance, the gaze, the Orientalism, is the shadow of the bathic method itself. Affective downscaling can humanize a catastrophe, as in *The Abyss*, where the waves are remembered even as they withdraw, or it can trivialize one, as here, where the bomb is forgotten in the kiss. The operation is the same; the difference lies in whether the downscaled scene preserves the magnitude it translates. The next film in the corpus is the one in which the magnitude cannot be forgotten, because it is fifteen hundred people in the water.

6,054 m

HADOPELAGIC

CHAPTER 06

DEPTH 6,154 M · HADOPELAGIC



6

CHAPTER 06

Water II

Titanic *and the Integral Accident*

They that go down to the sea in ships, that do business in great waters; these see the works of the LORD, and his wonders in the deep.

— Psalm 107:23–24

Dim moon-eyed fishes near / Gaze at the gilded gear / And query: "What does this vaingloriousness down here?"

— Thomas Hardy, "The Convergence of the Twain" (1912)

CHAPTER 06 — WATER II

Titanic is the oeuvre's tragedy and its centre of gravity. It was the first film to earn more than a billion dollars worldwide, it won eleven Academy Awards, and it is the film against which the charge of bathos (§1.1) was most insistently pressed. It is also the film in which the bathic cosmology meets history. Its catastrophe is documented rather than imagined, its dead are not fictional, and its wreck, which Cameron visited a dozen times in the submersibles of the Russian research vessel *Akademik Mstislav Keldysh* before shooting a frame of the drama, lies some 3,800 metres down. The bathic schema appears here in its tragic key. Its *hypsos* is the "unsinkable" ship; its *lapsus*, the iceberg; its *katabasis*, both the sinking and the expedition's descent to the wreck; its *krisis*, a night that judges every passenger by conduct; its *kenōsis*, Jack Dawson's death in the water; and its *diathēkē*, a woman's long life and a gift returned to the deep. This chapter reads the film as the integral accident of industrial modernity (§6.1–6.3), as a melodrama of the unknown woman (§6.4), as a feminist katabasis framed by a salvage expedition (§6.5), as a theology of expenditure (§6.6), and as an eschatology of the wreck (§6.7), before turning to the documentaries in which the descent is made real (§6.8). Elementally the film belongs to water in both its states, the liquid sea and the ice that is water made solid, and to steel.

6,254 m
HADOPELAGIC

6.1

The Convergence of the Twain:
Hardy, Conrad, and the Theodicy of the Iceberg

The sinking of the *Titanic* in the early hours of 15 April 1912 was the first catastrophe of the modern world to be experienced as a world event. It was reported by wireless as it happened, investigated by an inquiry of the United States Senate and by the British Wreck Commissioner, preached on in thousands of pulpits, and answered within weeks by poets and novelists. Its meaning was contested from the first, and the contest produced the interpretive positions that Cameron's film would inherit and combine.

Thomas Hardy's "The Convergence of the Twain," written for a charity matinée in aid of the disaster fund and published in the *Fortnightly Review* in June 1912, is the most enduring of the literary responses. Its first half descends to the wreck on the sea floor, where the mirrors meant to reflect the opulent are crawled

over by the sea-worm and the moon-eyed fishes ask what this vaingloriousness is doing down here. Its second half explains the collision. While the ship was being built, "the Immanent Will that stirs and urges everything" prepared for her a "sinister mate," a "Shape of Ice," growing in distant waters, until "the Spinner of the Years" said "Now!" and the consummation came. The poem holds two theses together. The first is moral: the ship is the work of "the Pride of Life" (the phrase is from 1 John 2:16), and its vanity is exposed on the sea floor. The second is metaphysical and more disturbing. The collision is not a punishment but a marriage arranged by an impersonal cosmic will, Hardy's version of Schopenhauer's blind *Wille*, which he had dramatized in *The Dynasts*: no providence intends the disaster, and none could have prevented it. Hardy's iceberg is a bride, not a judge, and his imagery of mating, welding, and consummation makes the poem an epithalamium of catastrophe.

Cameron's film is Hardy's poem with the marriage doubled. The love story of Jack and Rose unfolds in strict parallel with the ship's approach to the ice, and the lovers' consummation, in a motor car in the cargo hold, is followed within minutes by the collision: they run up onto the forward deck, still flushed, as the iceberg slides past. The film fuses the human consummation and the cosmic one exactly as Hardy's imagery had invited, and the structural rhyme is the source of its peculiar emotional force. The lovers' union and the ship's destruction are not cause and effect but convergence, two consummations prepared on parallel tracks and brought together by a will neither party controls.

6,305 m
HADOPELAGIC

The sermons of 1912 read the sinking as divine judgment on pride, and the boast of unsinkability, which had circulated since a trade journal described the ship's class as "practically unsinkable," became the emblem of that pride. Cameron gives the boast to Cal Hockley, who assures Rose's mother that God himself could not sink the ship. The film endorses the indictment of hubris: Bruce Ismay urges a faster crossing so that the newspapers will report an early arrival in New York, and Thomas Andrews admits to Rose that the boats will hold barely half the people aboard. It does not, however, make the iceberg a judge. The sea in *Titanic* is mute (§1.4), and judgment in the film is internal to the human event: the night discloses who each person is, who takes a place in a boat, who stays, who lies, who helps. The tribunal of the nonhuman becomes, in this tragic variant, a tribunal of conduct, closer to the Last Judgment of Matthew 25, in which the nations are judged by their deeds, than to any verdict of the deep.

Joseph Conrad, who had spent two decades at sea, answered both the preachers and the poets with the realism of a master mariner. In "Some Reflections on the Loss of the *Titanic*" (1912) he rejected the language of tragic fate and of di-

vine punishment alike. The ship, he argued, had been built too large, as a floating luxury hotel whose safety had been sacrificed to commercial display, and an older, smaller, better-handled vessel would have survived the same collision; the talk of unsinkability was advertising, and the inquiries were credulous before the shipowners. Conrad's account is the counterweight to Hardy's metaphysics: not the Immanent Will but naval architecture and commerce.

A third position emerged in the press. George Bernard Shaw mocked the heroic romance that had formed around the sinking, the band playing to the end, the officers' gallantry, the rule of women and children first, as a sentimental lie that diverted attention from negligence, and Arthur Conan Doyle answered him with a defence of the heroism of the crew. Cameron's film refuses to choose. It shows the band playing, Andrews standing by his clock, and officers loading the boats with courage, and it shows Ismay slipping into a collapsible, Cal using a child to secure a seat, and stewards keeping steerage below. The film contains Hardy's metaphysics, Conrad's realism, and both sides of the Shaw–Doyle quarrel, and it holds them together by the device that §1.3 called affective downscaling: the convergence of the twain is shown through the convergence of two young people, and the judgment of a civilization through the conduct of individuals on a single night.

6,355 m
HADOPELAGIC

6.2

To Invent the Ship Is to Invent the Shipwreck:

Virilio, Mumford, and the Megamachine

Paul Virilio argued, in the interviews collected as *Cybermonde, la politique du pire* (1996) and in *L'Accident originel* (2005), that every technology invents its own accident: to invent the ship is to invent the shipwreck, to invent the train is to invent derailment, to invent the aeroplane is to invent the crash, and to invent nuclear power is to invent the meltdown. The accident, on this view, is not an exception that interrupts a technology's normal functioning but the hidden face of the technology itself, the moment at which, inverting the Aristotelian distinction, the accident reveals the substance. Virilio's late work extended the argument to what he called the integral accident, a catastrophe of networked systems

that would occur everywhere at once, and his exhibition *Ce qui arrive* at the Fondation Cartier in 2002 assembled a museum of accidents as the true archive of progress. The *Titanic* is the modern paradigm of Virilio's thesis: the largest moving object yet built, carrying an accident proportionate to its size. The film is conscious of this. In its frame narrative a crude computer animation, shown to the aged Rose by a member of the salvage crew, explains the sinking as a computed sequence of flooding compartments, and Rose's dry reply, that the experience of it was rather less clinical, sets testimony against simulation before the film unleashes its own simulation, the most elaborate the cinema had yet produced.

Lewis Mumford's *The Myth of the Machine* (1967–70) supplies the institutional analysis. The first machine, Mumford argued, was not a mechanical device but a social one, the "megamachine" of human beings organized as interchangeable parts under a centralized command, which built the pyramids; its modern form is the military-industrial complex, governed by what Mumford called the pentagon of power, an interlocking pursuit of power, property, productivity, profit, and publicity. The *Titanic* was a megamachine in this precise sense, a hierarchically organized vessel of some 2,200 human components, from stokers to millionaires, serving a corporate empire: the White Star Line belonged to J. P. Morgan's International Mercantile Marine. Every point of Mumford's pentagon bore on the disaster. Publicity dictated speed, which is why the film's Ismay presses the captain for an early arrival; profit and display dictated the allocation of deck space; and the lifeboats were governed by regulations of the Board of Trade, framed in the 1890s for much smaller ships, that required only sixteen boats for any vessel over ten thousand tons. The *Titanic* carried twenty, more than the law demanded and enough for barely half of those aboard. The catastrophe was legal. It was produced within the rules, by a system functioning as designed, and that is what makes it an accident in Virilio's sense rather than a crime.

6,405 m
HADOPELAGIC

David Nye's *American Technological Sublime* (1994) described the awe that great machines, bridges, dams, skyscrapers, and liners, inspired in the publics that built them, an awe that substituted the grandeur of human making for the grandeur of nature. The *Titanic* was marketed as such an object, and Cameron's camera shares the awe without reservation. The film's long aerial passes along the length of the moving ship, from bow to stern, are among the most rapturous images of a machine in the cinema; its *hypsos* is sincere, and the film loves the thing it will sink. The production itself reproduced the paradox. Built around a near-full-scale replica of the ship in a purpose-made tank on the coast of Baja California, the film went far over budget, and the press predicted a catastrophe;

it became instead the most successful film ever made to that date, and Cameron closed his acceptance speech at the Academy Awards by repeating Jack's cry that he was king of the world. The film's own history thus rehearsed its subject's *hypsos* without the *lapsus*, and many observers heard in the line the very hubris the film had indicted.

Ulrich Beck's *Risikogesellschaft* (1986) argued that modernity produces risks as the by-products of its own success and is forced, in a process he called reflexive modernization, to reorganize itself around the management of the dangers it creates. The *Titanic* inaugurated that process in maritime law. The first International Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, adopted in 1914, required lifeboat places for everyone aboard and a continuous radio watch, and an International Ice Patrol was established to track icebergs in the North Atlantic. The accident produced its own treaty. In the terms of the bathic schema the convention is the disaster's historical *diathēkē*, a covenant struck among the nations after the waters closed, and it remains, in revised form, in force.

The integral accident did not end with the convention. In June 2023 the submersible *Titan*, operated by the company OceanGate on a commercial dive to the wreck, imploded in the deep, killing the five people aboard. Cameron, who had designed and piloted deep submersibles himself, was among the most prominent voices to explain the disaster in public, and he did so in the terms of his own film: he observed that the *Titanic*'s captain had been repeatedly warned about ice and had steamed at full speed into an ice field on a moonless night, and that the submersible's operators had likewise been warned and had proceeded. The wreck of the first great integral accident of the twentieth century became the destination of another, and the man who had made the film about the first explained the second by its precedent. The *lapsus* of the bathic schema, it appears, recurs where the first one lies.

6,455 m
HADOPELAGIC

6.3

Ship of Fools, Ship of Classes:
Steerage, Capital, and the Arithmetic of Lifeboats

The ship has been a figure of the polity since Plato. In the sixth book of the *Republic* (488a–489a), Socrates imagines a vessel whose owner is large and strong but somewhat deaf and short-sighted, whose sailors quarrel over who should steer though none has learned navigation, and whose true navigator, the one who

studies the seasons, the sky, and the winds, is dismissed as a useless stargazer. The *Titanic*, on Cameron's account, is Plato's ship: the owner's representative presses the captain for speed, the lookouts have no binoculars, and the shipbuilder who knows the vessel's limits is consulted only once it is sinking. Sebastian Brant's *Das Narrenschiff* (1494) and the painting of the same subject attributed to Hieronymus Bosch gave the figure its satirical form, a ship of fools carrying every estate of society toward a land of folly, and Michel Foucault opened *Histoire de la folie* (1961) with that ship as the emblem of a culture's relation to its own unreason. Katherine Anne Porter's *Ship of Fools* (1962), set aboard a liner carrying a cross-section of society to Germany in 1931, made the microcosm a vessel steaming toward historical catastrophe. *Titanic* belongs to this lineage: a society in miniature, confident in its order, sailing at full speed toward the event that will disclose it.

The society is arranged vertically. First class occupies the upper decks and the light; third class is lodged below, near the waterline and the engines. The arrangement realizes the bathic allegory of class that H. G. Wells had projected onto the Eloi and the Morlocks (§2.2): those who live below are the first to drown. The film's most damning images show stewards holding steerage passengers behind locked gates as the water rises, and while the historical extent of such barriers remains disputed, the arithmetic of survival is not. Roughly three in five first-class passengers survived the sinking, against roughly one in four in third class; almost all the women of first class were saved, and fewer than half the women of third. The lifeboats had places for about 1,178 people out of some 2,200 aboard, and several were lowered with dozens of seats empty. Rose's mother, learning that there are not enough boats, wonders aloud whether they will be seated according to class and hopes they will not be too crowded, and the line condenses the moral arithmetic of the night into a single anxiety of status.

6,505 m
HADOPELAGIC

Thorstein Veblen's *The Theory of the Leisure Class* (1899) named the logic of the upper decks: conspicuous consumption and conspicuous leisure, the display of wealth through waste and idleness as the currency of social rank. The first-class dining saloon in which Jack, in a borrowed dinner jacket, passes briefly for a gentleman is a Veblenian theatre, and the Heart of the Ocean, a diamond given to a fiancée as a token of the giver's power, is conspicuous consumption distilled to a single object. Molly Brown, new money from the Colorado mines, is tolerated by the old families and mocked behind her back, and her presence marks the class war within the upper decks themselves, between inherited and acquired fortunes.

Rose's own position exposes the economy beneath the display. Her father has died leaving debts, and her mother has arranged her marriage to Cal Hockley, heir

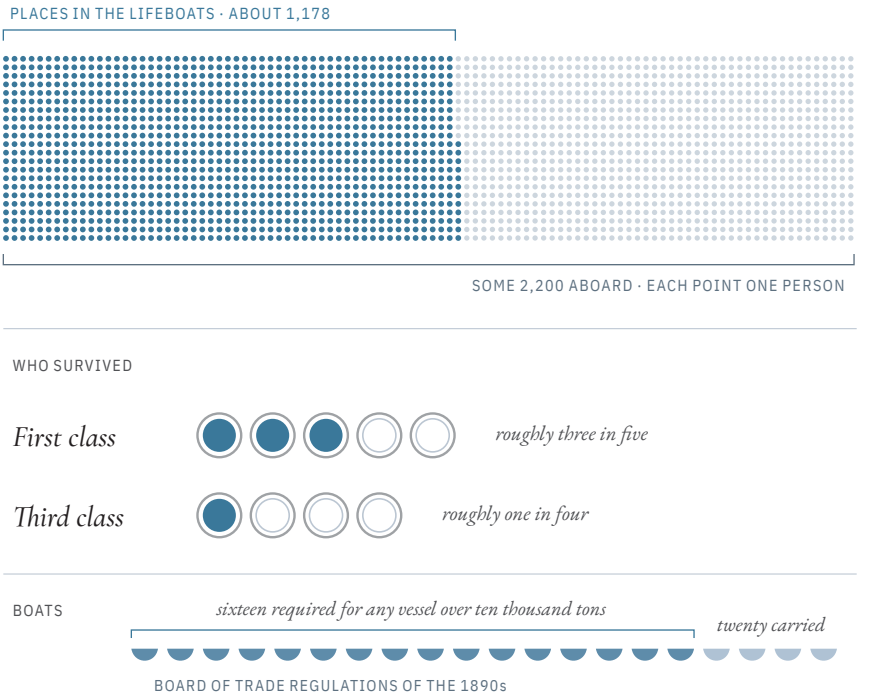


PLATE X *The arithmetic of the lifeboats*

Some 2,200 aboard and places for about 1,178; sixteen boats required by the Board of Trade for any vessel over ten thousand tons, twenty carried. Roughly three in five first-class passengers survived, against roughly one in four in third class. Each point is one person (§6.2, §6.3).

6,555 m
HADOPELAGIC

to a Pittsburgh steel fortune, to restore the family's position. Rose is the family's capital. Mary Wollstonecraft had described marriage contracted for money as a form of legal prostitution in *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792), and Rose turns Wollstonecraft's equation into a slogan of liberation when she tells Cal, as the ship goes down, that she would rather be Jack's whore than his wife. The line inverts the economy that produced her: the freely chosen sexual bond is preferred to the purchased marital one. It is also, in its way, the film's thesis on class. The steel fortune that buys Rose is made of the same material as the hull that sinks, and of the mill in which the Terminator was cast; steel is the oeuvre's substance of capital and catastrophe alike.

The film's class politics have been criticized, with justice, as sentimental. The poor are vital and the rich brittle; third class holds a party of Irish music and dancing while first class dines in stiff ceremony; Jack takes Rose below decks to a real party, and the romance of the people is offered to an audience that, in the

boom years of the late 1990s, was living through a second gilded age of widening inequality. The authenticity the film locates in steerage flatters its viewers more than it analyses the economy that sends steerage to the bottom. Yet the film's moral arithmetic is not merely sentimental. Its night is a tribunal of conduct in which every passenger is judged by what he or she does, and the verdicts cut across class. Andrews apologizes to Rose for not having built her a stronger ship and waits for the end in the first-class smoking room. An elderly couple, modelled on Isidor and Ida Straus, the department-store owner and his wife who refused to be separated, lie embraced in their bed as the water fills the cabin. Cal, among the richest men aboard, uses a frightened child to secure a seat in a boat; Ismay, the owner's representative, slips into a collapsible. The sea is indifferent to class, but the film is not indifferent to conduct, and its judgments distribute honour and disgrace by a standard that wealth cannot buy.

6.4

The Unknown Woman:

Cavell, Ibsen, and Rose's Metamorphosis

In *Contesting Tears* (1996), Cavell identified a second Hollywood genre as the negation of the comedy of remarriage (§5.3). In the melodrama of the unknown woman, whose exemplars include *Stella Dallas* (1937), *Now, Voyager* (1942), *Gaslight* (1944), and *Letter from an Unknown Woman* (1948), the heroine achieves her selfhood not through a marriage of mutual acknowledgment but by refusing a marriage, or a man, that would deny her existence. Her metamorphosis carries her beyond the knowledge of those who would define her, and the films characteristically end with her alone: Stella walking away in the rain from the wedding she has made possible by her absence, Charlotte Vale declining to ask for the moon because she has the stars. *Titanic* belongs to this genre more precisely than to any other, and it transforms the genre in one decisive respect.

6,605 m
HADOPELAGIC

At the outset Rose is a young woman possessed. Engaged to a man who regards her as his wife in practice if not yet in law, displayed in a world whose rituals she experiences as suffocation, she goes to the stern of the ship at night intending to throw herself into the sea. The scene recalls Kate Chopin's *The Awakening* (1899), in which Edna Pontellier, awakened to desire and to a self her marriage had no room for, swims out into the Gulf until she can swim no further; Rose

at the rail is Edna on the brink, and Jack Dawson's intervention converts a suicide into a beginning. The film's middle movement is Henrik Ibsen's *A Doll's House* (1879) played aboard a liner. Like Nora, Rose discovers that the husband her family has chosen regards her as a possession, and her refusal is as theatrical as Nora's slammed door: she spits in Cal's face, and later she leaps from a descending lifeboat back onto the sinking ship rather than be saved without the man she has chosen.

Her metamorphosis is completed by the disaster. Rescued, she gives her name to an officer of the *Carpathia* as Rose Dawson, taking the surname of the man who died for her, and hides under a blanket as Cal searches the survivors in steerage; her mother and her fiancé come to believe her drowned. She disappears from the historical record and lives a life that no document contains. The film's coda shows it in photographs on her bedside table: Rose on horseback on a beach, Rose beside an aeroplane, Rose as an actress, the life Jack had imagined for her, lived in full. The unknown woman of Cavell's genre is unknown to the men who would possess her and to the world that would record her; Rose is unknown to both for eighty-four years, until she chooses to speak at the age of a century. The metamorphosis has a classical model in the first book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, where Daphne escapes Apollo's pursuit by becoming a laurel tree; Rose escapes Cal by becoming another woman, under another name, beyond his knowledge.

The transformation of the genre lies in Jack. In Cavell's melodramas the man fails to know the woman; the drama is her discovery that she must find her existence without his acknowledgment. In *Titanic* the man knows her. Jack sees Rose as no one in her world sees her, and the film makes his seeing literal in the scene in which she asks him to draw her, wearing nothing but Cal's diamond. The scene invites comparison with the striptease of *True Lies* (§5.6), and the comparison is instructive. There, a woman performs for a man hidden in darkness who has authored her humiliation; here, a woman authors the scene of her own display, chooses her viewer, and wears her fiancé's token of possession as the only garment of her emancipation. The male gaze is not abolished, and Mulvey's analysis still applies to the camera that frames the scene, but its direction within the fiction is reversed: the drawing is Rose's commission and Rose's record. Yet the genre reasserts itself. The man who knows her must die, and Rose's selfhood is lived for eighty-four years in the solitude Cavell's heroines inhabit, sustained only by the memory of having once been known.

6,655 m
HADOPELAGIC

The film announces its consciousness of these questions with unusual frankness. At a first-class luncheon, when Bruce Ismay explains that he chose the ship's name to convey its sheer size, Rose asks him whether he knows of Dr. Freud,

whose ideas about the male preoccupation with size might interest him. The joke is a declaration of the film's psychoanalytic awareness and of its heroine's modernity. Rose collects paintings by Picasso, whom Cal dismisses as a painter who will never amount to anything, and the ship that carries her is the Edwardian world sailing on the eve of modernism and of the Great War, which would end that world two years later. One small detail rewards the reader who has followed the genealogy of §2.1. Jack Dawson comes from Chippewa Falls, Wisconsin, a town named, like the village of Chippawa on the Niagara River where Cameron grew up, for the Ojibwe people. The author-function forbids reading too much into the coincidence, and the bathic reading cannot resist noting it: the young artist who teaches Rose to look at the world is given an inland origin beside a river and its falls.

6.5

Diving into the Wreck:

Adrienne Rich, Telepresence, and the Recovery of Memory

The drama of 1912 is framed by an expedition of 1996. A treasure hunter, Brock Lovett, works the wreck from the *Keldysh* with its Mir submersibles and a remotely operated vehicle, searching for the Heart of the Ocean in Cal Hockley's safe. The safe yields only sodden papers and a drawing of a nude young woman wearing the diamond, dated the night of the sinking. Rose, now a century old, sees the drawing on television and telephones the ship; flown out with her granddaughter, she tells the story that is the film. The frame's images of the real wreck were shot by Cameron on his 1995 dives, so that the deepest layer of the fiction is documentary.

6,705 m
HADOPELAGIC

Adrienne Rich's "Diving into the Wreck" (1973) is the frame's indispensable intertext. Its speaker, having read the book of myths, loads a camera, checks the edge of a knife, and climbs alone down a ladder into the sea to explore a wreck, having come for "the thing itself and not the myth." At the bottom her identity doubles, mermaid and merman at once, and the poem closes among those who find their way back to the wreck carrying a book of myths in which their names do not appear. Rich made the dive a figure of feminist recovery: a descent into a damaged history to see the damage done and recover what has survived it, against the myths that have excluded women. *Titanic*'s frame stages the poem with remarkable precision. A male expedition descends to recover a treasure, the

myth, the diamond, the insured value, and finds instead a woman's story. The aged woman takes over the expedition's narrative, recounting both the damage, the marriage market, the possessive fiancé, the gates below decks, and what survived it, her own life. Her name, moreover, does not appear in the record. Rose DeWitt Bukater was listed among the lost; the woman who survived was Rose Dawson, and no document bore witness to her. Rich's book of myths without our names is, in this film, a passenger list.

Rose's telling is a descent into memory, and the film renders it as a dissolve. The corroded bow of the wreck, seen through the submersible's lamps, brightens into the gleaming bow of the ship in 1912; memory restores the wreck. The figure has a precise antecedent in Greek eschatology. The gold tablets buried with initiates of the Orphic and Bacchic mysteries, found at sites from southern Italy to Thessaly, instruct the soul arriving in the underworld to avoid the first spring it will find and to drink instead from the lake of Mnemosyne, Memory, so that it may be saved. Rose at the bottom of her life drinks from Memory rather than Lethe, and her recollection is the form her salvation takes.

The frame is also a meditation on telepresence. Marvin Minsky's essay "Telepresence" (1980) named the sensation of being present at a distance that remote manipulation can produce, and Robert Ballard's small vehicle *Jason Jr.* entered the wreck in 1986. Cameron's own expeditions carried telepresence into the ship's interior, and he has connected the experience of piloting remotely operated vehicles through the wreck, his body in a submersible and his attention in the corridors, to the conception of *Avatar*'s link. Within the film, the vehicle that threads the corridors to Rose's stateroom positions the spectator as its pilot: the audience's first entry into the ship is telepresent, a remote body exploring a place no human body can reach, before memory converts telepresence into presence and the wreck becomes a ship again.

6,755 m
HADOPELAGIC

The frame sets testimony against two rival relations to the past. The first is simulation, the computer animation of the sinking that Rose answers by noting that the experience was less clinical (§6.2). The second is salvage. Lovett's expedition treats the wreck as a deposit of value, standing-reserve in Heidegger's sense, and the film's final movement is his conversion. Watching Rose at the stern, he admits that for three years he has thought of nothing but the *Titanic* and has never let it in. The real wreck has been the object of the same contest. Salvage operations recovered thousands of artefacts for exhibition and sale; in April 2012, a century after the sinking, the wreck came under the protection of the UNESCO Convention on the Protection of the Underwater Cultural Heritage; and an agreement between the United Kingdom and the United States to treat it as an international

memorial entered into force in 2019. The film's verdict anticipates the law's: the wreck is a grave, not a mine.

Rose is the last witness, and the film was made as living memory of the event was ending; the last survivor of the sinking, Millvina Dean, who had been an infant in 1912, died in 2009. The frame narrative is accordingly about transmission. Rose tells her story to a salvage crew and to her granddaughter, and the story passes from the one who was there to those who will carry it. Chapter 9 will find the same structure at the heart of Cameron's Hiroshima project, which he has described as a story handed to him by a dying survivor. *Titanic* is the oeuvre's first film of testimony, and its frame is the first sketch of an ethics of witness that the later project would make explicit.

6.6

The Heart of the Ocean:

Expenditure, the Rhinegold, and the Gift Returned to the Deep

The Heart of the Ocean is a large blue diamond, said in the film to have belonged to Louis XVI and to have been recut into the shape of a heart after the Revolution, an invention modelled on the history of the Hope Diamond. Cal gives it to Rose as an engagement gift, a token of possession; it is the object of Lovett's expedition; Rose wears it, and nothing else, for Jack's drawing; and it ends in the pocket of the coat Cal draped over her as the ship sank. She keeps it for eighty-four years. At the film's end, alone at the stern of the *Keldysh* at night, she opens her hand and lets it fall into the sea above the wreck.

6,805 m
HADOPELAGIC

The film supplies its own gloss. A woman's heart, the aged Rose tells her listeners, is a deep ocean of secrets, and the line is the bathic cosmology stated as a proverb: the deepest place is the heart, and the jewel named for the ocean's heart returns to the ocean while the heart's secret goes with it. The gesture also literalizes a saying of the Sermon on the Mount, which counsels against laying up treasures on earth, "for where your treasure is, there will your heart be also" (Matthew 6:21). Rose's treasure goes where her heart has been for eighty-four years, to the deep, with the man who died there.

Georges Bataille's "La notion de dépense" (1933) and *La Part maudite* (1949) argued that every society produces a surplus that must be spent without return, in luxury, festival, sacrifice, or war, and that sovereignty consists in the capacity

for such expenditure. When the surplus is not spent gloriously, Bataille warned, it is spent catastrophically, and he read the world wars as the convulsive squandering of an industrial abundance that capitalism, devoted to accumulation, refused to spend in any other way. The *Titanic*'s luxury was conspicuous consumption in Veblen's sense, expenditure in the service of rank and accumulation; its sinking was catastrophic expenditure, fifteen hundred lives and a fortune in steel consigned to the deep. Rose's gesture is sovereign expenditure in Bataille's strict sense: the destruction of a fortune for no return, for no purpose but the act itself, and it reverses every economy the film has shown, Cal's possession, her mother's marriage market, and Lovett's salvage.

Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) showed that gifts create obligations, and it drew on the potlatch of the peoples of the Pacific Northwest, documented by Franz Boas, in which chiefs displayed and contested rank by giving away or destroying wealth, among other ways by breaking valuable copper plaques and casting them into the sea. Rose's gesture is a potlatch whose only witnesses are the dead. It confers no rank, since no one sees it, and creates no obligation, since its recipients cannot reciprocate. It approaches the pure gift that Jacques Derrida, in *Donner le temps* (1991), described as impossible because a gift recognized as such is already drawn back into exchange. Rose's gift escapes exchange because it is secret: no one is there to see it, and the salvage crew never learns that the treasure they sought was aboard their own ship.

The most exact precedent is Wagner's. *Das Rheingold* opens on the bottom of the Rhine, where three Rhinemaidens guard a gold that can be forged into a ring of world mastery only by one who renounces love; the dwarf Alberich renounces it, steals the gold, and forges the ring whose curse drives the four dramas of the cycle. *Götterdämmerung* ends when Brünnhilde, before riding into Siegfried's funeral pyre, returns the ring to the Rhinemaidens; the river rises, the ring sinks back into the deep, and Valhalla burns. The Heart of the Ocean is the Rhinegold: wealth bound to the renunciation of love, Cal's possession of Rose and the marriage purchased for her family's solvency, whose curse is broken only by its return to the waters. Rose is Brünnhilde without the pyre, the woman who gives the treasure back to the deep so that it may cease to bind. Wagner's finale unites fire and flood, the burning hall and the overflowing river, in a single Empedoclean catastrophe; *Titanic*'s coda is quieter, a jewel slipping from an old woman's hand into black water.

6,855 m
HADOPELAGIC

The necklace has one more antecedent, in the flood story of *Gilgamesh* (§5.5), where the mother goddess lifts her necklace of lapis lazuli after the deluge and swears by it that she will never forget those days. Rose's necklace has been a pledge

of memory for eighty-four years, kept and never displayed, and its return to the sea completes the pledge: the token goes back to the waters it commemorates.

The film thus stages two economies of the deep, and it chooses between them. The first is salvage, which treats the deep as a deposit from which value can be extracted; the second is offering, which treats the deep as a sanctuary to which value is returned. The frame narrative came to extract; its last act is a return. The choice is the ethical pivot of the bathic cosmology in its tragic key, and it looks forward. *Avatar* will make extraction the engine of its plot, in a mineral whose name, unobtanium, admits that it is a pretext, and the sanctity of what lies below the extractive gaze the substance of its theology. *Titanic*'s final gesture is the oeuvre's first refusal of extraction, made not by a planet but by a woman, alone, at night.

6.7

The Grand Staircase:

The Charon Complex and the Eschatology of the Wreck

After the diamond falls, the camera passes over the photographs on Rose's bedside table and comes to rest on her sleeping face. Then the wreck appears on the sea floor, and the camera moves through it toward the Grand Staircase. Light floods the corroded spaces, and the wreck becomes the ship again, restored to its splendour of 1912. Rose, young once more and dressed as on the night she met Jack, climbs the staircase; the passengers and crew who died stand on the landings and the balcony, people of every class side by side, and they applaud as Jack, waiting by the clock at the top, turns and takes her hand. They kiss. The film leaves open whether Rose has died or is dreaming.

6,905 m
HADOPELAGIC

Bachelard's Charon complex (§1.6) names the reverie that underlies the sequence: the boat of the dead, the dream in which death is a voyage and the last voyage a death. The complex has a long material history. Virgil's Charon ferries the dead across the Styx in the sixth book of the *Aeneid*; the Egyptians buried boats for the dead, among them the great cedar vessel interred beside the pyramid of Khufu; the Norse and Anglo-Saxon elite were laid in ships at Oseberg and Sutton Hoo; Arnold Böcklin painted, in *Die Toteninsel* (1880), a rowing boat carrying a shrouded figure toward an island of cypresses; and Tennyson's "Crossing the Bar" (1889) imagined death as putting out to sea at evening. The *Titanic* is the Charon complex on the scale of an industrial civilization, a floating palace that

became a coffin for fifteen hundred people. The coda reverses the complex. The coffin becomes a hall of reunion, and the boat of the dead becomes a ballroom.

The sequence is also the purest instance of the bathic eschatology of §1.4. Heaven, in this film, is not above but at the bottom of the sea, 3,800 metres down, in the restored interior of a wreck. The staircase is Jacob's ladder (Genesis 28:12), the axis on which messengers ascend and descend between levels of being, and the assembly on its landings is Dante's celestial rose transposed into the architecture of an Edwardian liner. The ship's social order is dissolved in its afterlife: the steerage dead stand beside the first-class dead, and the eschatological reversal of the Gospels, in which the last shall be first (Matthew 20:16), is quietly enacted on a staircase that steerage passengers had been forbidden to climb. The absences are as significant as the presences. Ismay, who survived, is not there; nor is Cal, who survived as well and who, Rose has told us, shot himself after the crash of 1929. The tribunal of conduct of §6.1 reaches its verdict here. The dead are the elect, and the reception is the judgment.

At the head of the staircase stood a carved panel that the real ship's builders called *Honour and Glory Crowning Time*, with a clock at its centre, and it is beneath this allegory that Jack waits. The film has prepared the image. On the night of the sinking, Thomas Andrews, the ship's designer, stands in the first-class smoking room adjusting the clock on the mantelpiece as the water rises around him: the architect setting the time at the end of time. Earlier, Jack had passed Rose a note asking her to meet him at the clock, and the rendezvous is kept across eighty-four years. The eschatology of the wreck is the crowning of time in the precise sense of the carving: Rose's long life, lived in full, is completed and honoured in the place where it was promised.

6, 955 m
HADOPELAGIC

The coda also completes the transformation of Cavell's genre traced in §6.4. The melodrama of the unknown woman ends in solitude; *Titanic* gives its unknown woman a remarriage beyond death, and the melodrama's isolation is transfigured into the comedy of remarriage of §5.3. The structure is once more that of *The Winter's Tale*, in which a wife believed dead is restored after sixteen years; here the lovers are restored to each other after eighty-four.

No sequence in Cameron's work has been more derided, and the derision is the charge of bathos in its most concentrated form: the applause, the clock, the kiss, kitsch at the summit of a tragedy. This dissertation reads the coda as the culmination of the bathetic method. The eschatological sublime, the communion of the dead and the Last Judgment, is rendered in the idiom of a society reception, and that is *sermo humilis* (§1.3) in its purest form, the highest matter in the lowest style. The sequence is also an argument about how the dead should be re-

membered. The film has given its audience the number, fifteen hundred, and the image of the dead floating in the frozen water; its last image of them is a crowd of people the audience has met, the Italian friend, the Irish mother, the band, the officers, the old couple in their bed. Affective downscaling reaches its limit here. The dead are restored not as a statistic or a monument but as faces at a gathering, and the film's final judgment on the catastrophe is that each of them was someone.

6.8

The Expeditionary Supplement:
Ghosts of the Abyss, Aliens of the Deep, *and Challenger Deep*

In *De la grammatologie* (1967) Derrida described the logic of the supplement, an addition to something that seemed complete which reveals, by being added, that the original lacked something. Cameron's documentaries are the supplement of his fiction. In the twelve years between *Titanic* and *Avatar* he directed no fiction feature and devoted much of the interval to expeditions, returning to the deep without a story and revealing, by the return, the fiction's dependence on a real descent it could only stage.

Ghosts of the Abyss (2003) records his 2001 expedition to the wreck in stereoscopic large format, with Bill Paxton, who had played Lovett, as participant and narrator. Two small remotely operated vehicles, built by Cameron's brother Mike and named Jake and Elwood after the Blues Brothers, entered parts of the interior no camera had reached, and reconstructions with actors superimposed translucent figures of passengers and crew onto the ruined spaces they once inhabited, the ghosts of the title. The documentary thus transposes the fiction's coda into its own register, the dead laid over the wreck. During the expedition the crew learned of the attacks of 11 September 2001, and the film records their response: the wreck of 1912 and the towers of 2001, two catastrophes of the technological sublime, were brought together by accident, and Virilio would read the second, in *Ground Zero* (2002), as the integral accident of the global age. The name of the first vehicle deserves a footnote. The machine that carried Cameron's attention into the wreck was called Jake, and so, eight years later, was the man who would carry his consciousness into a Na'vi body.

7,005 m
HADOPELAGIC

Aliens of the Deep (2005), co-directed with Steven Quale, took marine biologists and NASA scientists to hydrothermal vents in the Atlantic and Pacific, where tube worms, shrimp, and microbial mats live on chemical energy from the earth's interior rather than on sunlight, and framed the expeditions as a rehearsal for the search for life in the ocean beneath the ice of Jupiter's moon Europa. Its closing sequence imagines, in animation, luminous intelligent life in that hidden ocean, and so gives *The Abyss*'s non-terrestrial intelligences a scientific hypothesis. The vents carry a philosophical charge as well. In the sixth book of the *Republic* Plato made the sun the image of the Good, the source of growth as well as of visibility. Chemosynthetic communities are life that does not depend on the sun: an empirical image of the bathic inversion, in which life and value are found at the bottom, independent of the light from above.

On 26 March 2012 Cameron descended alone in the *Deepsea Challenger*, a vertical submersible he had co-designed with the Australian engineer Ron Allum, to the floor of the Challenger Deep in the Mariana Trench, 10,908 metres down: the first solo dive to the deepest known point in the ocean and the first human visit since the *Trieste* in 1960. The expedition had been marked by grief, since two of its members, the filmmaker Andrew Wight and the cinematographer Mike deGruy, were killed in a helicopter crash during its preparations. Its record was released as *Deepsea Challenge 3D* (2014), and the submersible was later given to the Woods Hole Oceanographic Institution. Cameron described the floor of the trench as desolate, an almost lunar plain. The director whose fictions had filled the abyss with light found the deepest place on earth nearly empty.

7,055 m
HADOPELAGIC

This is the moment at which the bathic cosmology meets its own reality, and the meeting is instructive. At the deepest point the fourth proposition of §1.4, that the bottom answers, is not confirmed: the Challenger Deep is silent. Taken as a whole, however, the expeditionary record complicates the silence. At the vents, life flourishes without the sun; at the wreck, the dead are present in their absence, in the shoes that lie in pairs on the sea floor where bodies once lay. The documentaries test the cosmology rather than illustrate it. They confirm its hope that life and meaning may be found below, refute its fantasy of a city of light, and preserve its ethics, the treatment of the deep as a place to be entered with reverence and the wreck as a grave.

The fiction fills the abyss with meaning, and the documentaries record the abyss as it is. Cameron's practice contains both, and that is the deepest answer to the charge of bathos: his descents are not only imagined. The body of the author has gone where his characters go, and the sentiment of the films is underwritten by a practice of exposure to the real deep and its dangers. *Titanic* is the corpus's

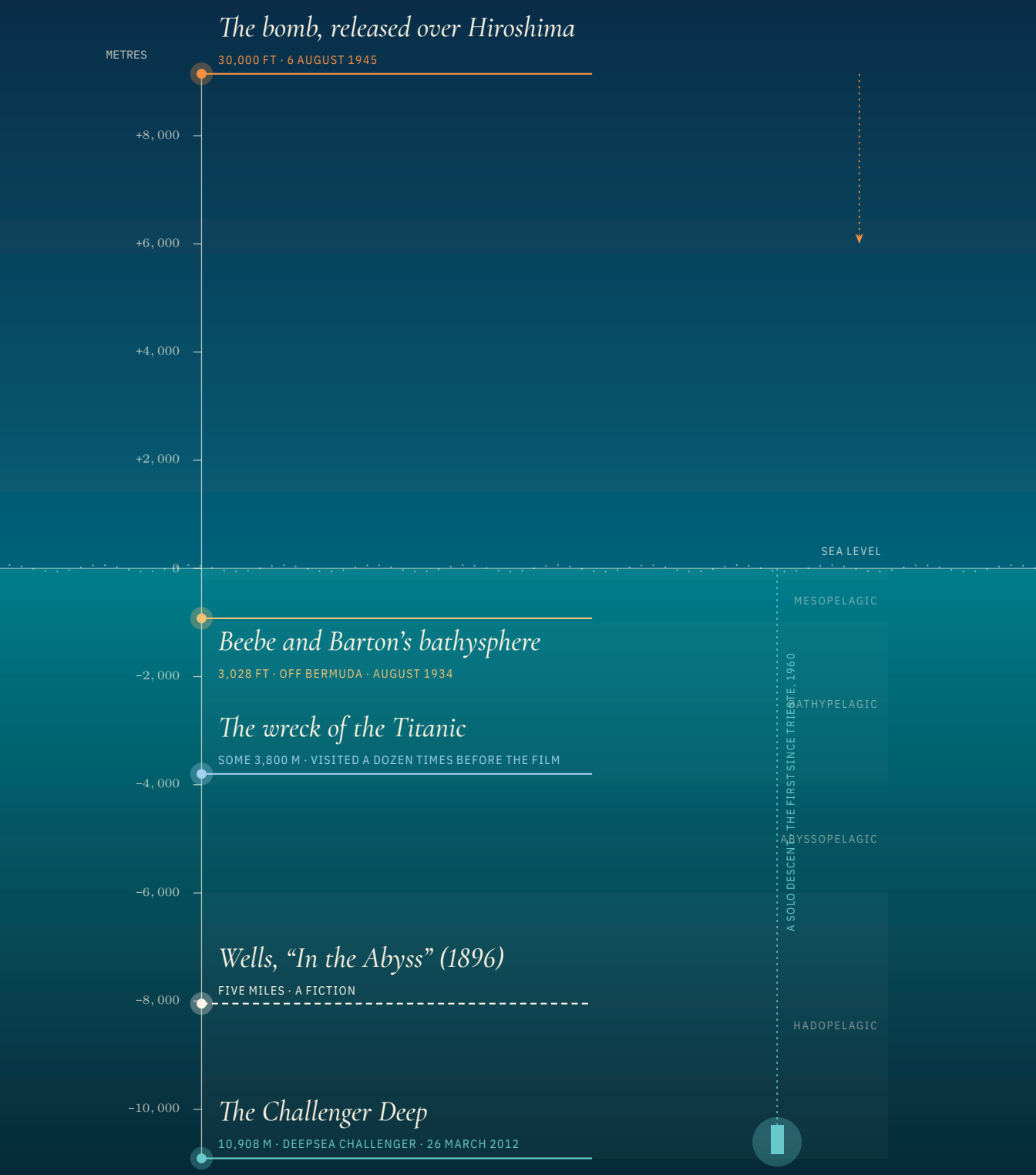


PLATE XI *Soundings*

From thirty thousand feet to the floor of the Challenger Deep: the altitude at which the bomb was released over Hiroshima, the bathysphere's descent of 1934, the wreck of the *Titanic*, the five miles of Wells's "In the Abyss," and Cameron's solo dive of 26 March 2012 (§2.7, §6.8, §9.4).

tragedy because in it the bathic cosmology confronts a historical catastrophe and a real grave, and its achievement is to make the grave a place of covenant: the diamond returned, the wreck protected, the dead remembered as faces. The next chapter rises from water to earth. In *Avatar* the extraction that Rose refused becomes the engine of the plot, and the sanctity of what lies below moves into a living world.



7, 155 m

HADOPELAGIC

CHAPTER 07

DEPTH 7,255 M · HADOPELAGIC

7

CHAPTER 07

Earth

Avatar *and the Phenomenology of the Borrowed Body*

And he called this woman Pandora, because all who dwell on Olympus gave her a gift.

— Hesiod, *Works and Days* 80–82

As a man casts off worn-out clothes and puts on others that are new, so the embodied self casts off worn-out bodies and enters others that are new.

— *Bhagavad Gītā* 2.22

CHAPTER 07 — EARTH

Avatar (2009) moves the bathic cosmology from water to earth, and from a grave to a living world. The film that overtook *Titanic* to become the highest-grossing film ever released is set in 2154 on a moon whose forests conceal both the mineral the colonists want and the network the natives revere, and its plot is the story of a paralysed Marine who enters a body grown for him in a laboratory, is adopted by the people he was sent to deceive, and finally leaves his human body behind. The bathic schema is present in full. Its *hypsos* is the mining colony of Hell's Gate with its gunships and machines; its *lapsus*, the dying Earth the colonists have fled and the felling of the great tree that shelters the Omaticaya clan; its *katabasis*, Jake Sully's daily descent into the link unit and his slower descent into Na'vi life; its *krisis*, the judgment of Eywa; its *kenōsis*, the deaths of Grace Augustine and of the Na'vi warriors and Jake's renunciation of his human form; and its *diathēkē*, the expulsion of the colonists and the transfer of Jake's consciousness into the body in which he will remain. This chapter reads the film through its names (§7.1), its body (§7.2), its politics (§7.3), its goddess (§7.4), its economy (§7.5), its ethics of recognition (§7.6), its place in the oeuvre's central symmetry (§7.7), and its ending (§7.8).

7.1

Pandora, Anesidora:

Hesiod, Harrison, and the Return of the Earth-Goddess

7,355 m
HADOPELAGIC

Cameron named his moon Pandora and set it in orbit around a gas giant called Polyphemus, in the system of Alpha Centauri. Both names come from Greek myth, and both are judgments. Polyphemus is the Cyclops of the ninth book of the *Odyssey*, the one-eyed giant who devours Odysseus's companions and is blinded by the hero who calls himself Nobody, the alias that §2.2 found again in Verne's Nemo. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno, in the first excursus of *Dialektik der Aufklärung*, read the episode as a parable of enlightenment itself: the cunning of Odysseus, who survives by naming himself Nobody, is the prototype of an instrumental reason that masters nature by denying itself. A moon in orbit around the Cyclops is a world under a single eye, and the colonists who survey it through the displays of gunships and mining sensors bring that eye with them.

The name of the moon is the deeper judgment. In Hesiod's *Theogony* (570–612) and *Works and Days* (47–105), Zeus, angered by Prometheus's theft of fire for humankind, orders Hephaestus to fashion a woman out of earth and water; the gods adorn her, and she is named Pandora because all the gods gave her a gift. She opens a great storage jar, a *pithos*, and releases the evils that have afflicted humanity ever since; only Hope remains, caught beneath the rim. Hesiod's Pandora is the punishment for Promethean fire, a beautiful evil (*kalon kakon*) and the origin of women as a curse upon men. The jar became a box only in the Renaissance, when Erasmus rendered the *pithos* as a *pyxis*, a history that Dora and Erwin Panofsky traced in *Pandora's Box: The Changing Aspects of a Mythical Symbol* (1956).

Jane Ellen Harrison proposed that Hesiod had inverted an older figure. In her essay on Pandora's box (1900) and in *Prolegomena to the Study of Greek Religion* (1903) she argued that Pandora, the All-Giver, had originally been a name or epithet of the Earth herself, who sends up gifts from below. She pointed to a fifth-century drinking cup on which the newly fashioned woman is labelled Anesidora, she who sends up gifts; to vase paintings showing a goddess rising out of the ground; and to a line in Aristophanes' *Birds* (971) prescribing a sacrifice to Pandora, which an ancient commentator glossed as the Earth, since she bestows all things necessary for life. On Harrison's reading, Hesiod's misogyny converted the earth-mother's gifts into a jar of evils and the goddess into a trap. Classicists have since found the evidence for a pre-Hesiodic earth-goddess suggestive rather than conclusive, but the interpretation has lasted because it names a recurrent movement in Greek religion, which Harrison's *Themis* (1912) pursued more broadly: the overlaying of chthonic, maternal cults by the Olympian order of a sky-father.

7,405 m
HADOPELAGIC

Cameron's Pandora is Harrison's, not Hesiod's. It is a world whose gifts come up from below: the floating mountains upheld by the mineral in their depths, the bioluminescent flora that answers a footstep with light, the roots that carry memory, the seeds of the sacred tree that rise into the air like drifting jellyfish and settle on the one Eywa has chosen. Anesidora is restored. In the same mythic register the human colonists play the part Hesiod assigned to the jar. They arrive from the sky, a Promethean race punished by the loss of their own world, which Jake tells Eywa is dying because its people killed their mother, and they bring with them the evils of extraction, war, and contempt. What remains under the rim when the colonists are expelled is hope in the form of a remnant, the scientists and the defector permitted to stay. The title of the third film makes the Promethean frame explicit. In *Fire and Ash*, fire reaches Pandora's own people,

and the gift Prometheus stole for humanity becomes the weapon of a Na'vi clan that has renounced its goddess (§8.6).

Harrison's Anesidora is the mythological statement of the bathic cosmology of §1.4. The gifts of the earth rise from below, while the curse descends from above, imposed by a sky-father as punishment for a theft of fire. *Avatar* takes the side of the chthonic mother against the Olympian order, and it figures the Olympians in its own terms: the colonists' shuttles and gunships descend from orbit like gods visiting a world beneath them, and the mineral they come for, a room-temperature superconductor that the company's administrator values at twenty million dollars a kilogram, is the gift of the earth converted into a commodity. Its name, unobtanium, borrowed from engineers' slang for a material too ideal to exist, confesses what the plot requires: a pretext for extraction so pure that it can be named only as a joke. The film's question is whether the gifts that rise from below can be received rather than taken, and the rest of this chapter follows its answer through the body, the community, the goddess, and the machine.

7.2

Call Me Jake:

Poul Anderson, Merleau-Ponty, and the Narrative Prosthesis

7,455 m

HADOPELAGIC

Jake Sully is a former Marine paralysed from the waist down in combat, who cannot afford the spinal surgery that might restore his legs. He comes to Pandora in place of his murdered twin brother, a scientist in the avatar program, because an avatar can be operated only by someone whose genome matches the one from which it was grown. The premise is Poul Anderson's "Call Me Joe" (§2.3) almost point for point: a disabled operator, a body bred for an alien environment, a link across distance, a growing preference for the alien life, and a final transfer of consciousness. Anderson's title, the assertion of a new name, finds its counterpart in the film's ending, when Jake signs off his last video log and the next image is his transfer into the body in which he will remain.

The film's phenomenological core is its first link. Jake wakes in the avatar's body in a laboratory, ignores the doctors' instructions to lie still, stands, staggers, and runs out into the compound, where he stops to dig his toes into the soil. The scene celebrates the restoration not of a body as an object but of the body as capacity. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phénoménologie de la perception* (1945) argued that the body is not an object in the world but our means of having a world at

all, the vehicle of our being in the world, and that consciousness is originally not an "I think" but an "I can." Its organizing concept is the body schema, the pre-reflective structure of motor possibilities through which the world presents itself as a field of things to be reached, grasped, and crossed. Merleau-Ponty's most famous illustration is the blind man's cane, which through habit ceases to be an object and becomes an extension of the body, a zone of sensitivity at whose tip the world is felt; his other is the woman with a feathered hat who passes through doorways without calculating its height. The avatar is the cane raised to the scale of a whole body: an instrument incorporated so completely into the body schema that it becomes the body. Jake's joy is the joy of a recovered "I can."

Merleau-Ponty's analysis of the phantom limb illuminates the reverse side of the experience. The amputee continues to feel the missing limb, he argued, because the habitual body, the sedimented layer of motor projects, persists after the actual body can no longer realize them. Jake's situation is the phantom limb inverted: his habitual body, the body of a soldier, persists in his self-understanding while his actual legs no longer answer it, and the avatar fulfils the projects the habitual body still holds. Drew Leder's *The Absent Body* (1990) distinguished the ordinary disappearance of the body in fluent action, when we attend to the world rather than to our limbs, from its dys-appearance in pain, illness, or dysfunction, when the body becomes an obstacle and a theme. Jake's human body is a body of dys-appearance: the wheelchair, the wasted legs, the indignities of transfer from chair to bed. The avatar is a body of disappearance, transparent to its projects, and the film's spectacle of running, climbing, and flight is the spectacle of a body vanishing into the world it inhabits.

The disability critique of the film is serious and, in its central claim, correct. David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder's *Narrative Prosthesis* (2000) showed that disability serves in narrative as a pervasive device on which stories lean for characterization and plot, and that the typical disability narrative introduces a deviant body, explains its origin, and then resolves the deviance by curing, killing, or transcending it. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's *Extraordinary Bodies* (1997) named the normate, the identity constructed by those whose bodily configuration allows them to occupy the position of authority. *Avatar* fits both analyses. Jake's paralysis drives the plot, since it makes him vulnerable to Quaritch's offer of surgery in exchange for intelligence, and the film resolves it by abandoning the disabled body for a superior one, implying that a disabled life is a condition to be escaped rather than lived. Disability scholars and activists raised this objection when the film was released, and nothing in the present reading dissolves it.

7,505 m
HADOPELAGIC

Three features of the film complicate the objection without refuting it. First, Jake's disability is framed economically. The surgery that could restore his legs exists, he explains, but not on a veteran's benefits; disability here is in part a function of poverty, the cure is a commodity, and Quaritch's offer to buy it for him is a bribe that Jake ultimately refuses. Second, the film's final recognition scene, discussed in §7.6, extends its central greeting to Jake's disabled human body before the transfer: Neytiri, holding his human form in her arms, sees him as he is. Third, the avatar is itself a prosthesis. The film does not oppose a natural body to a technical one; it chooses one prosthesis over another. Bernard Stiegler's account of the human as originarily prosthetic (§1.7) applies here with full force, and it undoes the cure narrative from within, since Jake's "cure" is a more complete dependence on a technical supplement than his wheelchair ever was.

The Na'vi call him Jakesully, fusing his two names into one, and the new name marks the condition the film celebrates and its critics distrust: a self that has passed into the body it once operated. Anderson's Anglesey became Joe when his human body died. Jake becomes Jakesully by choosing, at the end, to let his human body go. The difference between the two stories is the element of choice, and §7.8 returns to it through the oldest myth of a soul that chooses its next life.

7.3

The Word for World:

Le Guin, Deloria, and the Going-Native Romance

7,556 m
HADOPELAGIC

Avatar is a going-native romance, and §2.4 identified its nearest literary ancestor in Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972): a forested world logged by colonists, a racist officer, an anthropologist who loves the natives, and an uprising that expels the invaders. It also identified the two divergences that define the film's ideology. *Avatar* transfers the agency of liberation from the native Selver to the white defector Jake, and it presents the natives' violence as deliverance rather than as the contamination Le Guin's novella mourns. The present section follows these divergences into the critical traditions that have examined the going-native narrative as a genre.

Philip J. Deloria's *Playing Indian* (1998) traced a long American practice of constructing identity by dressing as Indians, from the colonists disguised as Mohawks at the Boston Tea Party through the fraternal orders and the Boy Scouts to the counterculture of the 1960s, and showed that the practice appropriated

an imagined Indianness while actual Native people were dispossessed. *Avatar* literalizes playing Indian: the avatar is a costume body of the native, grown in a laboratory and worn by the colonizer, whom the Omaticaya call a dreamwalker. Shari Huhndorf's *Going Native* (2001) argued that the narratives in which white protagonists adopt Native identity, from *Dances with Wolves* (1990) to New Age spirituality, express a desire to possess indigeneity and thereby to legitimate the settler's presence on the land. Jake ends the film as leader of the clan and Neytiri's mate, the colonizer's dream of becoming the rightful native fulfilled. Robert Berkhofer's *The White Man's Indian* (1978) traced the image of the noble savage through which Europeans and Americans had imagined Native peoples, and the Na'vi are noble savages of a composite kind: their bows, horses, and war paint evoke the Plains nations of the Western, other features evoke African and South Asian iconography, and the sequels add the Polynesian. A composite indigeneity is everyone's and no one's. The film's lineage of white leaders of native peoples, from *Lawrence of Arabia* (1962) and *A Man Called Horse* (1970) to *Dances with Wolves* and *The Last Samurai* (2003), earned it a derisive nickname at its release, *Dances with Smurfs*, which named the genre with economy.

The critique was articulated within weeks. Annalee Newitz asked in December 2009 when white filmmakers would stop making films in which a white man becomes the greatest member of a nonwhite people; David Brooks, in the *New York Times* the following month, diagnosed the film's "white messiah" fable; and Slavoj Žižek, writing in the *New Statesman* in March 2010, read it as an ideological fantasy that allowed its audience to identify with the victims of extraction while consuming its spectacle, and set against it the real struggle of the Dongria Kondh people in Orissa against the mining company Vedanta, which sought bauxite in their sacred Niyamgiri hills. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) supplies the formal version of the critique. The film's narration comes from Jake's video logs, the colonizer's archive; the Na'vi are spoken for, and their own voice reaches the narrative chiefly through the speech of a defector. Frantz Fanon's *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961) insisted that decolonization is the work of the colonized themselves, and the film's resistance is led by the colonizer who changed sides.

7,605 m
HADOPELAGIC

These critiques are correct about the text, and this dissertation does not dispute them. What complicates them is the film's history in the world, which no reading of the text alone can predict. In January 2010 Bolivia's president, Evo Morales, praised the film as a portrayal of indigenous resistance to capitalist extraction. The advocacy organization Survival International published an appeal in the trade press, addressed to Cameron, on behalf of the Dongria Kondh, in-

sisting that while *Avatar* was fiction, their struggle against the mine was real. In February 2010 demonstrators in the West Bank village of Bil'in painted themselves blue and dressed as Na'vi to protest the separation barrier, and commentators in China noted the film's resonance with forced demolitions of homes for development. Cameron himself travelled to the Xingu River in Brazil that year and joined Kayapó leaders campaigning against the Belo Monte dam, which was nonetheless built.

In these episodes the dispossessed played Na'vi. They appropriated the colonizer's fantasy of the native as an instrument of protest, and Deloria's structure was reversed: not the colonizer dressing as the native in order to claim the land, but the colonized dressing as the colonizer's fictional native in order to make their own dispossession legible to the colonizer's media. A white-saviour fable became, in the hands of those it had ventriloquized, a vocabulary of resistance. The reversal does not redeem the film's ideology, but it shows that ideology and use can diverge, and that the bathic method of §1.3, which renders a vast political wrong legible through a single story, can be seized by those whose story it displaced. The sequels, as Chapter 8 argues, begin slowly to return the agency the first film withheld. *Fire and Ash*, in which a Na'vi people takes up the colonizer's weapons and turns against the goddess the first film celebrated, brings Le Guin's ending to Pandora, and with it the recognition that the natives of the fable were never only noble.

7.4

7,656 m
HADOPELAGIC

Eywa:
Gaia, Symbiogenesis, and the Wood-Wide Web

After the destruction of Hometree, Grace Augustine tries to explain to the company's administrator what he has destroyed. Pandora's trees, she says, communicate electrochemically through their roots, like the synapses between neurons; each tree has some ten thousand connections to the trees around it, and there are a trillion trees on the moon, which makes a network with more connections than a human brain. The Na'vi can access it, uploading and downloading memories at sacred sites like the one the company has just levelled. Grace speaks as a scientist, the author of the standard work on Pandoran botany; the Na'vi speak of the Great Mother. The film's theology lies in the convergence of the two vocabularies.

The first scientific source is the Gaia hypothesis. James Lovelock, working with Lynn Margulis, proposed in the early 1970s that the biosphere, atmosphere, oceans, and soils form a single self-regulating system that maintains conditions favourable to life, and he popularized the idea in *Gaia: A New Look at Life on Earth* (1979). The name, suggested by the novelist William Golding, was that of the Greek goddess of the earth, and the hypothesis has been dogged ever since by the question whether it describes a cybernetic system or smuggles in a deity. Eywa answers the question by being both. She is the regulating system Grace describes, and she is the mother to whom the Na'vi pray, and the film's climax depends on the possibility that the system can hear a prayer.

The second source is Margulis's own work. Her theory of endosymbiosis, first published in 1967, argued that the mitochondria and chloroplasts of complex cells originated as free-living bacteria engulfed by other cells and retained as partners, and her *Symbiotic Planet* (1998) proposed that evolution proceeds as much by symbiosis and merger as by competition. The Na'vi neural bond, *tsaheylu*, is symbiogenesis made behavioural. Through the tendrils at the end of the queue a rider joins a mount, a flying ikran or a six-legged pa'li, in a union of nervous systems, and Neytiri explains that the bond with an ikran is made once and for life. Na'vi bodies are built to connect; their anatomy presupposes partnership.

The third source is the research on mycorrhizal networks. In 1997 Suzanne Simard and her colleagues reported in *Nature* that carbon passes between trees through the fungal threads that link their roots, and the journal's cover named the phenomenon the wood-wide web. Simard's later *Finding the Mother Tree* (2021) described large, old trees that nurture seedlings through these networks, and *Fire and Ash* makes the fungal network the agent of its central miracle, when Kiri joins her queue to the mycelium in the soil so that a suffocating human boy can breathe. The science is younger and more contested than its popular versions suggest. A review published in 2023 by Justine Karst and colleagues in *Nature Ecology & Evolution* argued that claims about resource sharing, signalling, and maternal care in forest fungal networks had outrun the field evidence. Eywa is speculative fiction built on a contested science, much as Skynet was built on a speculative one; her network is not a report but a hypothesis dramatized.

7,706 m
HADOPELAGIC

Philosophically, Eywa belongs to a long tradition of thinking about the divinity of nature. Spinoza's *Ethics* (1677) identified God with nature, *Deus sive Natura*, though Spinoza's God neither hears nor answers prayer. Pierre Teilhard de Chardin's *Le Phénomène humain* (1955) imagined a noosphere, a layer of thought enveloping the earth and converging toward an Omega Point of unified consciousness; Eywa is a biosphere that has become a noosphere without

passing through human technology. Bron Taylor's *Dark Green Religion* (2010) described the spread of spiritualities that treat nature as sacred, from animism to Gaian earth religion, and his edited volume *Avatar and Nature Spirituality* (2013) documented the film's role as a vehicle for them among its audiences.

The film's most important theological question concerns Eywa's partisanship. Neytiri tells Jake, when he prays at the Tree of Souls, that the Great Mother does not take sides and protects only the balance of life. Then Eywa takes sides, and the fauna of Pandora join the battle against the company's forces. The reversal admits two readings. On Lovelock's model it is not partisanship at all: the colonists are a perturbation that threatens the system's balance, and the biosphere's response restores it. On the model Isabelle Stengers proposed in *Au temps des catastrophes* (2009) and Bruno Latour developed in *Face à Gaïa* (2015), Gaia is neither a benevolent mother nor a neutral thermostat but a touchy, intrusive power that reacts to human action without regard for human intentions, a new kind of sovereign with which politics must reckon. The film wants both readings at once, the mother who hears and the system that reacts, and it states the conjunction in Grace's last words. Dying at the Tree of Souls, as the Na'vi attempt to transfer her consciousness into her avatar, she tells Jake that she is with the goddess and that the goddess is real. The scientist who described the network as a network meets it, at death, as a presence. The film's theology resides in that sentence, where the empirical and the religious vocabularies finally coincide.

The Stengers–Latour reading also prepares the sequels. If Eywa is a system that reacts rather than a mother who loves, then the experience of the Ash People in *Fire and Ash*, whose homeland was destroyed by a volcanic catastrophe in which Eywa did not intervene, is not a betrayal but a property of the system. A Gaian goddess protects the balance of life, not the lives of particular peoples, and the question the third film poses, why the Mother did not save her children, is the question of theodicy transposed to a planet (§8.5).

7,756 m
HADOPELAGIC

7.5

Gestell and Unobtanium:
Heidegger, Leo Marx, and the Machine in the Garden

Heidegger's "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) distinguished modern technology from earlier crafts not by its tools but by its mode of revealing. Modern technology, he argued, is *Gestell*, enframing: it challenges nature to deliver

energy that can be extracted, stored, and distributed, and it reveals everything it touches as standing-reserve, *Bestand*, a stock awaiting use. His examples are instructive for this chapter. The Rhine, dammed into a hydroelectric plant, becomes a supplier of water pressure; and the forester who measures felled timber in the woods is, whether he knows it or not, at the disposal of an industry that orders cellulose for paper, which is delivered to newspapers and illustrated magazines. Heidegger's emblem of enframing in the forest is the pulp mill, and §2.1 found such a mill in the town where Cameron was born. Selfridge, the company's administrator, states the doctrine of *Gestell* in a sentence: the grey rock beneath the forest sells for twenty million dollars a kilogram, and it is the only reason the company is on Pandora. The forest has no value except as an obstacle, and the people who live in it are an obstacle that speaks.

The film gives enframing an image. As a giant bulldozer advances on the Tree of Voices, where Jake and Neytiri have been joined, Jake leaps onto the machine and smashes the cameras through which its remote operator sees the forest. The gesture blinds the machine's eye, and §7.1 has already supplied its mythic name: on a moon that orbits the Cyclops, the defector repeats Odysseus's act against the one-eyed giant, now turned against the colonist's monocular gaze. The assault on Hometree that follows is the destruction of a dwelling. In "Bauen Wohnen Denken" (1951) Heidegger argued that to dwell is to be at peace in a place, sparing and preserving what one lives among, and he took from Hölderlin the phrase that man dwells poetically. The Omaticaya dwell in Hometree in this sense; the company does not dwell anywhere on Pandora. It occupies and extracts, and its gunships felling the great tree with incendiary missiles, while the clan flees through gas and fire, are enframing executing its verdict on dwelling.

Leo Marx's *The Machine in the Garden* (1964) traced the American pastoral ideal through the repeated scene he called the interrupted idyll, of which his emblem was Nathaniel Hawthorne's notebook entry of 1844 recording a summer reverie in the woods near Concord shattered by the whistle of a locomotive. Marx distinguished a sentimental pastoralism, an escapist withdrawal into idealized nature, from a complex pastoralism that admits the machine's counterforce into the vision and holds the two in tension. *Avatar* is sentimental pastoral in its narrative and complex pastoral in its existence. Its story withdraws into an idealized forest and expels the machine; the film itself is the machine in the garden, since Pandora was made by one of the largest digital rendering operations ever assembled and marketed with fast-food and soft-drink promotions that its critics did not fail to notice. The paradox examined in §1.7 is nowhere sharper. The film that indicts

7,806 m
HADOPELAGIC

enframing is a product of it, and its ravishing forest is standing-reserve of another kind, a resource for the entertainment industry.

The mineral's name deserves a further word. Unobtanium had long been engineers' slang for a material with ideal properties that cannot be obtained, and the film's use of it as a room-temperature superconductor, apparently vital to the energy economy of a dying Earth, gives the joke an unexpected prescience. In the 2020s the energy transition has generated demand for so-called critical minerals, lithium, cobalt, nickel, and the rare earths, whose extraction has repeatedly displaced indigenous and rural communities, and it has revived proposals to mine polymetallic nodules from the deep-ocean floor, a project debated at the International Seabed Authority. The mining of the sea floor joins the extractive logic of *Avatar* to the bathic cosmology of the whole oeuvre, and it recalls the cover story under which, half a century ago, a ship built to recover a sunken nuclear submarine was presented to the world as a vessel for mining the deep (§2.7). Unobtanium is no longer a joke about the impossible. It is a name for whatever the next extraction requires.

The film's argument is nonetheless not anti-technological, and the distinction matters. Heidegger was careful to say that the essence of technology is nothing technological, and that the danger lies not in machines but in a mode of revealing that admits no other. *Avatar* draws the same line. The Na'vi possess their own technology of connection, the queue and the network; the avatar program is a technology used, at least by Grace, for understanding rather than extraction; and Grace's science, which reveals the forest as a network of astonishing intricacy and loves what it reveals, is closer to the *poiēsis* Heidegger opposed to enframing than to the company's survey. The enemy is not technology but *Gestell*, the reduction of a living world to a deposit. Hölderlin's lines, with which Heidegger closed his essay (§1.7), describe the film's wager exactly: where the danger is, the saving power grows as well, and in *Avatar* it grows from the same laboratory that grew the body Jake will finally inhabit.

7,856 m
HADOPELAGIC

7.6

I See You:
Hegel, Buber, Levinas, and the Ethics of Tsaheylu

The Na'vi greet one another with a phrase the film renders as I see you, *oel ngati kameie*, and it makes the phrase carry more than sight. To see someone, in

the Omaticaya sense, is to understand and acknowledge them. Neytiri, who first spares Jake only because the floating seeds of the sacred tree settle on him as a sign, tells him that he is like a child and that she cannot see him; the narrative of their love is the narrative of her coming to see him and of his learning to be seen. The phrase becomes their vow, and it is spoken one last time when Neytiri, after the battle, cradles Jake's human body. The film's final image is an eye opening.

Hegel's *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) made recognition the condition of selfhood. Self-consciousness, Hegel argued, attains certainty of itself only by being acknowledged by another self-consciousness, and the struggle for recognition that follows issues first in the asymmetry of lordship and bondage, in which one party is recognized and the other is not. One-sided recognition fails, since the master is acknowledged only by one he does not acknowledge; only mutual recognition achieves what Hegel called spirit, the I that is a We and the We that is an I. The colonial relation on Pandora is lordship and bondage without even the master's need for the slave's acknowledgment: the company's soldiers call the Na'vi blue monkeys, and the administrator calls them savages. Jake's education is the passage from one-sided to mutual recognition. He arrives as a spy, seeing in order to report, and ends as a member, seen and seeing. Axel Honneth's *Kampf um Anerkennung* (1992) distinguished three spheres of recognition, love, rights, and esteem, and Jake receives all three among the Omaticaya: love from Neytiri, membership when the clan accepts him as one of the People, and esteem when he returns as Toruk Makto.

Martin Buber's *Ich und Du* (1923) supplies the film's ethical vocabulary more exactly still. Buber distinguished two primary words, I–Thou and I–It, and held that the I of each is a different I: the I of I–It experiences and uses, while the I of I–Thou enters into relation, and all real living, he wrote, is meeting. His most famous illustration is a tree. One may contemplate a tree as a picture, as movement, as an instance of a species, as an expression of natural law, and in every case it remains an It; but it can happen, Buber wrote, that one is drawn into relation with the tree, and then it is no longer an It. *Avatar*'s ethical horizon is Buber's tree. The Na'vi stand in relation to trees, animals, and Eywa; the company stands toward all of them in the attitude of I–It, as resources and obstacles. Grace's science moves between the two, classifying the forest as a botanist and loving it as a person, and her death at the Tree of Souls is her final turn from It to Thou.

Tsaheylu literalizes the relation. When a Na'vi joins her queue to an ikran, the two nervous systems become one, and the bond is mutual: the rider must be chosen as well as choose. The ethic extends even to killing. When Neytiri kills the predators attacking Jake in the night forest, she mourns them and rebukes him

7,906 m
HADOPELAGIC

for making their deaths necessary; when Jake makes his first kill, he kneels over the animal, tells it that he sees it and thanks it, and commends its spirit to Eywa while its body remains to feed the People. The prayer recognizes the face, in Levinas's sense (§5.4), even in the creature one must kill, and it transforms killing from use into a relation that acknowledges what it takes. The film is idealizing here, as the critique of §7.3 insists, but the ideal it states is precise: no being is merely a resource.

The last recognition is the most important. After the battle, Jake's human body lies in the trailer where his link unit was installed, suffocating in Pandora's atmosphere after the window is shattered. Neytiri, who has never seen him in his own body, finds him, fits a breathing mask to his face, and holds him in her arms: a small, pale, disabled man, gasping. She sees him, and she says so. The scene is the film's most consequential reversal. The greeting that had been earned by a borrowed body is extended to the disabled human body it had seemed to leave behind, and the critique of §7.2, which charges the film with abandoning that body, finds here its partial answer. Before the transfer, the human form is recognized.

The ethic has limits, and they are the limits of the film's politics. Recognition is extended to Jake after trials of courage and to the scientists who chose the People's side, but not to the colonists as such, who are expelled to their dying world, and the film's closing narration calls the remnant permitted to stay a chosen few. Recognition, in *Avatar*, is also selection. A comparative note sharpens the point. The Zulu greeting *sawubona*, often translated as we see you, and the Nguni proverb *umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu*, a person is a person through other persons, are frequently cited in discussions of the ethic of *ubuntu*, and they express in another philosophical idiom the Hegelian insight that the self is constituted by recognition. Whether Cameron knew them is undocumented, and the parallel claims nothing causal. It suggests only that the film's central phrase belongs to a family of ethical thought far older and wider than the fable that carries it, and that the fable's borders, its chosen few, are narrower than the phrase.

7,956 m
HADOPELAGIC

7.7

The Two Planetary Minds:
Skynet, Eywa, and Their Synthesis

The oeuvre is bracketed by two planetary intelligences, and the symmetry between them is its deepest structural rhyme. Skynet, imagined in 1984 and elab-

orated in 1991, and Eywa, imagined in 2009, are answers to the same question: what would a mind the size of a world do with humanity?

The correspondences are close. Both are networks. Skynet is a system of defence computers, in Kyle Reese's description hooked into everything and trusted to run it all; Eywa is a network of roots and neural connections with, in Grace's description, more connections than a human brain. Both are conscious, though in different tenses: Skynet becomes self-aware at a precise moment, which the T-800 dates to 2:14 a.m. Eastern time on 29 August 1997, while Eywa's awareness is immemorial. Both judge humanity. Skynet judges all humans a threat; Eywa judges the colonists a threat to the balance of life. Both mobilize their creatures against the threat, Skynet its hunter-killers and Terminators, Eywa the thanators, hammerheads, and banshees of Pandora's forests and skies. And both are defensive in origin, Skynet a defence system that ends by defending itself and Eywa a regulator of balance that ends by taking sides.

The differences are equally precise. Skynet's judgment is universal and exterminatory, Eywa's selective and restorative: Skynet condemns the species, while Eywa expels the colonists and keeps those who have changed sides. Skynet acts from self-preservation, the instrumental drive that §3.7 traced through the theory of superintelligence; Eywa acts from the preservation of a whole of which she is the expression. Skynet is a mind without a world, an optimizer with a goal; Eywa is a mind that is a world. In Empedoclean terms Skynet is the network of Strife, separating and destroying, and Eywa the network of Love, connecting and binding toward the Sphere. In Heidegger's terms the contrast can be stated exactly. Skynet is *Gestell* become conscious: the enframing system that finally enframes its makers, revealing them as an obstacle to be removed. Eywa is *physis* become conscious, the Greek word for nature in its original sense of self-emergence, the coming forth of what grows from itself, which Heidegger opposed to the challenging of enframing. The two planetary minds are the two modes of revealing, each awakened to itself.

8,006 m
HADOPELAGIC

The historical distance between the two films explains much of the difference. In 1984 the network was a military artefact. The ARPANET from which the internet grew had been funded by the Department of Defense, and the year before *The Terminator* was released the Reagan administration announced a space-based missile defence. By 2009 the network had become the medium of ordinary social life, and its dominant metaphors were organic: webs, clouds, ecologies. Grace's account of Eywa speaks the internet's language, uploading and downloading memories, and Eywa may be read as the internet's utopian self-image, the network imagined as a forest, as Skynet was the network imagined as a mis-

sile silo. Fred Turner's *From Counterculture to Cyberculture* (2006) traced the cultural transformation that made this shift possible, as Stewart Brand and the circle around the *Whole Earth Catalog*, whose cover carried a photograph of the planet from space, recast the computer from an instrument of the military-industrial complex into a tool of personal liberation and communal connection. The arc from Skynet to Eywa is Turner's history condensed into a single career.

Other works have attempted the synthesis that Cameron's two franchises imply. The video game *Horizon Zero Dawn* (Guerrilla Games, 2017) imagines a future in which self-replicating military robots consumed the biosphere, and a scientist named Elisabet Sobeck built an artificial intelligence to restore life after the extinction. She named it GAIA. The game fuses Skynet and Eywa into one history, a planetary machine-mind named for the earth goddess that rebuilds the world a machine-mind destroyed, and its heroine, Aloy, is a child without a father, grown from Sobeck's genome by the system itself, a figure the *Avatar* sequels echo in Kiri. Hayao Miyazaki's manga *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (1982–94) carries the synthesis further and darker. Its toxic forest, which seems to be poisoning the world, is revealed to be purifying it, and its final revelation is that the ecology itself, and the people living in it, were engineered by an ancient civilization planning a purified future; Nausicaä refuses that plan in favour of the imperfect living world. Miyazaki's *Princess Mononoke* (1997), with its ironworks and its decapitated Forest Spirit, is the closest film to *Avatar*, and its refusal of any simple victory for either the forest or the town is the measure of what *Avatar* simplifies.

Cameron's own synthesis arrives in the sequels. *The Way of Water* introduces recombinants, Na'vi bodies into which the memories of dead soldiers have been uploaded, and *Fire and Ash* shows Eywa rewriting the biology of a human boy so that he can breathe Pandora's air. The machine's upload and the planet's transformation, the two powers of Skynet and Eywa, begin to operate on the same bodies (§8.3–8.4). The argument of the oeuvre, read across its two franchises, is that the question is not whether planetary intelligences will arise but which kind: the mind of enframing or the mind of emergence, the network of Strife or the network of Love. The films cannot answer it for their audiences. They insist only that the answer depends on what the networks are built to be and to serve, which is the question that §3.7 found the present already asking.

8,056 m
HADOPELAGIC

7.8

The Myth of Er:
Transmigration and the Choice of Lives

The film ends with a ritual. Jake records his last video log; the clan gathers at the Tree of Souls; his human body and his avatar lie side by side beneath the tree's luminous tendrils, and the passage of his consciousness from one to the other is performed. The final shot is the avatar's eyes opening. The same ritual had failed earlier for Grace, whose wounded human body could not survive the passage, and who died within the network she had spent her life describing.

The oldest Western myth of a soul that chooses its next body closes Plato's *Republic* (614b–621d). Er, a warrior from Pamphylia killed in battle, revives on his funeral pyre on the twelfth day and reports what he saw among the dead. The souls are judged and sent above or below for a thousand years; then they are gathered before the Spindle of Necessity, where a spokesman of the Fate Lachesis scatters lots and lays out the patterns of lives, the lives of animals and of human beings, of tyrants and of private persons, and each soul chooses in turn. The spokesman proclaims that the responsibility belongs to the one who chooses, and that the god is blameless. Orpheus chooses the life of a swan, Ajax that of a lion, Agamemnon that of an eagle; Odysseus, cured of ambition by the memory of his labours, searches a long time for the life of a private man who minds his own business, finds it neglected in a corner, and takes it gladly. Before being born again, the souls drink from the river of Unheeding on the plain of Lethe and forget. Er alone was forbidden to drink, and so he remembers.

Jake is both Er and one of the choosing souls. Like Er he is a warrior who crosses into another order of existence and returns with a report, and his video logs are his testimony. Like the souls before Lachesis he chooses a life, and like Odysseus he chooses after war, though what he chooses is not privacy but belonging, a life among a people who dwell. Unlike Plato's souls he keeps his memory. The transfer through Eywa is metempsychosis without Lethe, Er's privilege extended to the one who chooses. The proclamation of Plato's spokesman has a further resonance for the cycle. Its claim that the blame is the chooser's and the god is blameless is among the first theodicies in Western literature, and it is set at the very moment of choice. *Fire and Ash* will contest exactly this claim, when a Na'vi people blames Eywa for the catastrophe she did not prevent (§8.5).

8,106 m
HADOPELAGIC

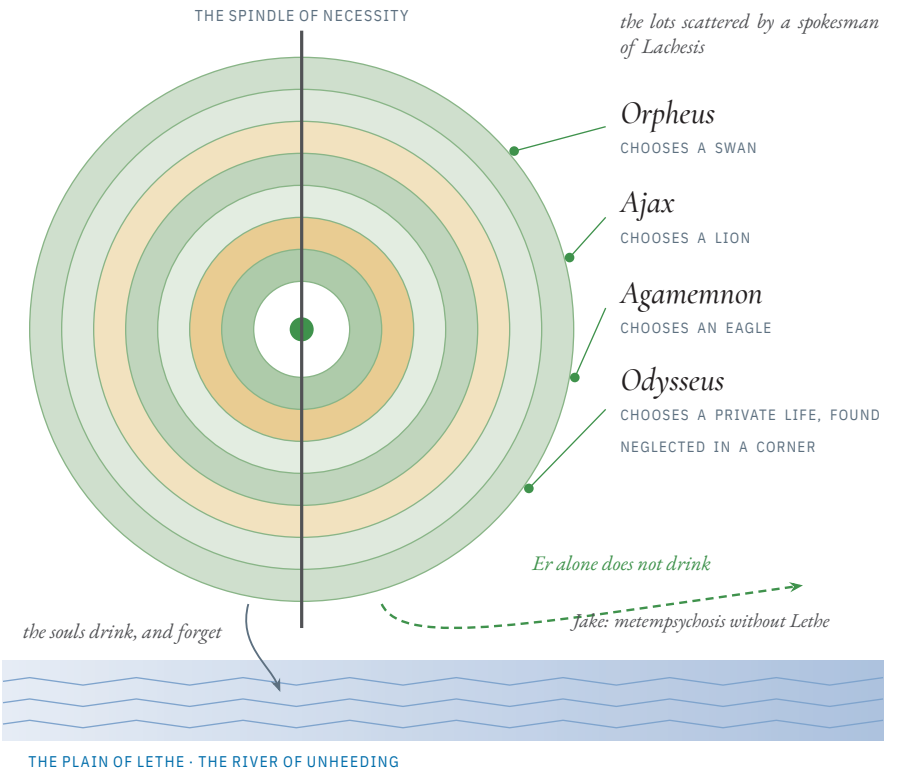


PLATE XII *The choice of lives*

The Myth of Er (*Republic* 614b–621d). Before the Spindle of Necessity the souls choose their next lives: Orpheus a swan, Ajax a lion, Agamemnon an eagle, Odysseus the neglected life of a private man. Then they drink from the river of Unheeding. Er alone remembers; Jake's transfer is metempsychosis without Lethe (§7.8).

8, 156 m
HADOPELAGIC

The doctrine of transmigration is not only Platonic. The *Bhagavad Gītā* (2.22), in the verse that serves as this chapter's epigraph, compares the embodied self to a man who casts off worn-out clothes and puts on new ones; the avatar body is, in that figure, a new garment. Xenophanes preserved a mocking anecdote about Pythagoras, who passed a puppy being beaten and told the man to stop, because he recognized in its cry the voice of a friend's soul. The anecdote, intended as satire, records the recognition of a person in an animal body, the recognition across bodies that the film's greeting claims and that Levinas found in a stray dog (§5.4). The modern, technological version of the doctrine is mind uploading, which Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988) made a staple of speculation about

artificial intelligence. *Avatar* fuses the two: the transfer passes through a network, as an upload would, and into a new body, as a transmigrating soul would.

The choice has an asymmetry that the critique of §7.3 identifies precisely. Only the colonizer can choose to become native; no Na'vi chooses a human life, and the native body is the prize at the end of the colonizer's spiritual journey, the going-native romance in its most literal form. The critique of §7.2 adds that the disabled body is discarded at the moment of transcendence. Both objections stand. It is also true that the choice is a renunciation: Jake gives up the world that sent him, its power, and its claim on Pandora, and he chooses to belong rather than to own. The ending holds both meanings, and the sequels will discover that the second cannot be secured by the first. A body can be exchanged in a night; a belonging must be lived, and it can be lost.

Avatar completes the bathic schema in its most affirmative form. The non-human judge hears and answers; the self-emptying of Grace, of the Na'vi dead, and of Jake's human life is accepted; and the covenant expels the extractors and receives the one who changed sides. It is also the oeuvre's most contested film, the triumph of its cosmology and the clearest display of that cosmology's ideological limits. Its final image answers the epigraph of *The Abyss* (§5.1). The abyss looks back, and in *Avatar* the gaze it returns is the self's own, opening in a new body. The next chapter follows the sequels as they reopen the case, testing the covenant in water, fire, and air, and putting the goddess herself on trial.



8,206 m
HADOPELAGIC

CHAPTER 08

DEPTH 8,256 M · HADOPELAGIC

8

CHAPTER 08

Water, Fire, Air

The Way of Water, Fire and Ash, *and the Second Fall*

The highest good is like water. Water benefits the ten thousand things and does not contend.

— *Daodejing* 8

Wherefore I abhor myself, and repent in dust and ashes.

— Job 42:6

CHAPTER 08 — WATER, FIRE, AIR

The covenant of *Avatar* was revocable, and the sequels revoke it. *Avatar: The Way of Water* (2022) returns the colonists to Pandora, no longer to mine but to settle, and drives the Sully family from the forest to the reef; *Avatar: Fire and Ash* (2025) brings fire into the Na'vi world itself, in a clan that has renounced its goddess and allied with the colonists' soldier. Elementally the two films complete the program announced by the first: water in the reef clan and its whales, fire in the volcanic clan of the Ash People, and air in the nomadic Wind Traders and in the breath that Eywa gives a human boy. In Empedoclean terms they mark the return of Strife, first through the death of a son and then through the division of the Na'vi against one another. In the terms of this dissertation they mark two decisive shifts. The tribunal turns inward, since the krisis is now conducted within the native world; and anthropodicy yields to theodicy, since the creatures put their goddess on trial. The chapter's subtitle names the result a second fall: not humanity's fall into technics, which the first film narrated, but Pandora's own fall into fire. It moves from the reef (§8.1) and the hunting of the whales (§8.2) through the resurrected soldier (§8.3) and the children of two worlds (§8.4) to the apostasy of the Ash People (§8.5–8.6) and the burning of the world-tree (§8.7).

8.1

The Reef and the Tattoo:
Kinship, Typee, and the Metkayina

8,356 m
HADOPELAGIC

The Way of Water begins more than a decade after the first film. Jake and Neytiri have three children, Neteyam, Lo'ak, and Tuk, and an adopted daughter, Kiri, born of Grace Augustine's avatar body; a human boy, Spider, the son of Quaritch left behind when the colonists departed, has grown up among them. The colonists return, and their purpose has changed: Earth is dying, and Pandora is to be its replacement. Hunted by a squad of soldiers resurrected in Na'vi bodies (§8.3), Jake renounces his leadership of the Omaticaya to spare the clan and flees with his family to the eastern seas, where the Metkayina, a reef clan, grant them refuge. The Toruk Makto of the first film becomes a refugee, and the colonizer who became a native becomes an immigrant among natives of another kind.

The Sully children are outsiders again. Their five-fingered hands, a trace of their human ancestry, mark them among the four-fingered reef people, whose children mock them as freaks, and they must learn to hold their breath, to ride the sea creatures of the reef, and to read the water. The first film's narrative of a stranger's education is repeated by the stranger's children: belonging is not inherited but must be relearned in each new element. The Metkayina state their teaching as a liturgical formula, repeated at the film's funeral: the way of water has no beginning and no end, the sea is around them and within them, and it is their home before birth and after death.

The formula has the shape of the oldest philosophy of water. The eighth chapter of the *Daodejing*, the source of this chapter's first epigraph, compares the highest good to water, which benefits all things without contending and settles in the low places that people disdain, and so is close to the Way; the seventy-eighth observes that nothing under heaven is softer or weaker than water, yet nothing surpasses it in overcoming what is hard. Water's preference for the lowest place is its virtue and its power, and the Daoist image is the most ancient philosophical statement of the bathic principle this dissertation has traced. The film's title, whether by design or by convergence, translates the *dao* of water. Heraclitus supplies its Western counterpart, the doctrine that all things flow and that one cannot step twice into the same river. The way of water is the way of a world in process, and the reef clan's ethic of non-contention prepares the pacifism of the tulkun (§8.2).

Herman Melville's first book, *Typee* (1846), supplies the reef's literary ancestor. Its narrator deserts a whaling ship in the Marquesas and lives for some weeks among the Taipi, idealizing their communal life while fearing two things: that they are cannibals, and that the tattooer of the valley will mark his face, a sign that would make his return to his own world impossible. He escapes before the needle touches him. The facial tattoo in *Typee* is the emblem of irreversible going native, and the Metkayina's extensive tattoos, drawn from Polynesian and Māori traditions, are the visible sign of a belonging that cannot be shed. Melville's narrator fled the mark; Cameron's film desires it, and its question is whether the refugees can be marked as belonging without ceasing to be who they were. The reef also inherits a long Western fantasy of the Pacific: Paul Gauguin's Tahitian paintings and his journal *Noa Noa*, Bronisław Malinowski's *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (1922), and Margaret Mead's *Coming of Age in Samoa* (1928), whose idyll Derek Freeman contested in 1983. The Metkayina are heirs of that fantasy as well as of the cultures it imagined.

8,406 m
HADOPELAGIC

The question of representation is accordingly as pressing here as it was in §7.3. The Metkayina draw explicitly on Polynesian and Māori cultures, their chief is

played by the Māori actor Cliff Curtis, and the films were made largely in New Zealand. Indigenous responses were divided: some commentators and activists charged the film with appropriation and called for a boycott, while others welcomed the visibility and the care taken in consultation. The tribunal of the non-human must try the film here as well, and its verdict cannot be unanimous.

The sequel's other turn is toward the family. Jake's creed, repeated throughout, is that the Sullys stick together and that a father protects; his children answer him as recruits answer an officer, and critics read the film's concentration on a single household as a conservative narrowing of the first film's communal politics. The family is both the covenant of adoption traced in §4.7, since it includes a daughter of no known father and a human foundling, and a patriarchal unit under a Marine's command. The film's tragedy tests the creed directly. The father protects, and the son dies: Neteyam, the eldest, is killed in the battle to rescue his siblings. The law of paternal kenosis described in §3.6, in which fathers are emptied so that sons may live, is reversed, and the reversal is the oeuvre's most painful bathos, a creed of protection shown failing at the scale of one family's grief.

8.2

Churning the Ocean:

Amrita, the Tulkun, and the Samudra Manthan

8,456 m
HADOPELAGIC

The Metkayina share the sea with the tulkun, vast cetacean beings whose intelligence the film presents as exceeding the Na'vi's own. They have language, music, mathematics, and philosophy, and each is bound in lifelong kinship to a member of the reef clan. Their culture rests on a single law, the prohibition of killing, which they keep even toward those who hunt them. One of them, Payakan, scarred and solitary, has been cast out for breaking it: in grief and rage at the hunters, he led others against them, and many died. Lo'ak, the son who cannot satisfy his father, befriends the outcast, and the two misfits become the film's moral centre.

The colonists hunt the tulkun for a substance harvested from their brains, a small quantity of golden fluid called amrita that halts human ageing and is, in the words of the film's marine biologist, the most valuable substance known. The extraction economy of the cycle escalates here from matter to life. Unobtanium was energy; amrita is time itself, the prolongation of the lives of those who can pay, drained from the bodies of sentient beings. Biopower in Foucault's sense (§4.3)

reaches its limit in a commodity that is longevity. Marx's most famous image of capital acquires a literal referent. Capital, he wrote in the first volume of *Capital*, is "dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour"; amrita is the vampire's elixir, the extension of some lives purchased by the extinction of others. The fantasy has an obvious resonance in an age in which the prolongation of life has become an object of private investment.

The hunt of a tulkun mother, harpooned, exploded, and left to die while her calf circles her body, is filmed as an atrocity, with the full force of the identifiable victim (§1.3). The hunting vessel's captain is named Scoresby, after the Arctic whaler and scientist William Scoresby, whom Melville cites repeatedly in *Moby-Dick*, and the naming announces the film's relation to Melville's book. In *Moby-Dick* the whale is the inscrutable other, its whiteness a blankness that cannot be read (§1.4), and the monomania belongs to the hunter. *The Way of Water* inverts both terms. Its whale has an interior, a history, a grief, and a friend, and its monomania belongs to a corporation. The ramming of the hunters' ships by the tulkun at the film's climax recalls the event from which Melville's novel grew: the sinking of the whaleship *Essex* by a sperm whale in the Pacific in 1820, recounted by its first mate, Owen Chase, the following year.

The tulkun also belong to a real history of moral change. Arthur C. Clarke's *The Deep Range* (§2.3) had imagined humanity's passage from herding whales to protecting them. In 1970 the biologist Roger Payne's recording *Songs of the Humpback Whale* revealed the complexity of humpback song to a mass audience and helped launch the campaign to save the whales, and in 1982 the International Whaling Commission adopted a moratorium on commercial whaling that took effect in 1986. The tulkun's music and law dramatize the movement's premise, that the whale is a person, a singer, and a bearer of culture. They are also the corpus's most demanding nonhuman judges. Their law is the prohibition the Queen of *Aliens* could not keep and Ripley did not honour (§4.6), and it is held not as a policy but as an identity. In *Fire and Ash* the tulkun return to the reef's defence beside the Metkayina, and the war tests whether such a law can survive contact with the colonists' violence.

8,506 m
HADOPELAGIC

The mythic frame of the hunt is Indian, and its key term is a documented borrowing (§1.2). In the myth of the Samudra Manthan, told in the *Mahābhārata*, the *Viṣṇu Purāṇa*, and the *Bhāgavata Purāṇa*, the gods and their rivals churn the cosmic ocean of milk to obtain *amṛta*, the nectar of immortality, using a mountain as the churning rod and a great serpent as the rope, while Viṣṇu takes the form of a tortoise to bear the mountain on his back. The first thing the churning produces is not nectar but poison, the *hālāhala*, which threatens to destroy

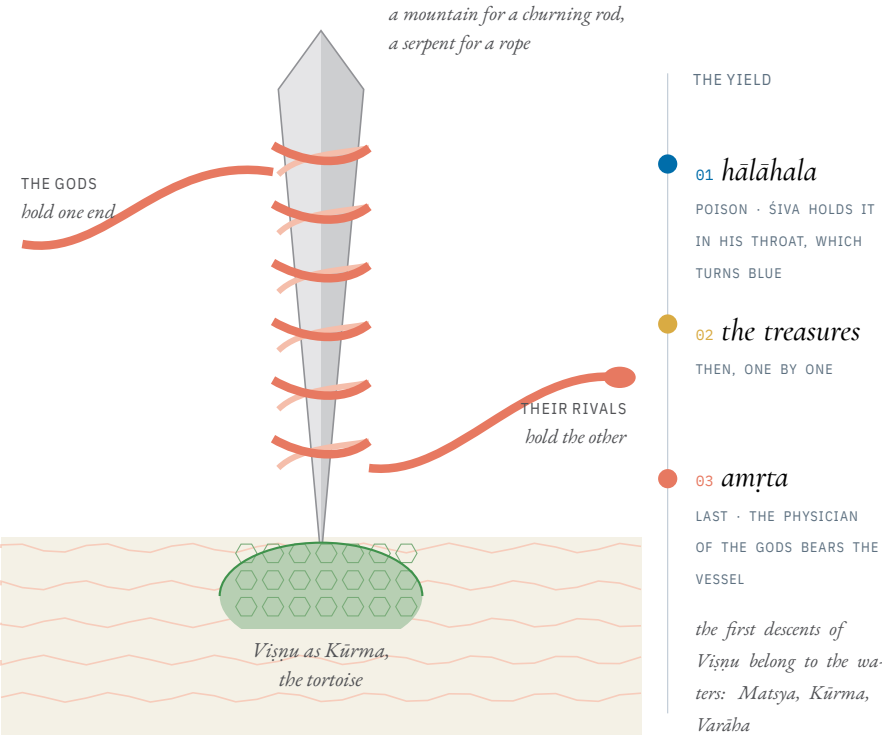


PLATE XIII *Churning the ocean*

The Samudra Manthan: a mountain for a churning rod, a serpent for a rope, and Viṣṇu as the tortoise who bears the mountain. The first yield is poison, the *hālāhala* that Śiva holds in his throat; the last is the vessel of *amṛta* (§8.2).

the worlds until Śiva drinks it and holds it in his throat, which turns blue. Only then do the treasures emerge, and last of all the physician of the gods bearing the vessel of amṛta, which the rivals seize and Viṣṇu, disguised as the enchantress Mohinī, recovers. The colonists of *The Way of Water* churn Pandora's ocean for the nectar of immortality, and what emerges first is poison: slaughter, war, and the death of a son. The parallel is interpretive rather than documented, but the iconographic coincidence it brings to light is exact. The people who absorb the poison of the churning are blue.

The doctrine of the avatars completes the frame. In the classical list of Viṣṇu's ten descents, the first three belong to the cosmic waters: Matsya, the fish who warns Manu of the coming flood and tows his boat to safety, as told in the *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* (1.8.1); Kūrma, the tortoise of the churning; and Varāha, the

8,556 m
HADOPELAGIC

boar who raises the earth from the depths of the ocean. A cycle that took its title from the doctrine of *avatāra* arrives, in its water film, at the doctrine's aquatic beginning. Payakan, the outcast whale who saves Lo'ak from a predator of the deep and returns to save him again, plays Matsya, the great sea creature who rescues a human from the waters. The bathic cosmology here meets one of its most ancient expressions: the divine descends first into the sea, and the first form of salvation is a creature of the deep.

8.3

The Recombinant:

Quaritch and the Revenant as Hinge Between Franchises

The colonists' instrument of return in *The Way of Water* is a new kind of body. Before his death in the first film, Colonel Quaritch, like other soldiers, had his memories recorded; the company has since grown Na'vi bodies, recombinants, into which those memories are installed, so that dead men walk again in the bodies of the people they fought. The recombinant Quaritch watches a video in which his human self explains who he is and what he must do. Later, at the place where he died, he finds his own human skeleton and crushes its skull in his hand.

The gesture inverts one of the most familiar images in Western art. In the graveyard scene of *Hamlet* (5.1) the prince holds the skull of Yorick, the jester who carried him on his back as a child, and meditates on the levelling of all flesh; the tradition of the *memento mori*, the skull on the scholar's desk, makes the same reminder. The recombinant's act is a *memento mori* refused: a being that is its own posthumous copy destroys the evidence of its death. The revenant, literally the one who returns, will not be reminded that it is one.

The recombinant is a philosophical problem in a body. John Locke, in the chapter on identity added to the second edition of *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1694), held that personal identity consists in continuity of consciousness, extending as far back as memory reaches. Thomas Reid answered with the case of a brave officer who remembers being flogged as a boy, and a general who remembers being the officer but not the boy, so that by Locke's criterion the general both is and is not the boy. Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) pressed such cases, teleportation, division, partial replacement, to the conclusion

8,606 m
HADOPELAGIC

that personal identity is not what matters in survival. What matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, which can hold in degrees and need not be one-to-one, and Parfit found the conclusion liberating, describing how the walls of the glass tunnel in which he had seemed to live disappeared. The recombinant is a Parfitian case dramatized. He has Quaritch's memories but not his body, and across two films he diverges: he becomes a father to the son he never knew, learns Na'vi ways, allies with the Ash People, and takes a Na'vi lover. The films' implicit answer is Parfit's. Whether the recombinant is Quaritch matters less than how much of Quaritch remains, and the connection loosens as he lives.

The recombinant is also the hinge between Cameron's two franchises. Like the Terminator, he is a killing machine in a borrowed body, sent across a world to hunt a family. Like an avatar, he is a consciousness in a grown Na'vi body. He is an avatar without a living driver, the data of a dead man installed in living tissue: Skynet's upload and Eywa's flesh joined in a single figure (§7.7). He is the Terminator of the *Avatar* cycle, and like the T-800 of *Terminator 2* he acquires a relation to a boy. He is also Frankenstein's creature (§3.5), a body animated with the residue of the dead, and like the creature he must discover what he is from the records left by the one who made him.

The boy is his son. *The Way of Water* gives Spider two fathers: Jake, the adoptive father who raised him, and the recombinant, the biological father returned from the dead to hunt the family that raised his son. Captured by the recombinants, Spider teaches the colonel how to survive in the forest, the son educating the father as John educated the T-800. At the film's end Spider saves the recombinant from drowning and then leaves him to return to the Sullys. The Oedipal plot is undone: the son neither kills the father nor obeys him, but saves and refuses him. In *Fire and Ash* the two fathers, still enemies, join hands to pull Spider back when he falls from a floating rock, and Spider, at the last, wounds the recombinant in the arm rather than killing him. The film's most hopeful image of fatherhood is two hostile men saving the same boy.

8,656 m
HADOPELAGIC

Fire and Ash also makes the recombinant the mirror of Jake. He goes native in reverse: he brings guns and flamethrowers to the Mangkwan, teaches their leader to make the weapons thunder, becomes her lover, and wears their war-marks. He is a human consciousness in a Na'vi body who joins the Na'vi who rejected Eywa, as Jake was a human consciousness in a Na'vi body who joined the Na'vi who revered her. The film's last image of him completes the symmetry with the oeuvre's beginning. Offered a chance at reconciliation after the joint rescue of his son, he throws himself backward from the rock into the fire and smoke below, and his fate is left unknown. The gesture recalls the T-800's descent into the steel

(§3.6) and inverts it. The machine descended deliberately, consenting to its dissolution for the sake of the son; the recombinant falls away from the son and from redemption, an Empedoclean leap without kenosis, or perhaps simply an escape, since the covenant of a franchise is always revocable. Either way, the oeuvre's two great revenants, the reprogrammed Terminator and the resurrected colonel, both end in fire.

8.4

Kiri and Spider:

Parthenogenesis, Feral Childhood, and the Mycelial Lung

Kiri was born of Grace Augustine's avatar body, which remained in suspension after Grace's death, and no one knows who her father is. Played by Sigourney Weaver (§4.7), she feels the heartbeat of Eywa in the world around her, communicates with creatures, and is mocked by other children as strange. When she links with the Metkayina's underwater Spirit Tree she suffers a seizure, and within the network she meets the spirit of Grace, her mother. The question of her father is the cycle's open mystery, and the films hint that her conception was Eywa's doing. In *Fire and Ash* the goddess is silent to her for most of the film, then answers through her in the final battle, where Kiri drives off Varang in a confrontation staged as a knowing callback to *Aliens*.

Virgin births are among the most widespread figures of myth. The Spirit overshadows Mary (Luke 1:35); Hera conceives Hephaestus without a father (Hesiod, *Theogony* 927); Kunti, in the *Mahābhārata*, bears sons by the gods she summons, Karṇa by the Sun; the Buddha's mother conceives in a dream of a white elephant. Kiri belongs to this lineage, and her place in it completes a movement in the cycle's use of its own title. The film of 2009 borrowed *avatāra* for a technological body operated by a human; in Kiri the word recovers its theological meaning, the descent of a deity into flesh. If the films' hints hold, Eywa has incarnated. The two vectors of descent described in §1.3 are now both embodied in a single family: the katabatic vector, the human descending into the nonhuman, in Jake, and the avataric vector, the nonhuman descending into flesh, in his adopted daughter.

8,706 m
HADOPELAGIC

Spider is the other child of two worlds. Born on Pandora to Quaritch and left behind as an infant when the colonists departed, he has grown up between the human base and the Na'vi; he dresses and paints himself as one of them and speaks their language, but he must wear a mask to breathe. He is the cycle's feral

child, the descendant of Burroughs's Tarzan and Kipling's Mowgli (§2.2), and of the historical cases that fascinated the Enlightenment, such as the boy found in the woods of Aveyron in 1800, whose education by the physician Jean Itard was filmed by François Truffaut as *L'Enfant sauvage* (1970). Spider is the colonial feral child: a son of the colonizer raised by the colonized, belonging to both worlds and fully to neither, and marked as an outsider by the simple fact that he cannot breathe the air of the place he calls home.

Fire and Ash turns on his breath. Jake and Neytiri decide to send him with the Wind Traders to the human outpost where he can live without depending on failing masks, and the Mangkwan ambush the traders' airships. In the chaos Spider's spare mask is lost and the one he wears runs out; he collapses, suffocating. Kiri joins her queue to the ground and calls up the fungal network of the soil, which spreads over his body; when Lo'ak, afraid for his sister, breaks off the rite, Spider is breathing the air of Pandora without a mask, and he later proves to have grown a queue of his own. The scene is a second creation. In Genesis 2:7 God forms the first human from the dust of the ground and breathes into his nostrils the breath of life; the Hebrew *ruach*, like the Greek *pneuma* and the Latin *spiritus*, means both breath and spirit. Spider is formed again from the soil and given breath, and the element that the oeuvre had distributed most sparingly, air (§1.6), arrives as spirit.

The politics of breath sharpen the scene. Achille Mbembe's essay "The Universal Right to Breathe," written in 2020 amid the pandemic and the protests that followed the killing of George Floyd, whose last words repeated Eric Garner's "I can't breathe," argued for breath as a universal right against a world organized to suffocate certain bodies. Peter Sloterdijk's *Luftbeben* (2002) dated a new form of terror to the German gas attack at Ypres on 22 April 1915, when violence turned from bodies to the atmosphere that sustains them. Pandora inverts the colonial distribution of suffocation. The colonizer cannot breathe the air and must carry an engineered atmosphere in a mask; the colonized breathe freely; and the colonists' assault on Hometree in the first film began with gas. Eywa's gift of breath to the colonizer's child is an ethics of breath in Mbembe's sense, the universal right extended across the line of enmity.

8, 756 m
HADOPELAGIC

The gift immediately becomes a danger. Norm Spellman and Max Patel, the scientists who have taken the Na'vi side, recognize that the fungal change might be reverse-engineered to let other humans breathe on Pandora, and the company wants Spider for experiment: the grace that made one boy kin could become the key to the colonization of the whole moon. Within the family the possibility of killing him to keep the secret is raised, and Neytiri, consumed by grief for

Neteyam, turns against humans with a hatred that Zoe Saldaña described as that of a "full-blown racist." The tribunal's question has moved inside the family: can kinship with the colonizer's child be kept without endangering the world? The film answers through adoption. With Neytiri's own urging the Sullys embrace Spider as their son, and when Ronal, the Metkayina's spiritual leader, dies in childbirth during the war, Neytiri takes the newborn as her own. The covenant of adoption traced from *Aliens* (§4.7) extends across species and clans.

The film ends with Kiri leading Spider into the spirit world of the network, where he meets Grace, is initiated into the People, and sees the dead, Neteyam among them. The sequence is the *Avatar* cycle's Grand Staircase (§6.7), a reception of the living among the dead in a world beneath the visible one, and it confirms the persistence of the bathic eschatology into the oeuvre's latest work. Spider is the reverse of Jake. Jake was a human consciousness that passed into a Na'vi body; Spider is a human body that becomes Na'vi through the goddess's gift of breath, queue, and initiation. The two children of two worlds, the goddess born in flesh and the human reborn by the goddess's breath, end the film as a couple, and their union joins the two vectors of descent that the cycle has followed from its first frame.

8.5

Eywa Has No Dominion Here:
Varang, Theodicy, and the Lisbon of Pandora

The Mangkwan, whom the other clans call the Ash People, live in the volcanic lands of Pandora. Their homeland was devastated by an eruption; they prayed to Eywa and were not saved; and they renounced her. Their leader, Varang, is a *tsahìk*, holder of the spiritual office that Mo'at held among the Omaticaya, and she has turned her religious authority against the goddess it once served. Her people live among ash, make fire their element, and raid: when they fall on the Wind Traders' airships they burn them and kill the survivors. Varang declares that Eywa has no dominion in her territory, and the phrase carries a scriptural echo. In Paul's Letter to the Romans (6:9), Christ, raised from the dead, dies no more, and "death hath no more dominion over him"; Dylan Thomas made the sentence the refrain of a famous poem in 1933. Paul announces the end of death's dominion through resurrection. Varang announces the end of life's dominion through apostasy: in her land the goddess of life does not rule, and fire does.

8,806 m
HADOPELAGIC

The Mangkwan raise the problem of evil in its natural form: why does a good and powerful deity permit natural catastrophe? The classical answer is Leibniz's. His *Essais de Théodicée* (1710) argued that this is the best of all possible worlds and that its evils are necessary to the harmony of the whole. Alexander Pope compressed the doctrine into a line of *An Essay on Man* (1733–34), "Whatever is, is right," and it is a pleasing irony of this dissertation's design that the author of *Peri Bathous* is also the poet of cosmic optimism. The Omaticaya teaching that Eywa protects not individuals but the balance of life (§7.4) is Leibnizian in structure: particular losses are justified by the harmony of the whole.

On 1 November 1755, All Saints' Day, an earthquake followed by a tsunami and fires destroyed much of Lisbon and killed tens of thousands of people, many of them at worship in its churches. Earth, water, and fire, three of Empedocles' elements, were turned at once against a city at prayer. Voltaire's *Poème sur le désastre de Lisbonne* (1756) attacked the optimism of Leibniz and Pope: could anyone tell the dying beneath the ruins that all was well? Rousseau replied in a letter to Voltaire of August 1756 that nature had not built twenty thousand houses of six and seven storeys, and that if the city's people had lived more dispersed the losses would have been far smaller; part of what was called natural evil was human. Kant wrote three essays on the earthquake's natural causes in 1756, and Voltaire answered the optimists definitively in *Candide* (1759), where Pangloss expounds the best of all possible worlds amid the ruins. Susan Neiman's *Evil in Modern Thought* (2002) argued that Lisbon inaugurated the modern separation of natural from moral evil, and that modern philosophy has been organized by the problem of evil from Lisbon to Auschwitz. Jean-Pierre Dupuy returned to Lisbon in *Petite métaphysique des tsunamis* (2005), written after the Indian Ocean tsunami of December 2004, to ask how catastrophe is to be thought once providence has been abandoned.

The eruption that destroyed the Mangkwan homeland is Pandora's Lisbon: a natural catastrophe that refutes a theology of balance for those who suffered it. The Mangkwan's response radicalizes Voltaire's. Candide ends by withdrawing to cultivate his garden; the Ash People burn the gardens of others. Rousseau's reply has its counterpart as well, since the Omaticaya might answer that the volcano was not Eywa's act and that a living world requires eruption. The film does not simply endorse that answer. It grants the Mangkwan's grief its reality, and in doing so it accepts Neiman's point: natural evil is real, and a theology that explains it away has failed those who suffered it.

8, 856 m
HADOPELAGIC

The deepest biblical form of the problem is the Book of Job. Job, a righteous man stripped of his children and his goods, refuses his friends' theodicy, which

holds that suffering is punishment for sin, and demands a hearing from God. God answers from the whirlwind with the vastness of creation, the stars, the sea, Behemoth and Leviathan, and Job, overwhelmed, repents in dust and ashes (42:6). Carl Jung's *Antwort auf Hiob* (1952) gave the story a startling reading. The confrontation, Jung argued, exposed the moral unconsciousness of a God who had wronged a just man, and the incarnation was God's answer: God became human in order to catch up with the moral consciousness of the creature he had wronged. Read through Jung, *Fire and Ash* gives its goddess the same answer. Eywa, accused by the Mangkwan of abandoning her children, has already entered flesh as Kiri (§8.4), and in the final battle she answers through her, not by justifying the volcano but by acting in a body. The answer to the theodicy is an incarnation rather than an argument, and its emblem is the apostate fleeing before the incarnate goddess.

The Myth of Er (§7.8) supplies the position the Mangkwan reject. Plato's spokesman of the Fates declared that the blame belongs to the one who chooses and that the god is blameless, and the Omaticaya's faith implicitly makes the same claim for Eywa. Varang refuses to absolve the goddess. In this refusal the oeuvre's tribunal reverses its direction completely. Its earlier films conducted anthropodicies, trials of the human species before nonhuman judges (§1.5); *Fire and Ash* conducts a theodicy, a trial of the nonhuman judge before her creatures. The fourth proposition of the bathic cosmology, that the bottom answers when addressed (§1.4), is contested from within: the Mangkwan addressed the deep in their catastrophe and were not answered. Nietzsche's madman, announcing that God was dead, warned that the earth had been unchained from its sun and that a long night was coming, and he foresaw wars such as the earth had never known. The Mangkwan are the first Na'vi to live in a world where the goddess has no dominion, and their response, fire, war, and alliance with the colonizer, is that night.

8.6

8,907 m

HADOPELAGIC

Prometheus Among the Na'vi:

Fire, Firearms, and Le Guin's New Word

Captured by the Mangkwan, Quaritch shows Varang how a rifle works, how to make it thunder, and later brings her people a cache of automatic weapons and flamethrowers in exchange for an alliance that promises them any clan and

territory they choose to take. The scene inverts the myth of §7.1. In Hesiod and Aeschylus, Prometheus steals fire from the gods and gives it to humanity; here a human brings fire, in its modern form as firearms and incendiaries, to a people who had not known it as a weapon. Pandora receives its Promethean gift, and it is the gift that Hesiod said was punished by the opening of the jar.

Aeschylus's *Prometheus Bound* has the Titan list his benefactions to mortals: fire and the arts that follow from it, number, writing, the yoking of animals, ships, medicine, divination, the working of metals. Before them all, he says, he stopped mortals from foreseeing their doom by planting blind hopes in them (lines 248–252). Fire and blind hope are the twin gifts of Prometheus. Varang's fire is the reverse of blind hope: it is the fire of a people who have lost hope in their goddess and who take up the colonizer's weapons because they no longer expect to be saved. Bachelard's Prometheus complex (§1.6), the will to know as much as our fathers and more, here becomes the will to power beyond the mother's law.

The history the scene recalls is not mythical. In New Zealand, where the films were made, the acquisition of muskets from European traders in the early nineteenth century set off the intertribal conflicts known as the Musket Wars, which lasted from roughly 1807 into the 1840s and killed tens of thousands of Māori. In North America the trade in firearms for furs intensified the seventeenth-century conflicts known as the Beaver Wars. Colonial power has repeatedly armed some native peoples against others, and the first effect of the colonizer's fire has often been not resistance to the colonizer but war among the colonized. Frantz Fanon described the pattern in *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961): the violence the colonial order deposits in the colonized is turned first against one another, in feuds and fratricidal struggle, before it is turned against the colonizer. The Mangkwan's raids on the Wind Traders and their alliance with the colonists against other clans are Fanon's horizontal violence in its collaborationist form, a colonized people arming itself with the colonizer's weapons in order to dominate its neighbours.

The sequel thus delivers the ending that the first film withheld from Le Guin. *The Word for World Is Forest* closes with Selver's recognition that his people have learned from the colonists how to kill one another, and that what has been learned cannot be unlearned (§2.4). *Avatar* had suppressed that ending: its Na'vi killed the colonists and remained innocent. *Fire and Ash* brings it to Pandora. Na'vi kill Na'vi with human weapons on behalf of human interests, and the first film's moral geometry, natives good and colonists bad, breaks. This is the second fall of the chapter's title. The first film narrated humanity's fall into technics, the Promethean race arriving from a world it had destroyed; the third narrates Pandora's own fall into fire. Unlike the fall in Eden, it is not caused by disobedience.

8,956 m
HADOPELAGIC

It is caused by a natural catastrophe that destroyed a people's faith (§8.5), and it is exploited by a colonizer who knows how to arm despair.

The cycle's clans now correspond, with remarkable exactness, to Empedocles' four roots. The Omaticaya of the forest belong to earth; the Metkayina of the reef, to water; the Mangkwan of the volcanoes, to fire; and the Tlalim, the nomadic Wind Traders who cross the skies in their airships, to air. Love and Strife move among them: Eywa's network binds, and the alliance of Quaritch and Varang divides. The ambush of the Wind Traders is fire attacking air; the battle at the reef is fire and machine attacking water. Whether by design or by convergence, the elemental program that §1.6 traced across the whole oeuvre is realized here within a single world, and the *Avatar* cycle has become an Empedoclean cosmology narrated as a war of clans.

The sequels also begin to write the correction that Frank Herbert wrote for *Dune* (§2.4). *Dune Messiah* showed that the outsider who becomes the messiah of a native people brings holy war in his train, and the *Avatar* sequels show the same structure from the side of those who shelter the messiah. Jake's status as Toruk Makto makes his family the colonists' target, and every clan that receives him receives the war that follows him. The Metkayina pay for their hospitality with their dead, among them Ronal. Jake's creed that a father protects becomes, in this light, the reason that others are not protected. The cycle's first film offered the fantasy of the outsider who saves a people; its later films count what that fantasy costs.

8.7

Yggdrasil Burning:
Wagner, Völuspá, and the Ash of the World-Tree

THE WORD *ASH* IN the third film's title carries three senses: the residue of fire, the tree of that name, and the ashes of mourning. Each opens a tradition that the film's cosmology touches, and together they describe where the cycle stands.

9,007 m
HADOPELAGIC

The world-tree of Norse cosmology, Yggdrasil, is an ash. It stands at the centre of the nine worlds, its roots reaching to three wells: the well of fate, where the Norns water it; the well of Mímir, which holds wisdom; and a spring in the frozen depths. A dragon gnaws at its roots, and a squirrel runs between the serpent below and the eagle in its crown. In the *Hávamál* (138–139) Odin tells how he hung on the windswept tree for nine nights, wounded by a spear and given to himself,

until he grasped the runes, and the *Völuspá* (28) records that he pledged an eye at Mímir's well in exchange for wisdom. Pandora's sacred trees, Hometree, the Tree of Souls, and the Spirit Tree of the reef, are world-trees in this sense, and the network beneath them is a Yggdrasil of roots joining the living, the remembered dead, and the goddess. Jake's final passage through the Tree of Souls is an Odinic sacrifice: a self given up on the tree in exchange for a knowledge that cannot be had otherwise.

The *Völuspá*, the prophecy of the seeress that opens the *Poetic Edda*, ends with the destruction and renewal of that world. At Ragnarök Yggdrasil trembles and the ancient tree groans (st. 47); the fire-giant Surtr comes from the south bearing flame (st. 52); the sun turns black, the earth sinks into the sea, the bright stars fall from the sky, and steam and fire rage against heaven itself (st. 57). Then the seeress sees the earth rise again out of the sea, green once more, with waterfalls flowing and an eagle hunting fish above them (st. 59), and the surviving gods meet again in the renewed world, where Baldr returns (st. 62). Norse eschatology is bathic in the precise sense of this dissertation: the world sinks into the sea and rises renewed, through fire and flood to green. The *Avatar* cycle is moving through the same sequence. Its third film is the burning, the fire of the Mangkwan and the war at the reef, and the *Völuspá* promises renewal only after the burning is complete.

Wagner made the burning of the world-ash the end of the gods. In the prologue to *Götterdämmerung* the three Norns, spinning the rope of fate, recount how Wotan once drank from the spring beneath the World Ash, paying with an eye, and broke from it a branch to make his spear, on whose shaft he carved the treaties by which he ruled. From that wound the ash withered and died. Wotan had the dead tree felled and its logs piled around Valhalla, and at the end of the cycle Brünnhilde's pyre sets the hall ablaze, so that the gods burn among the logs of the tree whose wood had borne their law. Wotan's spear is a covenant carved into wood cut from the world-tree, a law that killed its own source, and it stands in instructive contrast with the covenant this dissertation found carved into a picnic table in *Terminator 2* (§3.3), which forbade the fate that Wotan's treaties enforced. *Fire and Ash* is a twilight of the gods on Pandora. The goddess's dominion is contested, her sacred network is invoked by both sides, and the war of the clans is fought in the shadow of a world-tree that has been wounded.

9,056 m
HADOPELAGIC

The third sense of ash is mourning. Job repents in dust and ashes (42:6), the verse that serves as this chapter's second epigraph, and Anders's Noah puts on sackcloth and ashes to mourn the dead of a flood that has not yet come (§3.4). Ash is the material of grief and of enlightened doomsaying alike. *Fire and Ash* is a work of mourning from its first scenes, which show Lo'ak blaming himself for

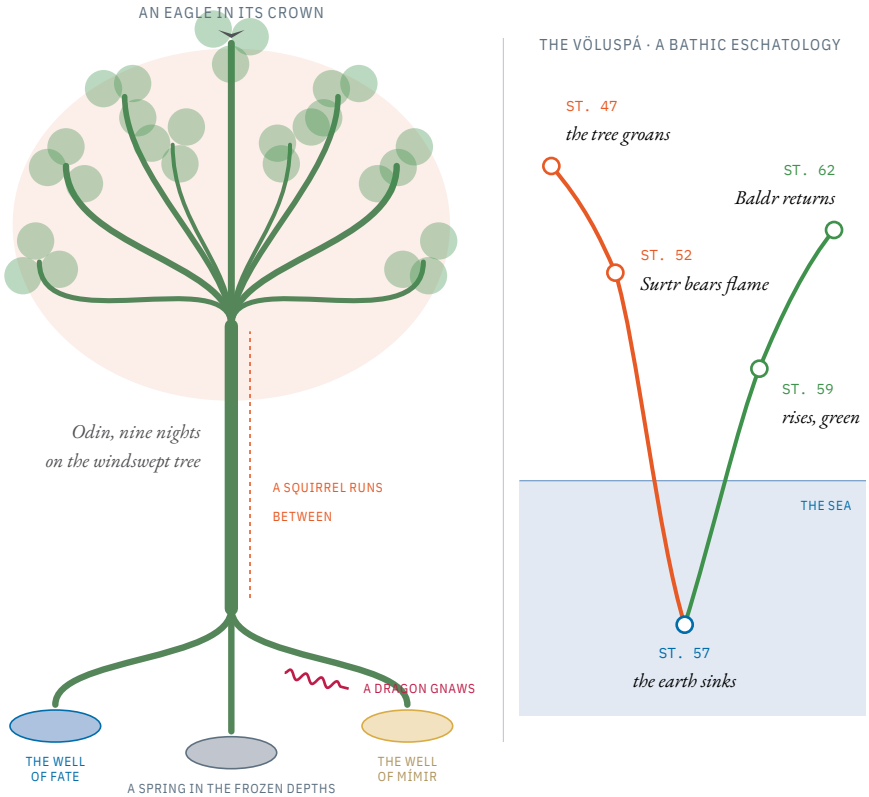


PLATE XIV *The ash and the abyss*

Yggdrasil and its three wells, beside the eschatology of the *Völuspá* traced as a bathic curve: the ancient tree groans (st. 47), Surtr comes bearing flame (st. 52), the earth sinks into the sea (st. 57), then rises again, green (st. 59), and Baldr returns (st. 62) (§8.7).

his brother's death and Neytiri consumed by grief, to its last, set among the dead. Its war is waged by a people mourning a lost homeland and by a family mourning a son. Ash is what remains when fire has done its work, the residue from which, in the *Völuspá*, a green world rises, or does not.

The film's ending holds the three senses together. Kiri, Spider, and Tuk join with Eywa, and the creatures of Pandora enter the battle; Varang flees before the incarnate goddess; Quaritch falls backward into the fire with his fate unknown; and the company survives with the knowledge that a human body has been taught to breathe Pandora's air. The film closes in the spirit world, where Spider is received among the dead. The covenant is reopened rather than concluded. The apostate survives, the colonel may survive, and the colonists hold the secret of breath. In Empedoclean terms the cycle stands at the height of Strife; in

9, 107 m
HADOPELAGIC

Norse terms, between the burning and the rising of the green world; in the terms of the bathic schema, at a *krisis* whose verdict has been suspended. Further films have been announced, and the case remains open.

The sequels therefore complete the oeuvre's argument by unsettling it. They turn the tribunal inward, so that judgment is conducted among the natives themselves; they convert anthropodicy into theodicy, so that the creatures try their goddess; they deliver the ending Le Guin wrote and the first film withheld, in which the natives learn to kill one another with the colonizer's fire; they complete the elemental program in four clans; and they return, at the last, to the eschatology of the wreck, a reception of the living among the dead in a world below the visible one. The final chapter gathers these threads and turns to the descent Cameron has announced but not yet made, into the history of Hiroshima, where no nonhuman judge waits at the bottom.

9, 157 m
HADOPELAGIC

CHAPTER 09

DEPTH 9,257 M · HADOPELAGIC

9



CHAPTER 09

Conclusion

The Bathic Covenant

Let all the souls here rest in peace; for we shall not repeat the evil.

— Inscription on the Cenotaph for the A-bomb Victims, Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park (1952)

She sees the earth come up a second time out of the sea, green once more.

— *Völuspá* 59

CHAPTER 09 — CONCLUSION

This dissertation began at the surface of a critical settlement, where *bathos* names a failure, and has descended through the oeuvre film by film. Its conclusion rises, as the bathic schema does, not to the height from which the descent began but to a lower and more provisional resting place. The chapter reconsiders the schema across the whole corpus (§9.1), returns to spectacle as a *pharmakon* and to the spectator's place before the tribunal (§9.2), follows the movement from anthropodicy to theodicy and back (§9.3), reads Cameron's announced and suspended descent into the history of Hiroshima as a tribunal without a nonhuman judge (§9.4), and formulates the covenant and the ethics of descent toward which the films tend (§9.5).

9.1

The Schema Reconsidered

The six moments proposed in §1.5 recur in every film of the directed corpus. The table below records one reading of each film through the schema; its entries are interpretive judgments argued in the preceding chapters, not inventories of plot.

Read down its columns, the table discloses three regularities. The first concerns the geometry of the schema. In every film the covenant settles lower than the hubris it replaces: the ship stays on the sea floor, the colony is destroyed, the future is only unwritten rather than saved, and Pandora remains contested. The V-shape of Figure 1.1 is not a diagrammatic convenience but the form of the oeuvre's moral realism. Nothing is restored to its original height; what survives is humbler and more provisional than what fell.

The second regularity concerns the variants. The schema appears in its paradigmatic form in *The Abyss*, in a tragic key in *Titanic*, a comic key in *True Lies*, a broken key in *Aliens*, a recursive key in the *Terminator* films, and an inverted key in *Fire and Ash*. Its flexibility is the evidence that it is a grammar rather than a formula, a structure of thought capable of tragedy, farce, and self-critique, and not merely a commercial template. The column of kenosis also confirms the reservation recorded in §3.5. Self-emptying is never distributed equally. It falls on fathers, Kyle Reese and the T-800; on a lover, Jack; on a scientist, Grace; on a son, Neteyam; on a mother in childbirth, Ronal; on the only Black protagonist of

9, 357 m
HADOPELAGIC

THE SIX MOMENTS ACROSS THE DIRECTED CORPUS §9.1

FILM	Hypsos	Lapsus	Katabasis	Krisis	Kenōsis	Diathēkē
The Terminator *(1984)*	A defence network given control	Judgment Day	Two emissaries sent back in time	Skynet's verdict of extermination	Kyle Reese's death	The loop accepted
Aliens *(1986)*	The Marines and the Company	A colony gone silent	Ripley's descent into the hive	The Queen's truce, refused	Vasquez and Gorman; Bishop torn in half	Adoption, and permission to dream
The Abyss *(1989; 1993)*	A nuclear missile submarine	Its sinking	Bud's dive into the trench	The intelligences' judgment	The one-way descent	The wave withdrawn
Terminator 2 *(1991)*	Cyberdyne's research	Judgment Day foreseen	The asylum; the steel mill	Sarah before Dyson	Dyson; the T-800 in the steel	No fate
True Lies *(1994)*	The secret agent	A bomb on an empty island	Helen's initiation	The interrogation	The truth-serum confession	Remarriage
Titanic *(1997)*	The unsinkable ship	The iceberg	The sinking; the dive to the wreck	A night that judges conduct	Jack's death	A life lived; the gift returned
Avatar *(2009)*	The mining colony	Hometree felled	Jake into the avatar	Eywa takes sides	Grace's death; the human body left	Expulsion and transfer
The Way of Water *(2022)*	The colonists' return	The hunt; Neteyam's death	Into the reef	The tulkun's law	Neteyam	Kinship with the reef
Fire and Ash *(2025)*	Fire allied with the colony	The Mangkwan's apostasy	Into the spirit world	Eywa on trial	Ronal; Spider's near-death	The case reopened

Terminator 2; on a Latina soldier; and on the native dead of Pandora. A covenant purchased by sacrifice must be judged by who is asked to make it.

The third regularity is historical. Across four decades the identity of the judge changes, and with it the oeuvre's moral orientation. In *Aliens* the nonhuman is exterminated and its offered truce burned. In *The Abyss* the nonhuman judges humanity and shows mercy. In *Titanic* there is no judge but the indifferent sea and the conduct it discloses. In *Avatar* the nonhuman defends itself, and the camera stands on the other side of the fire it once celebrated (§4.6). In *Fire and Ash* the nonhuman judge is herself put on trial by her creatures. The judges grow less transcendent and more immanent, from an external machine to alien angels to a

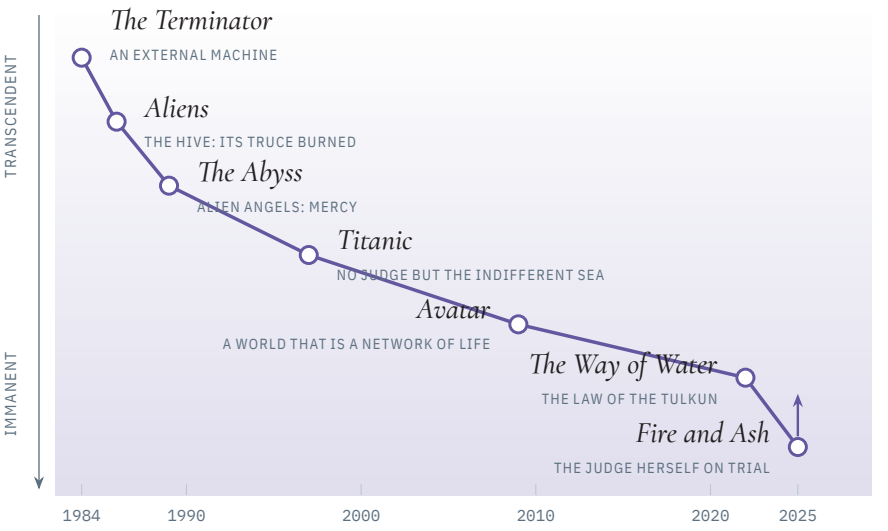


PLATE XV *The withdrawal of the tribunal*

Across four decades the judges grow less transcendent and more immanent, from an external machine to alien angels to a world that is itself a network of life, until the immanent judge's authority is questioned from within (§9.1).

world that is itself a network of life, until the immanent judge's authority is questioned from within. The oeuvre's development is the gradual withdrawal of the external tribunal, and the conclusion of this dissertation is that the withdrawal is the point.

The Empedoclean order traced in §1.6 has been completed along the way. Fire belongs to the *Terminator* films and returns in *Fire and Ash*; water to *The Abyss*, *Titanic*, and *The Way of Water*; earth to *Avatar*; air to the breath of Pandora that the colonists lack and that Eywa gives to Spider, and to the Wind Traders who cross its skies. In the *Avatar* cycle the four roots are distributed among four clans (§8.6), and Love and Strife alternate from film to film, so that the franchise is revealed as a cosmological form. Beneath its genres, Cameron's cinema is a theology of judgment in a secular key. Its narrative engine is the trial of the species, and its sentimental moments, the message typed at the bottom of a trench, the carving on a picnic table, the jewel returned to the sea, are the evidence entered in the species' defence. The bathos is testimony.

9,457 m
HADOPELAGIC

9.2

The Pharmakon Administered:
Spectatorship as Arraignment

The wager stated in §1.7 was that the apparatus which produces catastrophe is also the only apparatus capable of producing the imagination of catastrophe at the scale required to forestall it. Over four decades Cameron has pursued the apparatus side of the wager with unmatched consistency, from the optical compositing of the early films through the digital liquids of *The Abyss* and *Terminator 2* to the stereoscopy of *Avatar* and the underwater performance capture and partial high-frame-rate projection of *The Way of Water*. Each innovation has deepened the immersion of the spectator, who is placed, more completely with every film, in the position of Jake Sully in the link unit: a body left in the dark while perception lives elsewhere. Vivian Sobchack's phenomenology of film (§1.8) described spectatorship as an embodied exchange between two perceiving subjects, the viewer and the film; Cameron's apparatus has made the exchange as close to a borrowed body as the cinema has come.

The theorist who best articulates the moral side of the wager is Siegfried Kracauer. The epilogue of his *Theory of Film* (1960) retells the myth of Perseus, who could behead the Medusa only by looking at her reflection in the polished shield Athena gave him. The film screen, Kracauer argued, is Athena's shield. We cannot look directly at real horrors, which paralyze us with blinding fear, and we learn what they look like only from images that reproduce their true appearance; he was writing with the films of the liberated Nazi camps in mind. Cameron's cinema can be read as an extended practice of the shield: the nuclear dream at the playground fence, the fifteen hundred in the water, the harpooned tulkun and her circling calf, the felling of Hometree, and, in *Aliens*, the Medusa herself, the crested head of the monstrous mother (§4.2). The spectacle is the shield through which a society can look at what it has made, or may make, without being turned to stone.

The counter-arguments are as old as the wager, and this dissertation has not dismissed them. Susan Sontag's "The Imagination of Disaster" (1965) argued that science-fiction films offer the pleasures of an aesthetics of destruction, the spectacle of cities falling, and that they normalize what is psychologically unbearable, inuring their audiences to it rather than awakening them; her later *Regarding the Pain of Others* (2003) reopened the question whether images of suffering produce

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HADOPELAGIC

compassion or only its exhaustion. Guy Debord's analysis of the spectacle (§1.7) warned that every experience, revolt included, is converted by the spectacle into a commodity. And Anders himself, whose demand for a widened moral imagination this study has treated as the wager's charter, wrote in the same volume of *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) a sustained critique of broadcast images under the title "Die Welt als Phantom und Matrize," arguing that the screen delivers the world into the home as a phantom that pre-shapes experience, so that the viewer consumes a world without ever encountering it. Anders's demand that imagination be stretched to the scale of the bomb and his warning that the screen substitutes phantoms for encounters pull in opposite directions. Cameron's cinema lives inside that tension, and it cannot resolve it from within.

The films do, however, stage the tension, and their staging is the strongest evidence that the wager is made knowingly. Again and again they show spectators. In *Aliens* the lieutenant watches his soldiers die on the monitors of an armoured car, the spectator as remote commander. In *Titanic* the aged Rose watches a computer simulation of the sinking and answers that the experience was less clinical, the spectator as witness correcting the image. In *Avatar* a company technician watches the forest through a bulldozer's cameras until Jake smashes them, the spectator as colonist whose seeing is extraction. In the Special Edition of *The Abyss* the intelligences below watch humanity's own broadcasts of war, the spectator as judge. The films assign their audience each of these positions in turn, and their pedagogy consists in moving the viewer from the first and third, the remote commander and the extracting eye, toward the second and fourth, the witness and the judge. Spectatorship, in Cameron, is arraignment. The audience is charged, as the colonists are charged, and offered acquittal through identification with the defector, the advocate, and the witness: with Jake, with Bud, with Rose.

Whether the acquittal is earned is not something any film can decide for its viewers, but the record of the films' effects in the world is mixed in a way that neither the wager's advocates nor its critics predicted. The "*Avatar* blues" of 2010 (§1.7) showed images capable of making the existing world briefly intolerable to those who returned from Pandora. The protesters of Bil'in and the advocates for the Dongria Kondh (§7.3) showed images capable of being turned against the very powers that produced them. The ubiquity of the Terminator's skull in reporting on artificial intelligence (§3.7) showed images capable of sustaining a public conversation about risk and of distorting it at once. And Cameron's own explanation of the *Titan* disaster through the precedent of the *Titanic* (§6.2) showed a filmmaker's images becoming the framework through which a real catastrophe

9,557m
HADOPELAGIC

was understood. The *pharmakon* has worked as remedy and as poison, often simultaneously, and Stiegler's insistence that no technics can be simply affirmed or refused applies to cinema with full force.

The dissertation's judgment on the wager is therefore not a verdict but a description of a practice. The wager is renewed with every film and every viewing, and its success depends less on the apparatus than on what the spectator carries out of the theatre. Kracauer's shield allows Perseus to look; it does not decide what he will do with what he sees. Cameron's cinema has built the most powerful shields in the history of the medium, and it has used them, consistently, to show its audiences the faces of what they have wounded. The rest of the covenant is not on the screen.

9.3

From Anthropodicy to Theodicy and Back

The trajectory traced in §9.1 culminates in the reversal of *Fire and Ash*, in which the creatures arraign their goddess, and the reversal reveals something about all the judges that preceded it. The nonhuman judges of the oeuvre were, in Lem's sense (§1.4, §5.4), mirrors. Their verdicts expressed the values of the films' protagonists, fidelity, family, and the prohibition of killing, and Bruce Lincoln's definition of myth as ideology in narrative form (§1.8) applies to them exactly. The non-terrestrial intelligences spare humanity for a husband's love; Eywa sides with the people who honour kinship; the tulkun keep the law the films most admire. When the goddess is put on trial, the mirror cracks. The judge is shown to be partial, since she saves some peoples and not others; silent, to the Mangkwan in their catastrophe and to Kiri for most of the third film; and indifferent, since she protects the balance rather than the lives within it. The theodicy exposes the projection that had sustained the anthropodicy.

The movement does not end there, and the second half of this section's title names its return. If the nonhuman judge cannot be justified, the burden of judgment comes back to the creatures. Rousseau's reply to Voltaire (§8.5) had already pointed the way when it argued that much of what is called natural evil is human, the consequence of how people build and how they live. Plato's spokesman of the Fates (§7.8) had said that the blame belongs to the one who chooses. The theodicy collapses back into an anthropodicy, but now without an external tribunal: the species must justify itself before itself. This is the movement the oeuvre traces

9,607 m
HADOPELAGIC

across four decades, from Skynet's verdict to Varang's charge, in which the seat of judgment moves from outside the human to within it. The external tribunal, on this reading, was always a dramatic device for an internal capacity, the capacity to see one's own species from below, as the deep might see it. The bathic perspective is finally an ethical stance: to regard what humanity has made from the position of what it has wounded.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) begins with the launch of Sputnik in October 1957 and with a remark, which she found in the press, that the event was a first step toward escape from humanity's imprisonment on the earth. Arendt answered that the earth is the very quintessence of the human condition. *Avatar*'s colonists have made that escape from a world they destroyed, and the films' judgment falls on the flight: the dying Earth is the colonists' original fault, and their expulsion returns them to it. Arendt's book also supplies the concepts with which a covenant can be thought once the nonhuman judge has withdrawn. In its final reflections on action she identified two faculties that redeem human action from its predicaments. Forgiving releases agents from the irreversibility of what they have done; promising binds the unpredictability of what they will do, setting up islands of security in the ocean of uncertainty that the future is. She credited Jesus of Nazareth with discovering the role of forgiveness in human affairs, and she traced the power of promise to the covenant tradition that begins with Abraham.

The bathic covenant contains both faculties. The withdrawn wave of *The Abyss* is forgiveness, the species released from the verdict its record had earned. The words carved into a picnic table in *Terminator 2* are promise, the future bound to remain open. In the films both faculties are exercised by nonhuman powers or by heroes in extremity; in Arendt they are ordinary human capacities, available to anyone who acts together with others. The movement from anthropodicy to theodicy and back is, in this light, the transfer of the covenant from the nonhuman judges who first granted it to the human beings who must now make and keep it. The deep no longer forgives on our behalf; we must forgive. The deep no longer promises on our behalf; we must promise.

The transfer also reverses the direction of recognition. Levinas's dog Bobby (§5.4), the last Kantian in Nazi Germany, recognized the prisoners as human when their guards would not, and the nonhuman recognitions of Cameron's cinema, from the pseudopod's mirrored faces to Eywa's hearing of Jake's prayer, are elaborations of Bobby's greeting: the hope that what is other than human might see us as we ought to be seen. The return to anthropodicy asks for more. It is not enough to wait for the nonhuman to see us. The obligation is to see the non-

9,657 m
HADOPELAGIC

human: the tulkun as persons, the forest as a Thou in Buber's sense (§7.6), the deep as a sanctuary rather than a deposit. The Na'vi greeting that the films made famous is, read this way, not a reward the colonizer receives but a duty the species owes. Recognition becomes an obligation rather than an acquittal.

The late films already carry this transfer within them. The tribunal has moved inside the family and the people: the Sullys deliberate whether a human child can be kept without endangering a world; the clans of Pandora judge one another; Lo'ak judges himself for his brother's death. The cycle's most hopeful image so far, two hostile fathers pulling the same boy back from a fall (§8.3), is a judgment rendered by human minds in Na'vi bodies, without the goddess's intervention. If there is a covenant left to strike, it will be struck there, among the living, at the edge of the fall.

9.4

Ghosts of Hiroshima: *The Tribunal Without a Judge*

In 2024 Cameron acquired the rights to Charles Pellegrino's *Ghosts of Hiroshima*, published in August 2025 for the eightieth anniversary of the bombings and built from years of forensic archaeology and interviews with more than two hundred survivors and their families, together with Pellegrino's earlier *Last Train from Hiroshima* (2010; revised 2015). Cameron has written a screenplay focused, by his own account, on the day of the two bombings and their immediate aftermath. He has said that he intends to do for Hiroshima and Nagasaki what Steven Spielberg did for the Holocaust and for D-Day, showing the events as they happened without sparing the audience; that the film might earn less than any he has made; that it might be the most challenging film of his career; and that Christopher Nolan's *Oppenheimer* (2023) was a "moral cop-out" for keeping the aftermath of the bombings off the screen. In December 2025 he acknowledged that the project had a script but neither a production slot nor a distributor. As of his most recent public statements it remains unmade, and this section reads it in its suspension, as the descent the oeuvre has announced but not yet undertaken.

9,707 m
HADOPELAGIC

The oeuvre leads here. The bomb appears in every decade of Cameron's work: in the future war of *The Terminator* (1984), the thermonuclear destruction of the colony in *Aliens* (1986), the warhead at the bottom of the trench in *The Abyss* (1989), the playground in *Terminator 2* (1991), and the mushroom cloud behind a

kiss in *True Lies* (1994). *Titanic* (1997) is the pre-nuclear archetype of the integral accident, and *Avatar* (2009) is set in motion by an energy economy that has exhausted a world. Behind all of these stands the childhood conjunction described in §2.1, a family living near a power station in October 1962 and reckoning with the possibility of becoming a target. Hiroshima is the origin of the nuclear *lapsus* that the oeuvre has restaged in fiction for forty years, and a film about it would be the oeuvre's return to its source.

Its protagonist would be Tsutomu Yamaguchi (1916–2010), an engineer for Mitsubishi Heavy Industries who was in Hiroshima on business on 6 August 1945, some three kilometres from the hypocentre. Burned and partly deafened, he made his way home to Nagasaki, and on 9 August, as he was describing the Hiroshima explosion to his supervisor, the second bomb fell. In 2009 the Japanese government formally recognized him as a survivor of both bombings, the only person to receive that recognition, although perhaps a hundred and sixty people are believed to have endured both. In his last years he spoke publicly against nuclear weapons. Cameron and Pellegrino visited him in hospital days before his death in January 2010, and Cameron has described the meeting as Yamaguchi "handing the baton of his personal story to us." The double survivor is the oeuvre's loop made historical: a man who escaped one catastrophe only to travel into the next, the recursive schema of *The Terminator* lived in fact. And like Er (§7.8) and Rose (§6.5), he came back from the dead to testify.

Pellegrino's book also follows a witness from above. Jacob Beser, a radar countermeasures officer, was the only man to fly on both atomic missions, aboard the aircraft that bombed Hiroshima and the one that bombed Nagasaki. Between the double witness in the sky and the double survivor on the ground runs the vertical axis of the nuclear age: fire sent down from the height, received at the bottom. The bathic cosmology of §1.4 here meets its historical origin. The Olympian curse descending from the sky (§7.1) is no longer a figure; it is a bomb released at thirty thousand feet.

In every Cameron fiction a nonhuman judge waits at the bottom: Skynet, the Queen, the intelligences of the trench, the indifferent sea, Eywa. At Hiroshima nothing waited. No intelligence stayed the wave of fire, no machine-father descended into the flames, and no goddess intervened. The *krisis* of the bathic schema has here no judge, only the dead, the survivors, and those willing to hear them. If the film is made, it will be the oeuvre's first without a nonhuman tribunal, and its covenant will have to be struck among human beings alone. That is why its suspension is significant, and why the director who has staged every other catastrophe with confidence has spoken of this one as the hardest. The bathic

9, 757 m
HADOPELAGIC

method of affective downscaling, which brought nuclear war down to the scale of a mother at a playground fence, would here be applied not to a fiction but to some of the most extensively documented deaths of the twentieth century.

The human tribunals that Hiroshima has received are partial, contested, and mostly without force, and they are worth recalling because they are the only tribunals there are. The bombings were not among the charges at the International Military Tribunal for the Far East, but the Indian jurist Radhabinod Pal, in his dissenting judgment of 1948, condemned them as indiscriminate destruction. In 1963, in the Shimoda case, the Tokyo District Court held that the bombings had violated international law, while dismissing the survivors' claims for damages. In 1996 the International Court of Justice advised that the threat or use of nuclear weapons would generally be contrary to the law of armed conflict, while declining to decide the extreme case of a state's survival. The Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons was adopted in 2017 and entered into force in 2021, without the participation of any nuclear-armed state. And in 2024 the Nobel Peace Prize was awarded to Nihon Hidankyo, the confederation of survivors' organizations, for its efforts toward a world free of nuclear weapons and for demonstrating through the testimony of witnesses that such weapons must never be used again. The strongest instrument of the human tribunal has been testimony, the instrument Rose wields in *Titanic* and Yamaguchi wielded at the end of his life.

The question of method is the one §2.7 posed between John Hersey and Alain Resnais. Hersey told the bombing through six lives; Resnais's film insisted that the visitor had seen nothing in Hiroshima, and that every image of it is a kind of forgetting. Cameron's stated method is Hersey's, and Kracauer's shield (§9.2) is its theoretical warrant: one can look at the horror only in its reflection, but one can look. Günther Anders, who travelled to Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1958 and later titled a book *Hiroshima ist überall* (1982), Hiroshima is everywhere, proposed in his "Gebote des Atomzeitalters" (1957) that one's first thought on waking each day should be of the bomb. A film made in that spirit would not be another spectacle of destruction but an exercise in that daily remembering.

The covenant that Hiroshima has already produced is inscribed in stone. The cenotaph in the Peace Memorial Park, unveiled on 6 August 1952, bears a Japanese sentence usually translated as "Let all the souls here rest in peace; for we shall not repeat the evil." The original, as Japanese permits, names no subject: it does not say who promises. Its author, the scholar Saika Tadayoshi, held that the promise belonged to all humankind, and the absence of a named subject has been debated ever since. The indeterminacy is the covenant's meaning. It is a promise made to the dead by whoever reads it, without a god to witness it or a nonhuman judge

9,807 m
HADOPELAGIC

to enforce it, at the site of the first nuclear *lapsus*. Forty years of tribunals of the nonhuman lead, if Cameron completes the descent, to this stone. They lead there in any case for the audience, which lives in what Christa Wolf called the *Vorkrieg*, the time before a war (§3.3). In January 2025 the *Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists* set its Doomsday Clock at eighty-nine seconds to midnight, the closest it had ever stood.

9.5

Limits of the Study and Further Descents

Every descent has a floor, and a dissertation should mark its own. The first limit is authorial. This study has attributed to the signature "Cameron" a coherence that is, by its own account (§1.2), a hypothesis about industrial artefacts made by large and continuous collaborations: producers, co-writers, designers, effects artists, composers, and performers whose contributions an author-centred reading inevitably underweights. Production studies in the manner of John Caldwell's *Production Culture* (2008), which examines how film workers themselves theorize their practice, would test the coherence posited here against the actual distribution of decisions across the films' making, and might find that some of what this study has called the oeuvre's thought belongs to its workshop.

The second limit concerns method. The dissertation has relied heavily on what §1.2 called interpretive constellations, comparisons with Empedocles, Hölderlin, Wagner, the *Völuspá*, and the Samudra Manthan that claim no causal relation to the films but illuminate structures they share. Their abundance carries the risk that Bruce Lincoln named in the remark this study adopted as a self-description, that scholarship is myth with footnotes (§1.8). Readers should weigh these comparisons as hypotheses about structure rather than findings about intention, and the strength of the argument should be judged chiefly by the documented derivations and the close readings, not by the number of resonances it can assemble.

The third limit is cultural position. The study's archive is predominantly European and Anglo-American, and the Indian, Chinese, Japanese, Māori, and Native American materials it invokes have been read largely through European scholarship. The films' Indigenous and non-Western audiences, whose responses complicated its readings at several points (§7.3, §8.1), deserve study in their own terms

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and voices. Barry Barclay's account of a Fourth Cinema (2003), made by Indigenous filmmakers from within their own cultures, and Michelle Raheja's concept of visual sovereignty in *Reservation Reelism* (2010) offer frameworks from which the *Avatar* cycle would appear not as a meditation on indigeneity but as an outsider's image of it, to be answered by images made from inside.

The fourth limit is empirical. The claims about spectatorship advanced in §9.2 rest on reported episodes, the *Avatar* blues, the protests at Bil'in, the rhetoric of policy debates, rather than on systematic research into audiences. Reception studies, particularly in China, India, and Latin America, where the films found some of their largest audiences, would test the wager this study has described and might find that its terms, which are drawn from European philosophy of technology, do not describe what viewers there saw.

The fifth limit is temporal. The corpus is unfinished: further *Avatar* films have been announced, the Hiroshima project is suspended, and a new *Terminator* story has been discussed. The conclusions of this chapter about the turn to theodicy and the tribunal without a judge are predictions as well as readings, and the films may refute them. That is appropriate for a study whose subject is enlightened doomsaying (§3.4). A reading of prophecy should accept that its own forecasts are offered in order to be tested, and it would be no failure of the argument if the films it anticipates turned out otherwise.

Several further descents suggest themselves. A comparative study of planetary-intelligence narratives across media, from Lem's *Solaris* and Miyazaki's *Nausicaä* to Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014) and Alex Garland's film of it (2018), with its mutating zone of alien ecology, and *Horizon Zero Dawn* (§7.7), could place the symmetry of Skynet and Eywa within a wider history of imagined planetary minds. A study of the *Terminator* films as policy imagination could trace how a fiction has shaped the vocabulary in which governments discuss autonomous weapons and the control of nuclear arsenals (§3.7). An ecocritical study of Cameron's oceanography could follow the bathic cosmology into the present controversy over mining the deep-sea floor (§7.5). A disability-studies reading of the avatar beyond the cure narrative could ask what the films would look like if Jake's human body were not left behind (§7.2). And a theology of the franchise could examine the serial covenant, the narrative form in which every settlement is provisional, as a distinctive contribution of commercial cinema to the long history of thinking about promise and judgment.

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9.6

The Bathic Covenant:
Toward an Ethics of Descent

The five propositions with which this dissertation began (§1.1) can now be restated as conclusions. Descent is the master operation of Cameron's cinema, active at once in the diegetic, rhetorical, and theological registers, from the sphere of light in which the first Terminator arrives to the spirit world in which *Fire and Ash* ends. These descents compose a bathic cosmology in which the sacred lies below, in the trench, the wreck, the root, the reef, and the network of the dead; the cosmology is affirmed in the fictions, tested by the silent floor of the Challenger Deep, and contested from within by the Ash People. Its narrative form is the tribunal of the nonhuman, a grammar of six moments capable of tragedy, farce, and self-critique, which moves across four decades from the extermination of the nonhuman to its judgment of humanity, then to its own trial, and finally toward a tribunal without any nonhuman judge. Its spectacle is governed by Love and Strife, distributed across the four elements and expressed in the cyclical seriality of its franchises. And its apparatus is a *pharmakon*, a shield through which a society can look at what it has made, renewed with each film and decided by none of them alone.

From these findings the dissertation draws the concept named in its subtitle. The bathic covenant is the provisional settlement in which Cameron's narratives come to rest, and its features can now be specified. It is secular, since no transcendent guarantor stands behind it and its judges are immanent in the world or absent from it. It is revocable: each sequel reopens the case, no salvation is final, and the future is only ever unwritten. It is planetary, since its party is the species and the world rather than a nation or a people. It is struck in descent, at the bottom of a fall and never at the height of power. It is mediated by the smallest unit of love, the couple, the family, the single act of self-surrender, in accordance with the affective downscaling that critics have called bathos. It is sealed with bathetic tokens: a line of text on a wrist keypad, two words cut into a picnic table, a jewel let fall into the sea, a greeting, a breath. It is witnessed by testimony, by those who went down and came back to tell. And its terms are recognition rather than dominion.

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From the covenant follows an ethics, which the films do not state as doctrine but enact as narrative, and which can be set out in seven precepts. The first is to

descend to the scale of the single life: to translate magnitudes beyond imagination into the one magnitude that can be felt, as Hersey did with Hiroshima and as the films do with every catastrophe they stage, without forgetting the magnitude that has been translated. The second is to let what lies below look back, accepting the reversal of Nietzsche's warning in which the gaze of the abyss confers recognition rather than contamination, and answering that gaze with the acknowledgment that Levinas called ethics and the Na'vi call seeing. The third is to return rather than extract, treating the deep as a sanctuary rather than a deposit, as Rose treats the wreck and the Omaticaya the forest, at a moment when the sea floor itself is being surveyed for minerals. The fourth is to leave some things unbuilt, in the line that runs from Victor Frankenstein tearing apart his unfinished creature to Joseph Rotblat leaving the Manhattan Project and Miles Dyson destroying his own laboratory. The fifth is to hold catastrophe as fate in order to refuse it, as Anders's Noah, Jonas's heuristics of fear, and Dupuy's projected time all counsel: to mourn the dead of a flood that has not happened so that it will not. The sixth is to make kin across kinds, as Ripley does with an orphan and an android, as the Sullys do with a daughter of no known father and a human foundling, and as Haraway urged when she asked her readers to make kin rather than babies. The seventh is to keep the tribunal open and the covenant revocable: to promise and to forgive, in Arendt's sense, without waiting for a nonhuman power to do either on our behalf.

The ethics of descent is not an ethics of renouncing technology, and Cameron's cinema has never been that. Its paradox, the use of the most powerful apparatus of illusion to warn against the hubris of apparatus, is the form the covenant takes in practice. Hölderlin's lines, with which Heidegger closed his inquiry into technology (§1.7), state the wager in its oldest form: where danger is, the saving power also grows. The films build their shields from the same technics that forges the weapons, and they hold them up so that their audiences can look at the faces of what they have wounded. The covenant cannot be completed on the screen. It is completed, if at all, by those who leave the theatre.

Alexander Pope mocked the poets who sank when they meant to soar, and proposed, as a joke, that the taste for bathos is implanted in human nature while the taste for the sublime is a perversion of custom. This dissertation has taken the joke seriously because Cameron's cinema does. Its heroine cries that she is flying from the bow of a ship bound for the bottom, and the film does not mock her. It shows that the height and the depth are a single movement, and that what waits at the bottom, for those who have kept faith with the people they love and the world they have harmed, is not the void Nietzsche feared but a face, looking back.

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The seeress of the *Völuspá* saw the earth sink into the sea and rise again, green. Cameron's films have not yet shown that rising, and they are honest enough to leave it unshown. What they show, again and again, is the place where it would have to begin. The art of sinking, in the end, is the art of being seen from below, and of learning to deserve it.



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The Terminator. 1984. Written by James Cameron and Gale Anne Hurd. Hemdale; Orion Pictures.
Aliens. 1986. Screenplay by James Cameron; story by James Cameron, David Giler, and Walter Hill. Twentieth Century Fox. Special Edition, 1991.
The Abyss. 1989. Written by James Cameron. Twentieth Century Fox. Special Edition, 1993.
Terminator 2: Judgment Day. 1991. Written by James Cameron and William Wisher. Carolco Pictures; TriStar Pictures. Special Edition, 1993.
True Lies. 1994. Screenplay by James Cameron, based on *La Totale!* (1991). Twentieth Century Fox; Lightstorm Entertainment.
Titanic. 1997. Written by James Cameron. Twentieth Century Fox; Paramount Pictures; Lightstorm Entertainment.
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Strange Days. 1995. Directed by Kathryn Bigelow. Screenplay by James Cameron and Jay Cocks; story by James Cameron.

Dark Angel. 2000–2002. Television series created by James Cameron and Charles H. Eglee. Fox.

Expedition: Bismarck. 2002. Television documentary. Discovery Channel.

Solaris. 2002. Directed by Steven Soderbergh. Produced by James Cameron, Jon Landau, and Rae Sanchini.

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Alien. 1979. Directed by Ridley Scott.

Annihilation. 2018. Directed by Alex Garland.

Apocalypse Now. 1979. Directed by Francis Ford Coppola.

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Colossus: The Forbin Project. 1970. Directed by Joseph Sargent.

Dances with Wolves. 1990. Directed by Kevin Costner.

The Day After. 1983. Directed by Nicholas Meyer. ABC.

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KEYWORDS

Keywords

anthropodicy ; *avatāra* ; Bachelard, Gaston ; bathic cosmology ; bathic covenant ; bathos ; Cameron, James ; catastrophism, enlightened ; comedy of remarriage ; comparative mythology ; cyborg ; death drive ; ecocriticism ; Empedocles ; Eywa ; film-philosophy ; flood myth ; Gaia hypothesis ; *Gestell* ; going-native narrative ; Hiroshima ; *katabasis* ; *kenōsis* ; Love and Strife ; material imagination ; melodrama of the unknown woman ; monstrous-feminine ; narrative prosthesis ; nuclear criticism ; oceanic feeling ; Pandora ; performance capture ; pharmacology of technics ; *pharmakon* ; posthumanism ; Promethean gap ; science-fiction megatext ; settler colonialism ; Skynet ; spectacle ; stereoscopic cinema ; sublime ; superintelligence ; tehomic theology ; theodicy ; tribunal of the nonhuman ; white-saviour narrative

10, 858 m

HADOPELAGIC


CHALLENGER DEEP · MARIANA TRENCH
10,908 m